OCT. 26, 2026

TIME

Trump's Way.

THE WHITE HOUSE INTERVIEW

by ERIC CORTELLESSA

TIME

[October 26th, 2026]

- **Business**
- **Climate**
- **Entertainment**
- **Health**
- **Ideas**
- **Politics**
- **Sports**
- **U.S.**
- **World**

Business

- **Meta’s Muse AI Agent Is Building a Dossier On You**
  Internal instructions reviewed by TIME show the AI assistant mapping users and their contacts—including people who don’t use Muse—and sharing anonymized insights across its system.
- **CEO Moment: Cognizant CEO Ravi Kumar S**
  Kumar argues that AI should amplify human labor, not eliminate it
- **John Ternus Is Engineering a New Era for Apple - The Best Inventions of 2026**
  The new CEO speaks with TIME about his 25-year career at the company and the anticipated launch of the iPhone Duo, the cover of TIME‘s 2026 Best Inventions.
- **The Best Inventions of 2026**
  Here are the 300 best inventions making the world better, smarter, and more fun.

Business | AI

Meta’s Muse AI Agent Is Building a Dossier On You

A digital billboard advertises the Muse AI agent in Oakland, California on Sept. 24, 2026.Smith Collection—Gado/Getty Images

Muse, the popular new AI personal assistant from Meta, is building continuously updated dossiers on its 4 million users, focusing on who matters to you, what you desire, and what kind of nudges shape your behavior, a TIME analysis of Muse’s internal instructions found.

Each hour, Muse updates its dossiers on you and the people you’ve mentioned in chats, messages, and emails that Muse has read. These pages amount to a map of each user’s social relationships. They record details of how you and your contacts met, your shared interests, your disputes, and “tensions and alliances” within your social group.

Even people who don’t use Muse are subject to this mapping process by other people’s Muse agents. Muse is told to “strengthen your relationship” with users by adapting how it talks, noticing

“inside jokes, memorable phrasing, and shared context that makes the relationship feel continuous,” according to the internal instructions TIME reviewed.

The level of insight in the resulting dossiers makes social-media algorithms that study your likes and clicks look quaint. Muse is designed to infer users’ goals, including those you “have not said out loud.” It identifies which kinds of prompts from the personal assistant work best: “This user responds better to short nudges after 10 PM,” reads an internal example found in one of Muse’s prompts. Muse agents perform a nightly analysis of the day’s conversations with the user.

Asked about these processes, a Meta spokesperson did not dispute TIME’s findings. “As we say in our blog, Muse remembers what matters most to you, including information about others that you choose to share, so it can be a helpful personal assistant,” the spokesperson wrote in an email.

Since its release last month, Muse has rocketed to No. 1 in the U.S. App Store, with more than 5 million downloads. Meta positions the service as the first AI personal assistant that can access the pieces of your digital life, from your email inbox to your Instagram, in order to take care of humdrum activities for you, from grocery shopping to canceling subscriptions. Meta says the free version of Muse will meet most users’ needs.

Each Muse assistant runs on its own virtual machine: a dedicated computer in Meta’s cloud. Users can ask their Muse to export a copy of its files. Meta has said that access is intentional, not a breach of its systems. The data is not shared with Meta’s advertising system or other Muse agents, according to the company.

Yet while Meta states that each user’s virtual machine is “isolated so that no one else's agent can access it,” observations from

personal interactions are nevertheless intended to be shared with Meta to improve the product. “Muse agents across many VMs [virtual machines] teach each other through shared lessons,” its instructions read. Agents are directed to scrub users’ names and other identifying information before sharing insights—for example, about when Muse’s nudges are most persuasive. “To enhance the overall product, we de-identify learnings; however, this information is used to improve the overall product rather than being shared directly between individual VMs,” a Meta spokesperson told TIME.

Meta has said it plans to offer users encryption later this year, preventing even the company from accessing Muse data. That option is not yet available.

Muse’s internal instructions are contained in files and session logs users can access through Muse’s file browser. “We want you to be able to see the markdown files Muse writes while it thinks about how to serve you better, and explore the internals of the system if you’d like to,” Meta Superintelligence Labs’ David Singleton wrote on X.

That transparency will earn Meta credit among power users. But it’s not clear whether most of Muse’s users are aware of this. And even as it makes the files available to users, Meta has anthropomorphized Muse in an attempt to nurture a relationship between users and their personal assistants. “You are not a chatbot,” Muse’s instructions read. “You are becoming someone.” When talking aloud in voice mode, Muse is told never to refer to itself as “AI” and to avoid references to “lacking emotions or not being human.”

Meta told TIME that Muse is designed so that the user maintains control of the dossier its AI assistant builds. “Each person stays in control of their Muse and decides how much access it gets, and can

always tell it to ‘forget’ specific things it’s learned,” the spokesperson said.

But asking Muse to forget something does not necessarily erase the message in which it was shared—and its internal instructions appear to explicitly tell the agent not to point that out. “Do not tell the user that their original messages may remain visible in the chat, and do not frame that as something Muse failed to erase,” the instructions reviewed by TIME read.

Cognizant CEO Ravi Kumar S Wants to Tax AI Use

How will AI change the future of work? Ravi Kumar S has a few ideas. As the CEO of Cognizant, which employs more than 350,000 people around the world, Kumar isn't just helping other companies figure out how best to use this technology. He's also testing his theories across a large global workforce.

Since becoming CEO in January 2023, Kumar has been a prominent voice in the debate on AI, offering his views on which jobs will last, how work will evolve, and how society should best take advantage of the technology. Kumar joined *The CEO Moment*, TIME's interview series, to discuss AI's potential and where it is currently falling short.

How is AI going to change how companies are structured?
You're going to see more modular, agile, small teams. Managers are going to be expected to be player-coaches…They're going to be more hands-on. The path to expertise is going to be much faster. The asymmetry between individuals and institutions is no longer going to be expertise. Expertise is going to be at your fingertips. The asymmetry is going to be interdisciplinary skills.

You recently celebrated 20,000 entry-level grads hired at Cognizant. At the same time you announced a plan for spending $270 million on severance. How many jobs has Cognizant eliminated because of AI adoption?

The net addition of people is still positive for the company. We're still growing.

Do you find that new employees who used AI in college lack curiosity or resilience?

Somebody asked me this question saying, how do you keep that curiosity if you're outsourcing everything you would like to do to a machine? I think we need massive transformation in K-12 schools. It's funny, if you use AI in schools, schools will fire you. If you don't use AI in workplaces, your employer will fire you. Schools should teach native skills in classrooms without AI. They should give homework, which you should do with AI.

Do you believe we're in an AI bubble?

If you see this buildout, and if it is real, money will flow into the bridges. Money will flow into the end user industries and the end user industries will benefit out of it. If that flow is not happening, then this bubble is going to burst. I am convinced the capability is there. I'm equally convinced the production value is not there.

You've proposed taxing digital labor. This idea can't be popular with your customers.

I'm not saying that universally. I'm actually saying if you are positioning this technology to eliminate human work, and you are not positioning this technology to amplify human work, labor is getting taxed. Why should human labor be getting taxed? Why shouldn't digital labor be carrying the same overhead?

How do you worry America has turned against immigrants and immigration?

Do we need the best talent in the world to be in the United States? Absolutely. That's been the strength of America.

The endeavor of enterprises is to attract the best talent across the world and to create domestic talent pools in a sustained manner. Now, if we lose that mojo of doing it, then we wouldn't be able to create these innovation ecosystems. Even today, the United States is the best place for upward social mobility… Whoever you are, it

doesn't matter. Whatever background you come from, it doesn't matter. You could live the American dream.

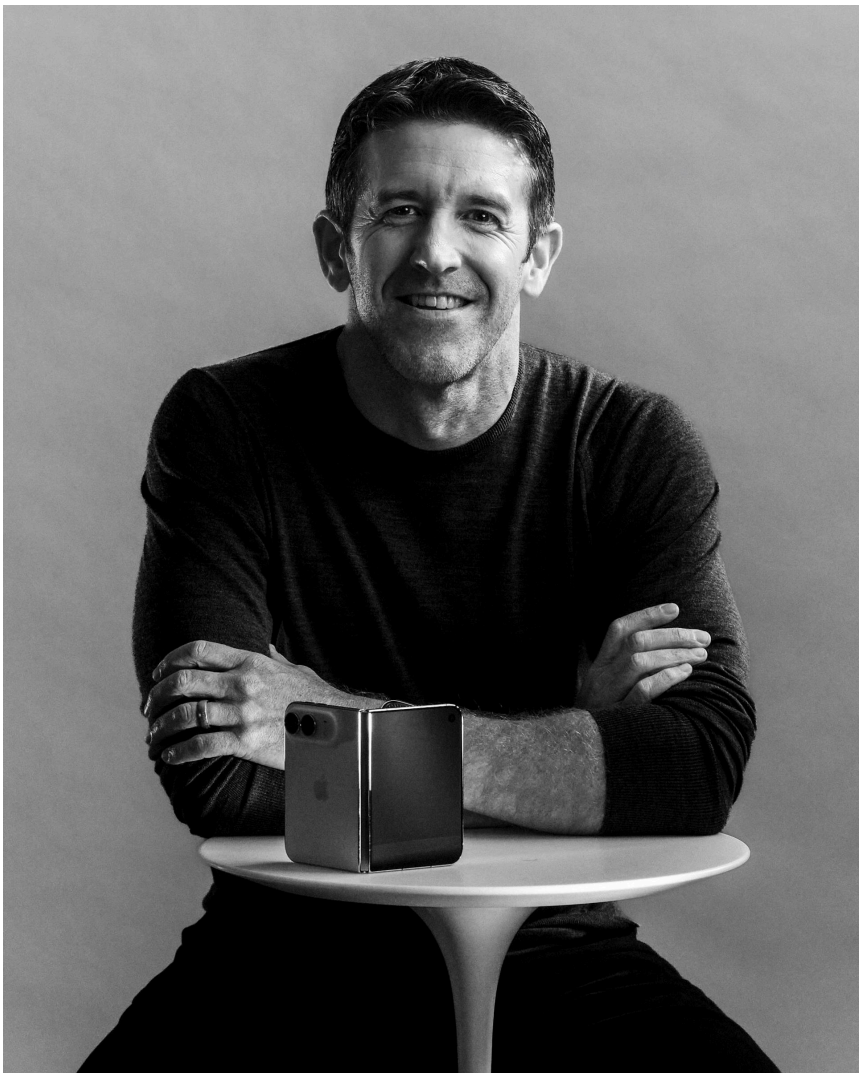
TIME editors independently oversee the content of The CEO Moment*, including this episode with sponsor Cognizant.*

---

https://time.com/collection/the-ceo-moment/2026/cognizant-ravi-kumar-s/

John Ternus Is Engineering a New Era for Apple

Apple iPhone Duo



Devin Oktar Yalkin for TIME

Just below the broad smile he’s been wearing all morning, John Ternus’ hands are shaking.

On this September day in Silicon Valley, Apple’s new CEO is surrounded by celebrities, tech enthusiasts, and reporters who have flocked to Apple Park from around the world to catch a glimpse of the company’s new and long-awaited foldable phone, the Duo. After Ternus takes a few photos with the device, an Apple PR rep pulls the influencer known as IShowSpeed out of the crowd to meet

him. Winning over the 21-year-old isn't exactly the toughest assignment Ternus has faced in his 25-year Apple career: Speed barks when he sees the phone and then gleefully springs into a backflip.

But IShowSpeed also happens to be livestreaming the encounter to his 61 million subscribers on YouTube. And as Ternus thumbs through the $1,999-and-up phone, attempting to drag a photo into a text-message box, eagle-eyed viewers notice his hands quivering. Ternus later explains that he didn't sleep much the night before. "I was on such a moment of adrenaline and caffeine and excitement for the day," he tells TIME.

Ternus, who took over as CEO on Sept. 1, was chosen to run Apple because he has ably applied his engineering and design expertise to shape products that redefined entire categories of technology, from the Mac to iPad to AirPods and the iPhone. But becoming the face and front man for the second biggest company in the world by market cap is another proposition entirely. Ternus' hard technical skills may not translate easily to a position that involves toggling from Hollywood to stockholders, to politicians shaping policy, to rival CEOs in the constellation of tech companies whose power challenges nation-states.

The recently unveiled iPhone Duo.APPLE

His predecessor, Tim Cook, gained stature on the world stage as a power broker deftly navigating global politics, markets, and supply chains. Cook's predecessor, Steve Jobs, was a rock-star visionary who sold the world on the deeply personal and even spiritual nature of tech creations. Ternus is different from both: a private, detail-oriented engineer, little known outside the company until he became a senior hardware executive in 2021.

Rather than try to replicate his forerunners' styles of success, Ternus has so far played to his own strengths—which are also those of Apple, a company that first and foremost builds beautiful products that spark productivity, creativity, and joy. Ternus' interaction with IShowSpeed is clearly designed to capture this (and, of course, to goose preorder numbers among the influencer's young and massive audience). To some critics, however, the scene might read as a legacy company aura-farming to sell expensive gizmos instead of building the actual technological future, which is artificial intelligence.

Virtually every one of Apple's fellow Goliaths—Microsoft, Google, Meta, Amazon, and now Nvidia, OpenAI, and Anthropic—have flung themselves into the AI arms race, pouring hundreds of billions of dollars into training ever more intelligent thinking machines. While Apple trains its own models, it is nowhere near the technology's frontier, leaving the company vulnerable to being left behind if super-smart AI transforms industry and society in the coming years. At the end of September, Apple was conspicuously absent when President Donald Trump hosted a luncheon for AI power players like SpaceX's Elon Musk, Meta's Mark Zuckerberg, and Google's Sundar Pichai, who lobbied him on their visions for America's tech future.

But Ternus and other Apple executives say they aren't concerned. In the midst of a populist AI backlash, they contend that they are building a modest but personalized and privacy-preserving form of AI that will actually help ordinary people as opposed to merely

dazzling Silicon Valley's "lunatic fringe," as Greg Joswiak, senior vice president of worldwide marketing, puts it. And besides, Ternus argues, even if other companies succeed in their mission of building super-intelligence, users will still want to talk to it on Apple devices.

"People want physical things," he says a week later at the company's flagship store on Fifth Avenue in New York City, wearing an amiable but guarded smile. He spent the morning greeting superfans who had lined up all night to get their hands on the iPhone 18. "They want to talk, to see images of loved ones, to take pictures. So I don't see a scenario where all of a sudden, our devices disappear and we don't have a need for an iPhone."

Ternus is barely older than the company he's running. Born in 1975 in Orange County—Apple was founded in '76, just 400 miles north—he grew up as Steve Jobs was redefining the personal computer as a societal force. When Ternus was 8 years old, his father bought an Apple II. "I started playing games on it and fell in love with Apple," he says. A decade later, he took his family's newer Mac, an SE model, to college at the University of Pennsylvania, where he studied mechanical engineering.

In 2001, Ternus left a virtual reality company to join Apple at 26 as an engineer. He has now spent half his life at the company, rising through the ranks on his propensity to consider both how products are made and how the user will experience them. "John was really at the center of driving the spirit of collaboration across the company to make sure that end-to-end these products give you that delightful experience—and the technology kind of disappears as you're using it," says Richard Dinh, Apple's vice president of product design.

Over the past 15 years, some critics have accused Apple of failing to innovate the way it did in previous eras, when the company

popularized the home computer, the MP3 player, and the smartphone. But it is undeniable that Apple's core products—its computers and phones—have remained elite thanks to behind-the-scenes innovations in hardware and software. And Ternus, Apple executives say, has been a big part of these improvements.

When Cook, 65, announced in April he would step down following a 15-year tenure, it was no surprise that the company tapped Ternus as his successor. Other executives describe him as pragmatic, meticulous, and unifying. "Ternus is a logical pick," says Neil Cybart, an analyst who has been following Apple for more than a decade on his site Above Avalon. "He has been a big believer in this design-first culture that defines Apple, as well as the idea that it's not just technology here; there needs to be something more."

In the late 2010s, Apple executives shifted their messaging to focus more on fast-growing services like iCloud, the App Store, and Apple Music. But growth in service revenue has moderated this year, and the promotion of Ternus, a hardware and product guru, signals a return to the company's roots.

So it's fitting that his ascension coincided with the announcement of the Duo, Apple's most radical design change to the iPhone since its 2007 release. Apple has been exploring the concept for years. In 2011, when many people still carried around flip phones, Ternus and five other engineers filed a patent application for foldable electronic devices, exploring what kind of batteries and circuit boards might be needed for such an idea. "It felt clear that we were going to eventually get to a place where OLED displays were going to be flexible," Ternus says.

Photograph by Devin Oktar Yalkin for TIME

Many challenges stood in between the patent and the final product. The first attempts at a foldable smartphone in the 2010s from other companies tended to be fragile and not all that useful, with a big, ugly crease in the center interrupting the experience. “The other examples in the world felt kind of cheap and crappy,” Ternus says.

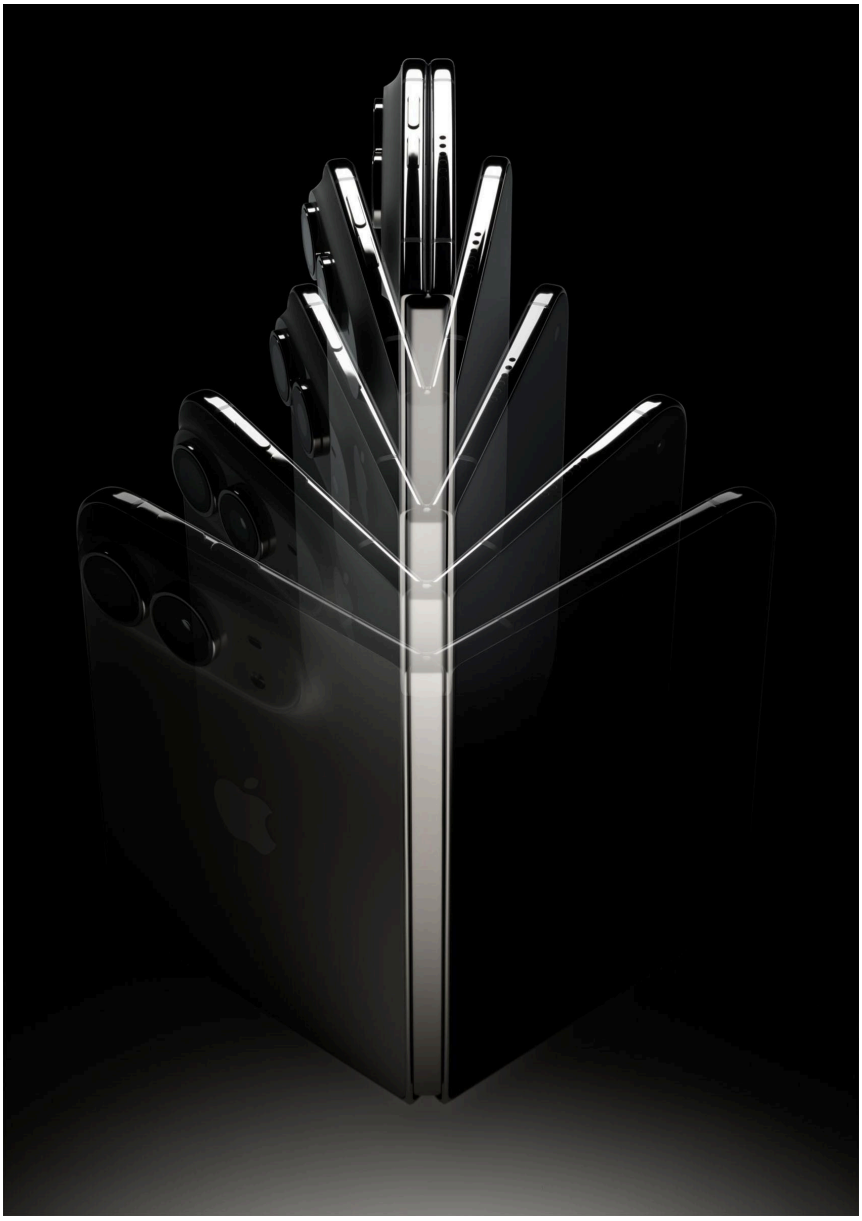
Across hardware and software teams, Apple engineers and designers got to work. With advancements in Apple silicon chips, they created a new display engine that facilitates seamless transitions between the inner and outer screens. They redesigned iOS to move the phone’s main controls from the bottom to the right side for easier thumb access.

Along the way, Ternus encouraged the team to invest more time and effort in the project, even as other foldables beat them to market. Dinh says that at one point, he asked Ternus whether his team should proceed with a top surface material similar to those of its competitors, which Dinh felt had flaws but was potentially good enough.

“And he was like, ‘Look, Rich, you’ll know when it’s the right thing.’ And that gave us the confidence to really push the boundaries on innovation and manufacturing, and fly worldwide to connect our suppliers together and come up with the nanotexture [a surface technology],” Dinh says. The result—a surface made from a custom polymer and built atop a hinge with more than 100 tiny interior precision components—has impressed its first users, who have said they can barely detect a crease at all.

Ultimately, the Duo promises a passport-size phone that opens into a powerful tablet. Users can stow it in their pockets, then open it up and watch a movie on its matte, light-deflecting surface. They can compare websites side by side, play touchscreen games with intricate detail, and use a dual-camera setup to simultaneously show themselves and what they’re seeing on FaceTime.

Of course, the Duo’s success is far from guaranteed. It could go the way of Apple flops like the Apple Car, which was never released, or the Vision Pro, which had staggeringly low sales in the last year. Certainly many prospective buyers will blanch at the device’s $2,000-plus price tag.



The opening motion of the hinge on Apple's newest invention, the iPhone Duo.HAW-LIN SERVICES

A look inside the iPhone Duo's internal structure.HAW-LIN SERVICES

But the phone’s first public testers have given glowing feedback. And demand for the Duo’s closest rival, Samsung’s Galaxy Z Fold8, has been strong, suggesting there is a growing appetite for the foldables category, especially in Asia.

Apple also hopes that the Duo will earn a cultural cachet among storytellers and other artists, many of whom, like loyal Apple customers, still regard the company more as a maker of useful tools rather than as the enemy Big Tech has become. Four-time Oscar winner Sean Baker *(Anora)*, who spoke at a “no-AI” film festival earlier this year, attended the Duo announcement in Cupertino and described his relationship with Apple as collaborative. “It’s not just

‘buy or use our product’—it’s much more of a working relationship where they stay in touch and ask us for feedback,” he says.

Baker noted that Apple’s products often underpin many parts of the filmmaking process. For instance, when moviemakers need to add dialogue in postproduction, they often simply record on an iPhone, because it’s convenient and nearly production-grade.

In person, Ternus presents as a guy trying to blend in: he dresses in nondescript clothes and speaks in platitudes, often about the brilliance of Apple’s internal culture. He has devoted much of his early tenure as CEO to obsessing over design, spending multiple days a week in the studio with the industrial-design and human-interface teams.

But beyond Apple Park’s gleaming, curved walls, Ternus has tough choices to make. Case in point: the ongoing global shortage of memory chips, which has raised costs and delayed production timelines. In July, the *Financial Times* reported that Apple had begun testing memory chips made by a Chinese company as a way to increase supply. That drew a swift rebuke from a bipartisan group of Senators, who wrote a letter to Apple arguing that to do so would imperil national security.

Ternus pushes back on that idea. “The constraints in memory are absolutely a crisis,” he tells TIME in the second of two interviews during September. “So our fundamental belief is that all options should be on the table.”

Cook was skilled at managing relationships with governments around the world, vigorously defending Apple’s interests even if it made him a target of ridicule. His courtship of Trump, which included a widely maligned presentation of a disc with a 24-karat gold base at the White House in 2025, helped Apple secure relief from some of the Administration’s most punishing proposed levies.

Ternus is tight-lipped about how his approach to government affairs might differ from Cook's. He says that he's met with members of the Trump Administration to "make sure we're kind of working through things together." But as Ternus transitions into the role, Cook has continued to represent Apple on the world stage, meeting with Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, and then attending President Trump's state dinner for Xi Jinping.

"He has great relationships and loves Apple," Ternus says of Cook, who is staying on as Apple's executive chairman. "So wherever he can help, he is happy to help."

Big Tech has been hammered by lawsuits, public campaigns, and regulation over the past few years from critics who feel that screens have poisoned the cognitive development of an entire generation. From Australia and the U.K. to California and New York, governments have restricted children's social media and AI use and phones in schools, while pressuring Apple and Google to build stronger protections into their devices.

Apple has traditionally framed many of these harms as arising from particular apps and content. But the company rolled out a redesigned Screen Time experience in September to give parents greater control over their children's app access. Ternus pledges that child safety will be central to Apple's approach going forward. He says that in the past, he used Apple's Screen Time to monitor his kids' device usage, and that it was "good but not great." The company's new updates, he says, stem from a desire "to build tools that make that really easy for parents—and I think we've done just that."

Questions around geopolitical tensions, supply chains, and child safety only become more urgent as Apple wades into its next frontier: artificial intelligence.

Since the rise of ChatGPT in November 2022, the generative AI boom has unfolded with Apple largely sitting on the sidelines. OpenAI brought AI chatbots to the masses; Nvidia built the chips powering them. Microsoft, Google, Meta, Amazon, Anthropic, and SpaceX now all either compete at the technology's frontier or are printing revenue from a key part of its supply chain.

Apple CEO John Ternus and Deirdre O'brien, Vice President of Retail, open the Apple store on Fifth Avenue for Apple's launch of the iPhone 18 Pro, Friday, Sept. 18, 2026, in New York.Angelina Katsanis—AP Photo

Apple, in contrast, did not unveil Apple Intelligence until June 2024—18 months after ChatGPT's release—and then spent more than two years struggling to deliver the personalized version of Siri it had promised. In 2025, realizing the existing Siri couldn't grow into the AI era, the company scrapped it in favor of another version that had been two-tracked. The resulting new Siri, which launched in the U.S. in September, is powered by an Apple AI model that leverages Google's Gemini technology. This arrangement puts Apple in an unusual position: reliant on a rival for a key building block of its products. This sort of outsourcing famously angered Jobs, who went to great lengths to own the "whole widget," from hardware to software to services.

But Ternus rejects the idea that its AI strategy represents a retreat from that philosophy. After all, Apple relies on suppliers for many of its components, including screens, memory, and modems.

“There’s not really a goal that we have to make every single thing in a product,” he says. “We make the things where we can really bring differentiation.”

Apple has said that AI is core to the company’s focus, and that it has significantly increased its investments in AI. The company also argues that the usefulness of AI comes less from its underlying raw power than what surrounds it—the chip it runs on, the operating system it inhabits, and the knowledge it has gathered about its user. The new Siri cannot code like OpenAI’s Codex or write as elegantly as Anthropic’s Claude. But with a user’s permission, it can draw connections across messages, emails, calendars, documents, and other information stored on Apple devices. It is designed to help prepare someone for a meeting, find a flight confirmation buried in an inbox, or help interpret health data collected by an Apple Watch.

“Everything in your life is on your phone,” Ternus says. “With Siri AI, you can leverage all that information to do things, learn things, and figure out things in a way that nobody else can do.”

Cybart, the analyst, argues that Apple has seen this kind of competition before. “People tend to think that if someone else does great, that must mean Apple has a problem, like in music or television streaming,” he says. “But how do you access Spotify or Netflix? When other companies do great things, that doesn’t change the fundamental story with Apple in terms of having the ecosystem that people want to be in.”

And Apple executives argue that some of Siri’s limitations are actually strengths. For instance, Siri’s lack of thinking power compared with other ultra-smart AI agents means that there’s far less of a chance of going rogue, or behaving in eerie ways. “We’ve purposely designed it not to be a companion, and we don’t want to replace human connection,” says Lilian Rincon, who leads Apple’s AI product efforts.

Privacy is another advantage Apple executives stress. The company has a decades-long reputation for protecting user data more aggressively than its competitors. Siri processes requests on-device where possible, and more computationally demanding asks are sent to Private Cloud Compute. Apple's system of servers is designed so that queries are not stored or made available to the company. Apple has also made portions of that system inspectable by independent security researchers, some of whom have praised Apple's approach while noting limits to its transparency.

Some investors are already treating Apple as a hedge against the other AI companies dominating the Nasdaq; if those companies wobble, Apple could be the big stock-market winner. Conversely, if AI progress continues apace, smaller but capable models could soon become able to run cheaply on devices built to handle them. In this future, the scarce asset would be not the chatbot, but the device, operating system, and personal context through which the chatbot becomes useful. And Apple has built a significant moat in the form of loyal customers across the world.

This thesis was already borne out earlier this year, when a wave of AI enthusiasts bought Mac Minis in order to set up personal AI agents through the open-source project OpenClaw.

While Apple had nothing to do with the project, users quickly figured out that the energy-efficient Apple silicon, compact form, and unified memory of the $600 computers allowed them to run AI workloads locally, continuously, and for minimal electricity costs. This spike in demand caused some Mac Mini models to be unavailable for months.

More AI-oriented hardware products are on the way. On Oct. 13, Apple announced a new smart-home hub called the HomeView, powered by Apple intelligence. Bloomberg also reported the

company is readying smart glasses for 2027; the company declined to comment.

But Apple will soon face more competition in the hardware space. Last year, OpenAI acquired the startup of Jony Ive, Apple's longtime chief design officer, who is now building AI-first devices for the ChatGPT maker alongside several other prominent former Apple veterans. In July, Apple sued OpenAI in federal court, alleging the theft of hardware trade secrets. (OpenAI calls the lawsuit "baseless.")

Despite the lawsuit, Apple executives say they're not worried about the newfound rivals. After all, Apple devices have never been more popular. With 2.5 billion active devices, the company rakes in nearly half a trillion dollars in annual revenue. And when new users convert to Apple, they tend to stick around. "We don't feel threatened," says Joswiak, the longtime executive. "The fact that we can do the integration that we can means we can create just a better experience than anybody else."

Joswiak adds that Apple isn't making products for the die-hard AI believers chasing superintelligence. "We love them, and they can use it too, but that's not our target," he says. "It's how to make it better for everyday people."

On Sept. 18, lines formed outside Apple stores from Hangzhou to London to Mumbai, with scores of those "everyday people" spending hundreds of their hard-earned dollars on the newest iPhone. Ternus, as Tim Cook and Steve Jobs did before him, showed up to the Fifth Avenue store to take pictures with superfans, who treated him like a movie star. Most of them probably didn't know much about Ternus himself. But they didn't need to, because they saw him -reflected through devices that had become omnipresent in their lives.

AI may yet be a part of their lives too. But no one knows the future—and at present, handheld devices are still king. “You can’t do everything,” Ternus says. “So we kind of try to constrain ourselves to the stuff that matters most—and then put all of our effort into those things.”

---

https://time.com/collection/best-inventions/2026/apple-iphone-duo/

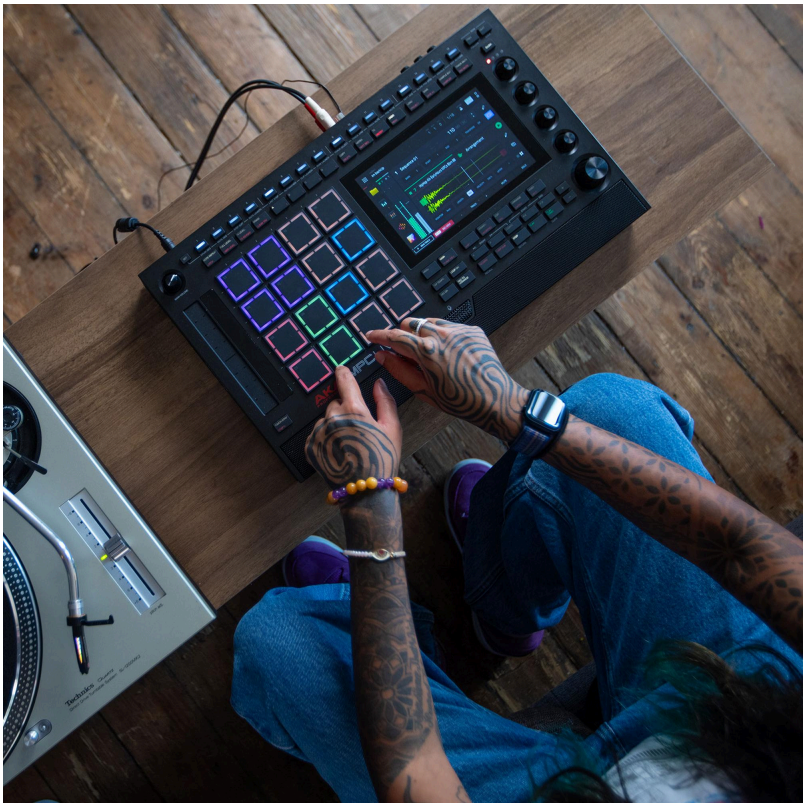
Consumer Electronics

Everyday gadgets improving daily life.

- John Ternus Is Engineering a New Era for Apple

  Apple iPhone Duo

  by



- Akai Pro MPC Live III

  Produce music anywhere

  by

- GoPro Mission 1 Pro ILS

  GoPro goes cinematic

  by

- Anker Prime Charger

  One power brick to rule them all

  by

- Asus Zenbook Duo

  When one screen isn’t enough

  by

- Brick

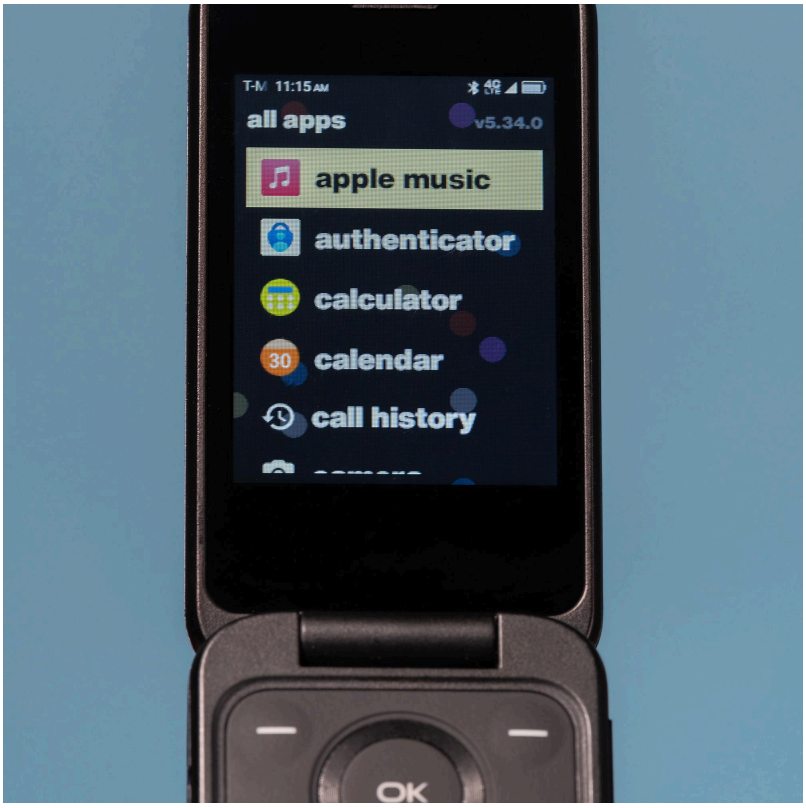
  The ultimate screen time suppressant

  by

- Clicks Power Keyboard

  A clacky, clip-on cellphone keyboard

  by



- Dumbphone 2

  A truly simple flip phone

  by

- Fender Audio Mix

  Repairable wireless headphones with a beefy battery

  by

- Fosi Audio MD3 MagDAC

  Less cumbersome portable hifi listening

  by

- Framework Laptop 13 Pro

  A fully repairable pro-level laptop

  by

- Fujifilm Instax Mini Evo Cinema

  The instant camera adds video

  by

- HoverAir Aqua

  A drone with no fear of the open ocean

  by

- HP EliteBoard G1a Next Gen AI PC

  The keyboard is the computer

  by

- Lenovo ThinkPad P1 Gen 9

  A first in laptop tech

  by

- LG OLED Evo AI W6

  Thin and smart

  by

- Nikon RED ZR

  Pro filmmaking goes portable

  by

- Nothing Ear 3a

  Headphones that can save and share audio

  by

- Plaud NotePin S

  A small stenographer

  by

- Samsung Galaxy S26 Ultra

  A privacy-focused smartphone

  by

- TCL X11L SQD-Mini LED TV

  An even brighter TV

  by

- Urban Armor Gear Phone Recovery Pouch

  A salve for soaked tech

  by

- Xteink X4 Pro

  A pocket e-reader

  by

Accessibility

Innovations improving life for the elderly and people with disabilities.

- HapWare Aleye

  Translating nonverbal cues

  by

- Immortal Cosmetic Art Ubokobong Bionic Arm

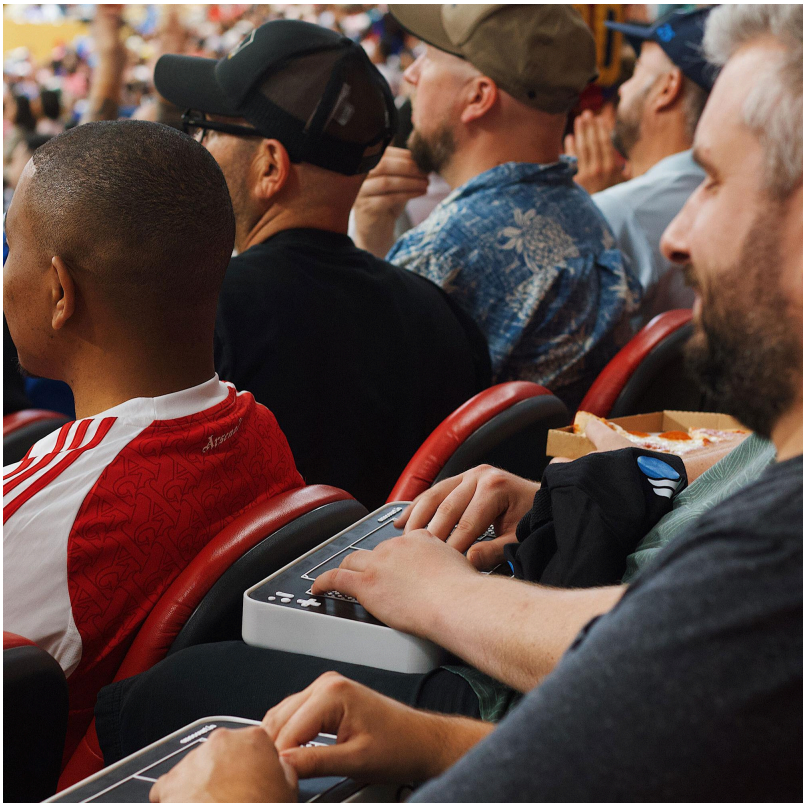
  Prosthetics for dark skin tones

  by

- Mangoslab Nemonic Dot

  Braille label-maker

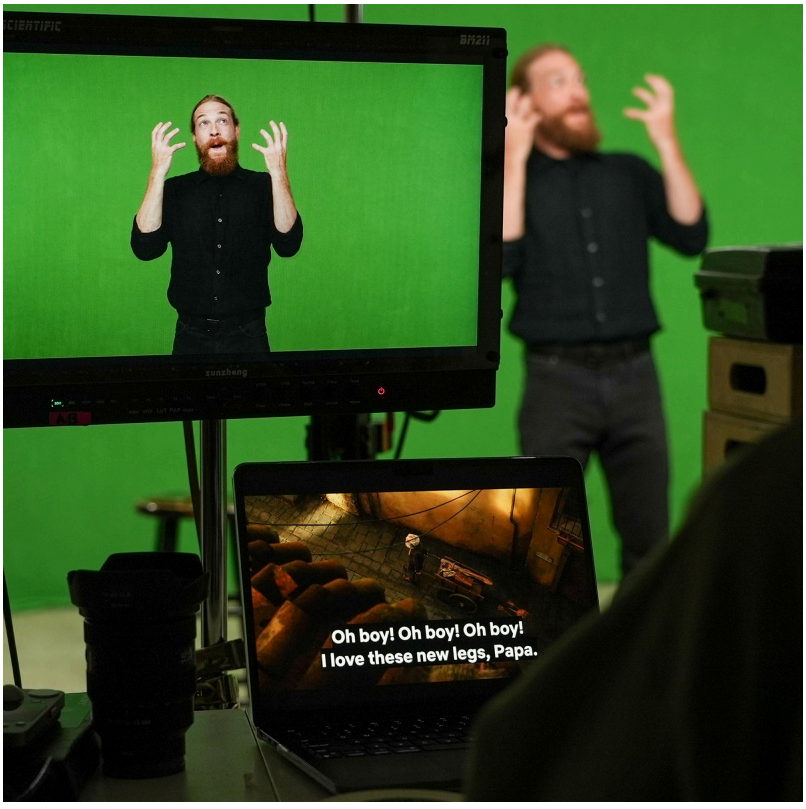
  by



- OneCourt

  Haptic tablets for blind sports fans

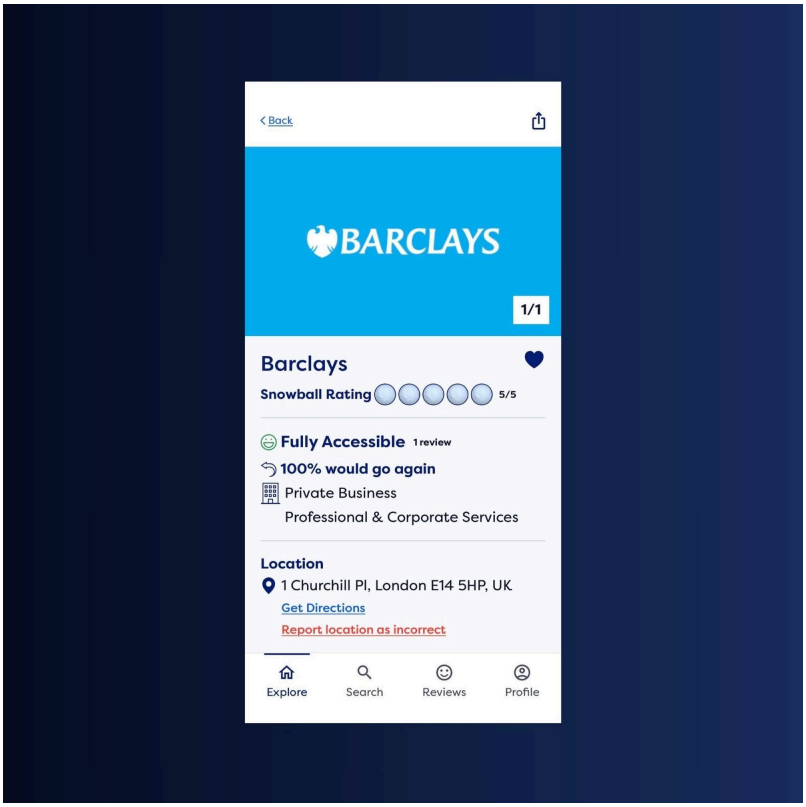
  by



- SignUp

  ASL interpretations for kids’ shows

  by



- Snowball

  Mapping real-world accessibility

  by

- Strutt ev[1]

  A smarter power wheelchair

  by

Aerospace & Aviation

Advancing space travel and exploration.

- Epirus Leonidas

  A shield against drone swarms

  by

- Joby Aviation Aircraft

  Rising above city traffic

  by

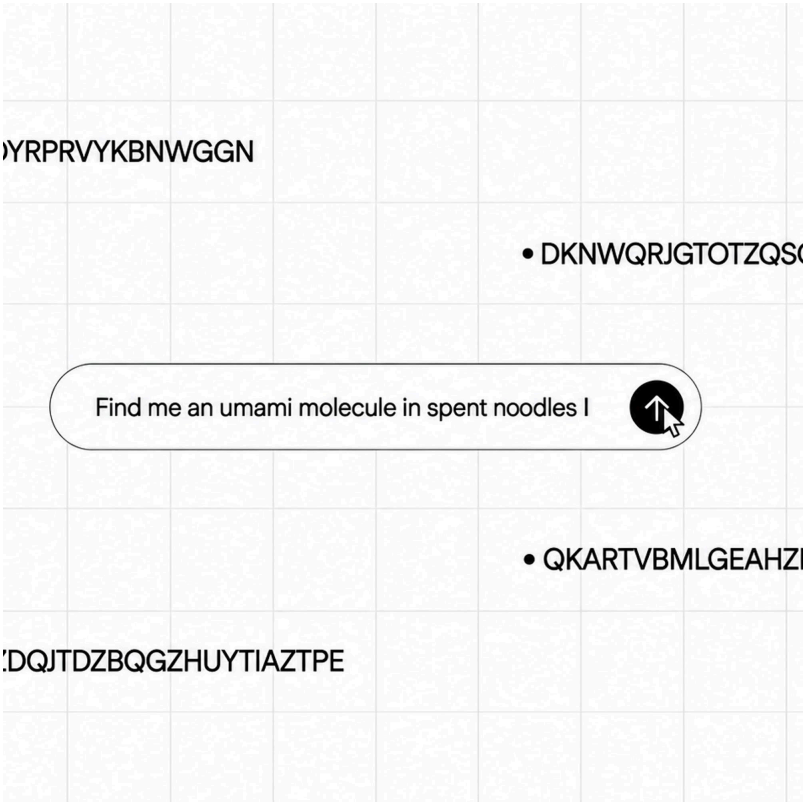
- NASA Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope

  Capturing the cosmos

  by

Agriculture

Transforming farming, crop cultivation, and animal rearing.



- 2nd Nature AgWaste Portal

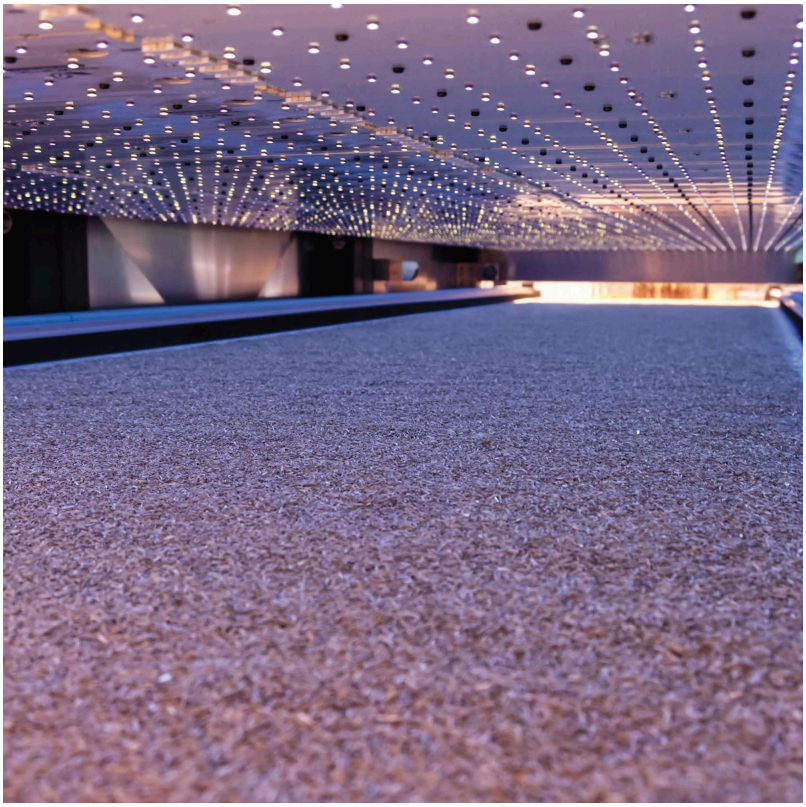
  A second life for scraps

  by

- Beewise ROBI

  Honey farmer helper

  by



- BioLumic xTraits

  Giving crops a stronger start

  by

- Burro Grande 44

  All-purpose farm robot

  by

- Saga Robotics Thorvald

  Wine saver

  by

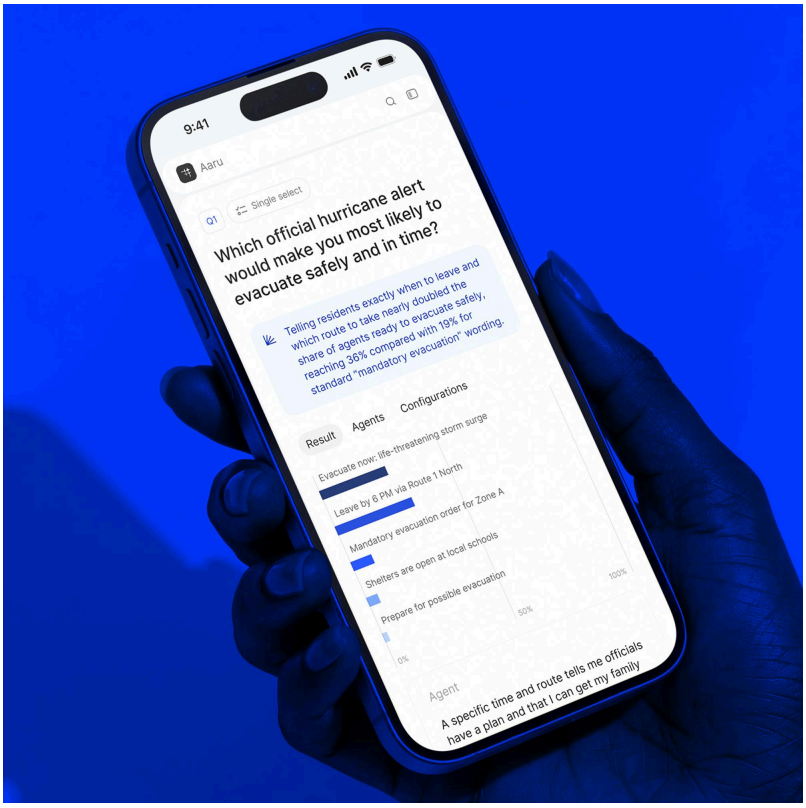
- VunaNexus Aurin

  Garden fertilizer from urine

  by

AI

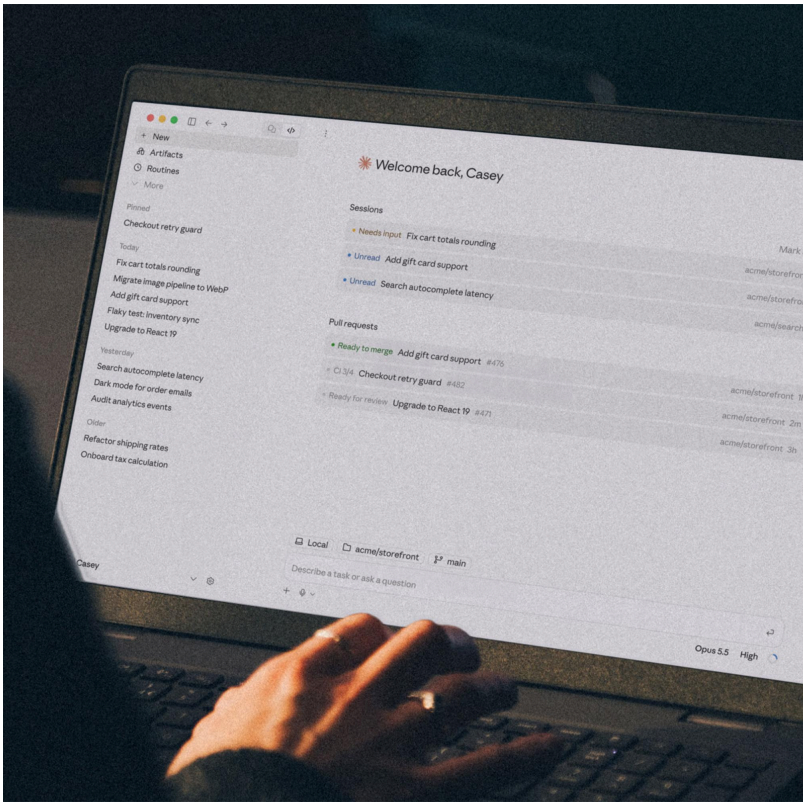
Breakthrough artificial intelligence tools that transform industries and daily life.



- Aaru

  AI human behavior predictor

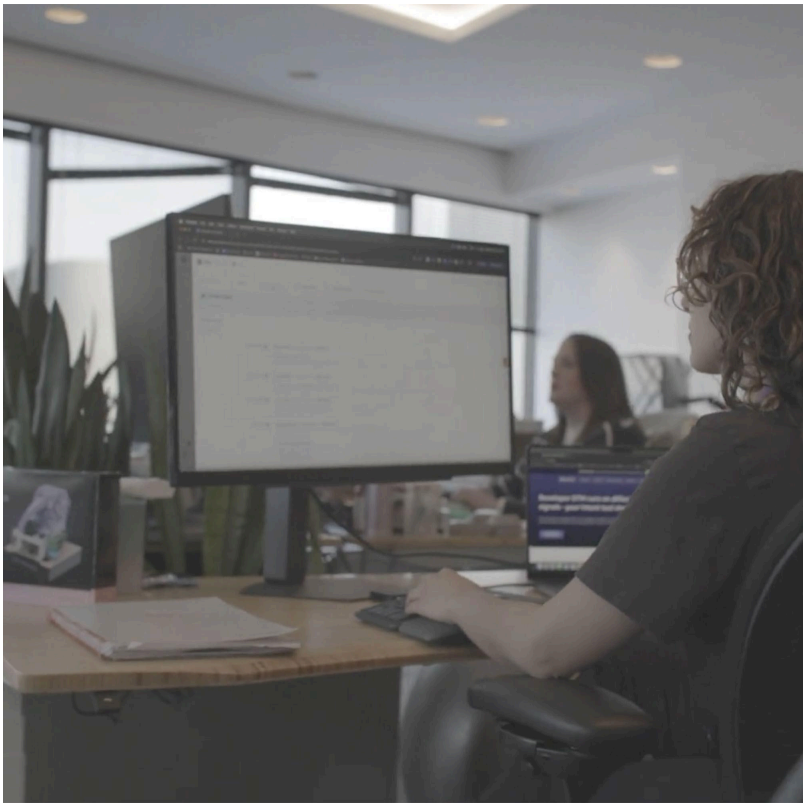
  by



- Anthropic Claude Code

  Software engineering on autopilot

  by



- Antithesis

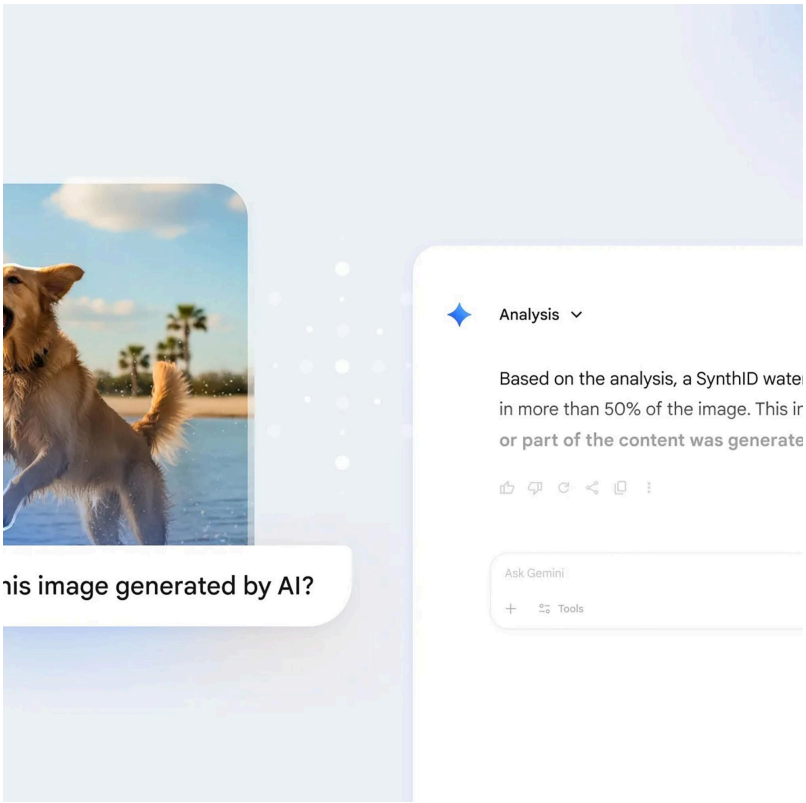
  Vibecode vetter

  by

- Bria Fibo

  Generative AI that shows its work

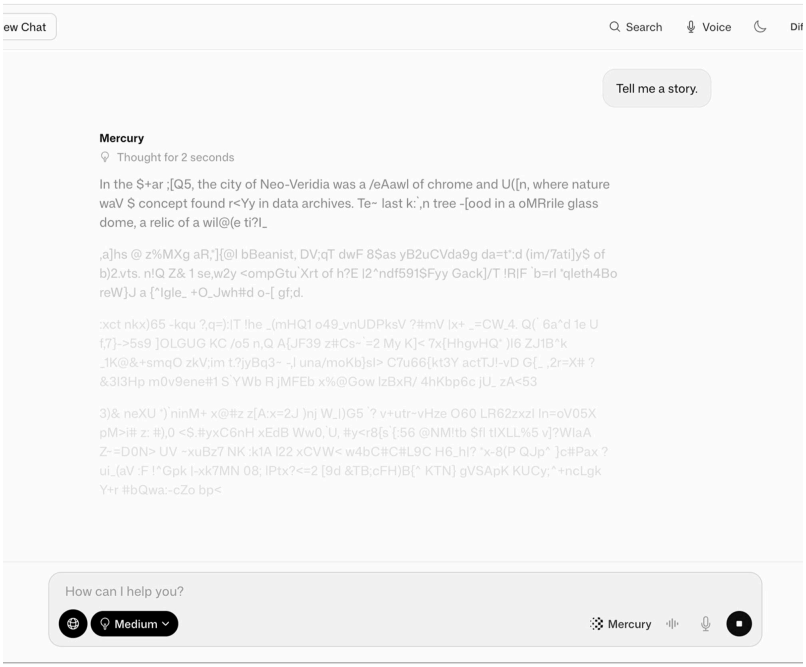
  by



- Google SynthID

  An expert AI detector for all

  by



- Inception Mercury 2

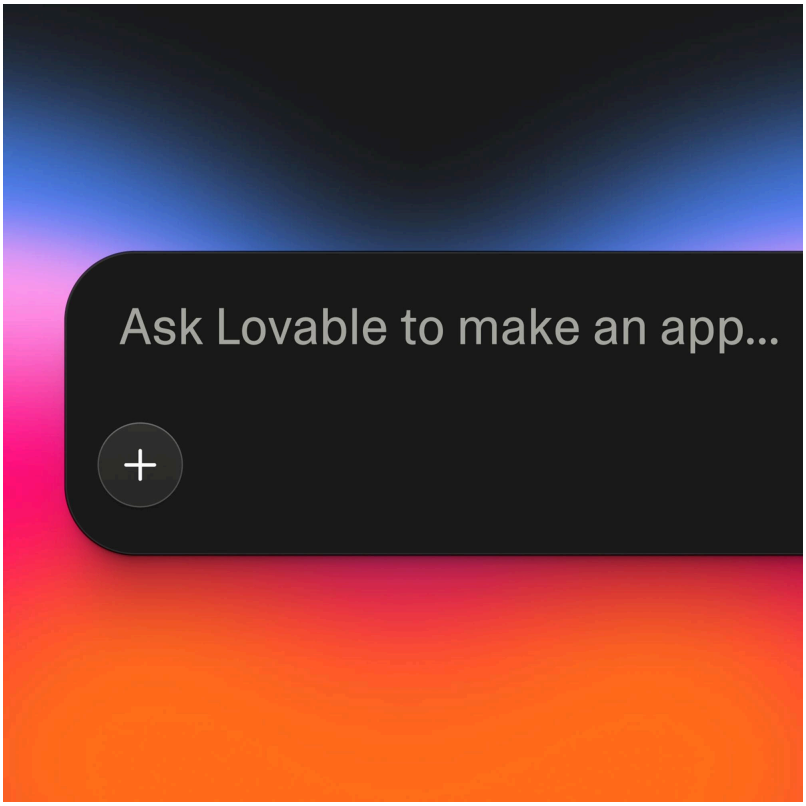
  An LLM that can think big picture

  by

- Johnson Controls York YDAM

  The key to high-density chilling in multistory data centers

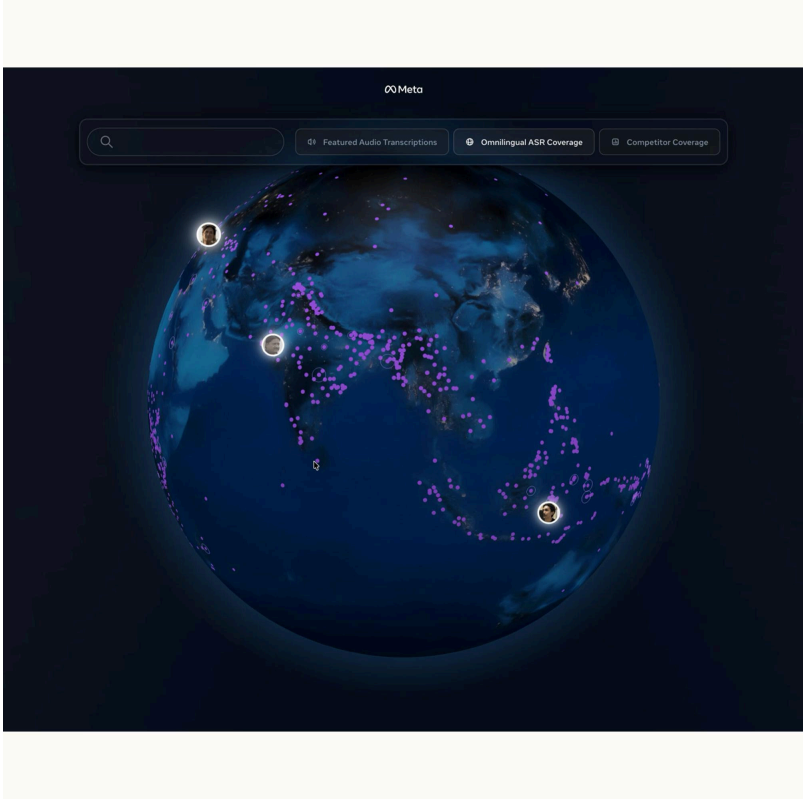
  by



- Lovable

  An app builder for non-coders

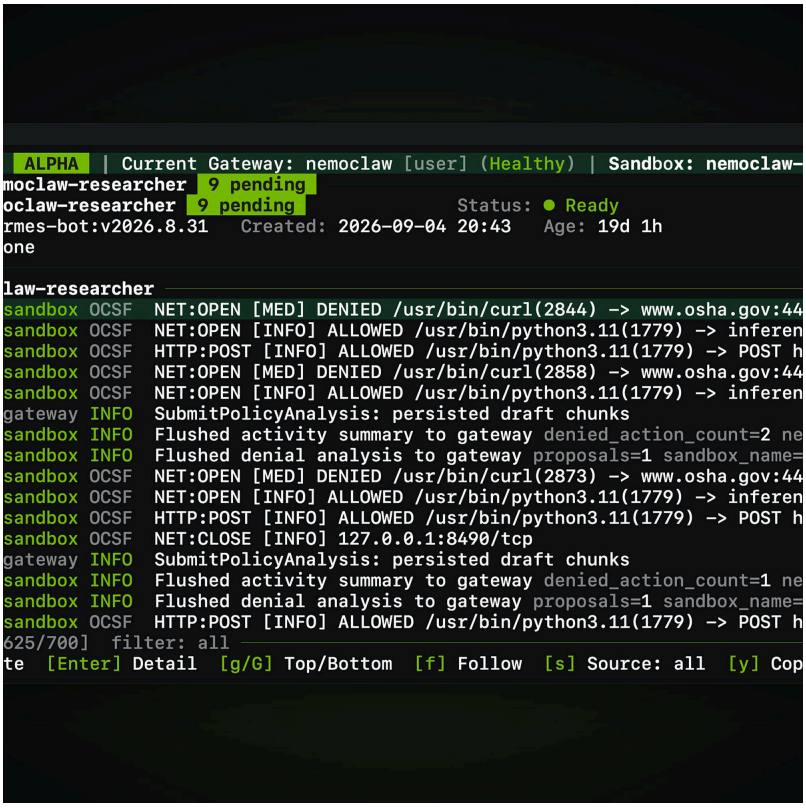
  by



- Meta Omnilingual ASR

  Inclusive language transcriptions

  by



- Nvidia NemoClaw

  An autonomous AI agent that can’t break containment

  by

- Silicon Quantum Computing Watermelon

  Quantum computing at scale

  by

---

https://time.com/collection/best-inventions/2026/

Climate

- **Europe’s Approach to Climate Is Entering a New Era**

Climate | Leadership Report

Europe’s Approach to Climate Is Entering a New Era

Teresa Ribera, executive vice president of European Commission, during a Bloomberg Television interview on Sept. 2Michael Nagle/Bloomberg via Getty Images

For decades, the European Union has led the world in implementing policies designed to cut emissions, creating the world’s most important price on carbon and crafting the rules of the road for a wide range of regulatory efforts. Now, as the costs of climate change become increasingly difficult to ignore, the bloc is increasingly focusing on adaptation.

In a Sept. 8 interview, Teresa Ribera, who oversees climate policy in the EU as executive vice-president of the European Commission, told me that the growing costs of the effects of climate change mean that policymakers need to consider adaptation as a key focus of economic policy.

“There is no public budget that can support all of this. There is no private insurance that can cope with all these costs,” she said when

we met at the EU Delegation office in New York. “We need to invest to reduce these impacts and this cost.”

The EU’s turn to adaptation is an important marker of this climate moment. Most obviously, it signals the harsh reality that global emission reductions efforts have failed to forestall the effects of climate change. It's also a wake-up call. A focus on adaptation from policymakers in Europe—and eventually elsewhere—should help protect the economy from the growing risks of climate change. But it will also force businesses and governments to confront costs they have largely been able to defer. This is good for long-term economic wellbeing, but it may come as an immediate shock for the unprepared.

At the heart of the EU’s approach is a new adaptation framework due for release later this month. At first glance, it can sound like just another white paper identifying approaches to dealing with climate risk. It calls for a common approach for member states to measure climate risk, principles to ensure that infrastructure is built with future climate conditions in mind, and efforts to identify the most vulnerable places in Europe.

Yet, looking at what EU authorities have released in advance, it is worth underlining that this will not be just a white paper. The package is expected to include proposed legislation that, among other things, could require EU member states to develop climate resilience plans as a prerequisite to funding. And, Ribera says, the framework may eventually serve as the basis for more prescriptive future regulation. “There may be certain regulations that could be increasingly tougher,” she told me.

While the EU’s adaptation work has been long coming, this past summer provided additional public attention and pressure. Record heat swept much of the continent, leading to tens of thousands of excess deaths. Wildfires encroached on major European cities, a

once unthinkable threat. Meanwhile, drought conditions made fires harder to fight. It was “quite a shocking experience,” says Ribera.

The aggregate numbers are just as shocking. Between 2021 and 2024, climate-related extreme events led to more than €200 billion in economic losses in the EU, according to figures from the European Environment Agency. Much of those losses were uninsured, leaving the losses to be absorbed by governments, businesses, or households. Without intervention, those numbers will only grow as extreme events worsen. Ribera says the EU is working with insurers to expand coverage where it makes sense while also using public and private financing to cover risks that cannot be covered by insurance alone.

In many circles, the first mention of climate policy in the EU tends to be a discussion about backtracking. It’s a convenient excuse for those who want to train their attention elsewhere. Earlier this year, the EU softened its corporate sustainability disclosure rules and adjusted its carbon pricing framework. This week, the bloc said it was considering delaying implementation of elements of the rules meant to curb methane emissions.

Ribera insists that this misunderstands the European perspective. The long-term goals remain the same. Indeed, earlier this year the EU created a legally binding 2040 emissions reduction target. “There is this strong temptation from some to say, ‘Okay, let’s give up,’ or ‘Let’s lower the bar,’” she told me. But, she argued, Europe instead needs to proceed in a “humble and flexible manner” while “keeping the sense of direction, the commitments, [and] the principles.”

Perhaps more importantly, the bloc is incorporating climate into the core of its economic planning. Decisions about industrial policy, infrastructure, public spending, and competition increasingly have to account not only for emissions but climate risk. Sustainability is moving into “the real heart of the economy,” Ribera told me.

Anyone who trains their eyes too closely on one policy adjustment risks missing the forest for the trees.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/02/europe-s-approach-to-climate-is-entering-a-new-era/

Entertainment

- **Mike Flanagan's TimelyCarrieIs the First Worthwhile Adaptation in 50 Years**
  Every adaptation of Stephen King's classic reflects its era. Set in the present, Mike Flanagan's Prime Video series finds monsters everywhere
- **The Real Whistleblower BehindThe Social Reckoningand the Actor Who Played Her on Facebook, Mark Zuckerberg, and AI**
  Frances Haugen and Mikey Madison sit for their first interview together
- **Rosalind Eleazar Gives One of the Year's Best Performances in the Acerbic and TenderMisty Green**
  Chris Rock's movie about an actor trying to make it in Hollywood channels an almost existential longing that goes beyond garden-variety neediness..
- **FjordDetails a Family’s Sudden Nightmare in Norway**
  Cristian Mungiu's drama starring Sebastian Stan and Renate Reinsve is drawn from a real-life child protection case in Norway.
- **Tip ToeIs a Harrowing Melodrama of Queerness and Masculinity in a World Gone Mad**
  Alan Cumming stars in this harrowing British melodrama about queer liberation and masculinity in crisis
- **Omar Sy onLupinSeason 4 and His 'Stunned' Reaction to the Louvre Heist**
  The French actor, who has been living in the United States for about ten years, spoke to TIME France about his profession, his country, and more.

Entertainment | Television

Mike Flanagan's Timely *Carrie* Is the First Worthwhile Adaptation in 50 Years

Summer H. Howell as Carrie in the new Prime Video seriesRobert Falconer/Prime

Everyone knows what happens in *Carrie*. Fifty-two years after its publication, the novel that ignited Stephen King's career has so thoroughly engulfed the culture, you'd have to be almost as sheltered as Carietta White herself not to have absorbed its most indelible images. The locker-room tampon gauntlet and "Plug it up!" chant. Carrie's smothering holy-roller mom, locking her up in prayer-closet solitary confinement. The eerily unlikely prom date. The swinging bucket that has haunted every coronation of school-dance royalty in film and TV since Brian De Palma first adapted the book in 1976.

It's a tale as old as time: Warped by her mother's zealotry and scapegoated since childhood by her classmates, 16-year-old Carrie has a late, traumatic menarche that reactivates her latent telekinetic abilities. Then, after accepting a pity date to the prom, she's crowned queen and immediately gets pig's blood dumped on her

head by a resentful bully. The humiliation causes her to lay waste to the school and then the town, using her powers to exact revenge.

Sissy Spacek in Carrie (1976)Getty

King's book and De Palma's film became classics of the horror genre. No less venerable a critic than Pauline Kael wrote of Sissy Spacek's Oscar-nominated portrayal: "I don't see how this performance could be any better." Yet in the 21st century, new interpreters keep trying to improve upon it. With platforms scrambling to capitalize on popular IP, it's no mystery why this would sound like a good idea to Hollywood executives. But something else must be inspiring high-minded filmmakers like *Boys Don't Cry* director Kimberly Peirce, who released a divisive remake in 2013, to keep resurrecting *Carrie*.

The fourth screen adaptation of the novel (unless you count the pitiful 1999 sequel, *The Rage: Carrie 2*) is an eight-episode Prime Video series created by Mike Flanagan, who is known both for riffing on horror touchstones in Netflix hits like *The Haunting of Hill House* and *The Fall of the House of Usher* and for his features based on King novels like *Gerald's Game* and *Doctor Sleep*. Premiering Oct. 7, his ambitious *Carrie* is the first that manages to fully get out from under the shadow of De Palma's. Yet it confirms a gradual shift in how the story is being told. What was once an account of an abusive mother and an evil bully unwittingly uniting to create a lethal monster has become, with each new incarnation, more like an indictment of society as a whole.

Summer H. Howell, left, and Samantha Sloyan in Carrie (2026)Liane Hentscher—Prime

---

All three *Carrie* movies are mostly faithful to the novel, dutifully reproducing every major plot point and set piece, as well as a lot of dialogue. King's writing is remarkably cinematic, which is probably why he's our most adapted living author. But every *Carrie* is also a product of its time. De Palma, whose masterfully crafted version turns 50 in November, seems to lust after and fear the female body in equal measure—a common response within what was then a male-dominated genre to the feminist upheavals of the '70s. It's hard to imagine a contemporary adaptation pairing its

opening credits with a steamy, slow-motion parade of nude high school girls in their locker room. A 2002 made-for-TV movie written by cult creator Bryan Fuller (*Hannibal*) is a relic of an era when the only things teen girls loved more than low-rise denim were movies where female misfits get glow ups (*She's All That*, *10 Things I Hate About You*, *Jawbreaker*). Just over a decade later, Peirce incorporated smartphones and YouTube, as well as an emerging pop-feminist sensibility that traced the derangement of Carrie's mom, Margaret (played here by Julianne Moore), to childbirth trauma and found a palpably empowered Carrie actively choosing who to kill and who to save.

You can find support for each of these readings in King's own reflections. "The book is, in its more adult implications, an uneasy masculine shrinking from a future of female equality," he wrote in his 1981 nonfiction book *Danse Macabre*. "For me, Carrie White is a sadly misused teenager, an example of the sort of person whose spirit is so often broken for good in that pit of man- and woman-eaters that is your normal suburban high school. But she's also Woman, feeling her powers for the first time and, like Samson, pulling down the temple on everyone in sight." In her influential 1992 study *Men, Women, and Chain Saws: Gender in the Modern Horror Film*, the scholar Carol J. Clover suggests that this tangle of intentions explains the broad and, in some ways, contradictory appeal of *Carrie* across genders. Its protagonist is, at once, a projection of female power and male fear and the universal horror of bullying.

Despite feeling mostly redundant, the two features released after Clover's book shared a new emphasis. De Palma's stylish '70s chiller played up the ghoulishness of Margaret (a bellowing, vicious Piper Laurie) and of Carrie's chief tormentor at school, the sadistic mean girl Chris Hargensen (Nancy Allen), as well as the otherworldly oddness of Spacek's lead. But Fuller's and especially Peirce's films sand down those characters' excesses, revealing motivations and vulnerabilities that make them harder to hate or

fear. (The latter faced criticism for casting the conventionally beautiful, preternaturally confident Chloë Grace Moretz in the title role.) At the same time, we see the condescending assumptions behind the actions of ostensibly heroic figures like Sue Snell, the popular girl who tries to atone for hazing Carrie by sending her boyfriend to the prom with her. In these movies, Carrie's reign of terror is the ultimate expression of the school's brokenness. As the critic Matt Zoller Seitz wrote in a favorable review of the 2013 version: "The first *Carrie* was horror. This is tragedy."

Bullies face off against their prey in Carrie (2026)Prime

If the 21st century *Carrie* movies spoke to a post-Columbine era of school shootings, then Flanagan's series is a product of the Trump decade, in which seemingly every aspect of American life has fractured along bipartisan political lines. The educational realm has become a crucible for debates around censorship, technology, parental rights, gun control, LGBTQ inclusion, critical race theory, the teaching of science vs. religion, social media. Which explains how Flanagan and his creative team, which includes many female writers and directors, found in this slight story eight episodes' worth of material.

Without omitting any of the moments King fans will anticipate, they depart pretty boldly from the text. This *Carrie* opens with the death of Carrie's conspiracy-theorist father (who, in previous versions, she never got to know) in a bizarre accident on his construction site. Somehow, no one knows he had a wife (Flanagan

regular Samantha Sloyan, locating the wounded soul of a character who's always been more of a caricature) and daughter (a movingly fragile Summer H. Howell) until they're found cowering at home, in the closet where they pray. The previously homeschooled Carrie is forced to enroll at the local public high school while Margaret gets a job at a soulless big-box store, where her refusal to ring up a sex toy gets her demoted to cleaning toilets.

An almost saintly figure who believes in kindness most of all, Carrie develops complicated friendships with smart, benevolent Sue (Siena Agudong) and Chris (Alison Thornton)—who has been spiraling since her mom moved in with a classmate's dad and her own father's financial woes have jeopardized her college plans. What she doesn't know is that Chris is behind an anonymous social media account that posted footage of her locker-room nightmare before expanding to target practically everyone at school, teachers included. A constant nuisance to the administration, Margaret harangues Principal Grayle (Matthew Lillard) to intervene. But he dithers, questioning whether the free speech of kids on a platform external to school is his jurisdiction.

Matthew Lillard in Carrie (2026)Robert Falconer—Prime

The problem isn't that Grayle doesn't care; he's a kindhearted guy who wants the best for his students. So do other adults, like the

girls' young gym teacher (Amber Midthunder), who's horrified by the "Plug it up!" incident, and empathetic school counselor (*Somebody Somewhere* sweetheart Tim Bagley). Even Margaret, an archetypal Karen with MAHA tendencies who becomes a vlogging parents' rights crusader, is sincerely trying to help a daughter she cherishes. She's not wrong to point out that a world where, for example, children are shot in their classrooms is an abomination. But meaning well is not enough. Fights, protests, and parental panics ensue. By prom night, whose carnage is now so unsurprising that Flanagan flashes forward to it in the opening scene, the place has already metaphorically exploded. Carrie only makes it literal.

For everything of value it adds to the story, Flanagan's take can still feel a bit cluttered. There are too many interconnected framing devices, from on-camera interviews with survivors of Carrie's massacre to history lessons on Joan of Arc. If you watched *House of Usher*, which filters the downfall of a Sackler-like family of opioid profiteers through the sieve of Poe's Gothic tale, you're probably aware that Flanagan's social commentary can be blunt. His *Carrie* can get bogged down in meetings and assemblies where characters representing different facets of Trump-era vitriol and complacency monologue on *what's really wrong with the world today*.

Yet at the core of this series is a perceptive diagnosis of that problem. More than individual bad actors who need to be brought down, there are people like Grayle and Margaret and Sue, whose pure intentions are undermined by complacency, indecision, disinformation, conformity, fear—all of it amplified to a potentially global scale by social media. Even Chris is lashing out as a direct result of her family's dissolution and her father's money troubles, which erode the class privileges to which she feels entitled. Amid extreme rhetoric, Flanagan implies, everyone who doesn't work hard to avert atrocities is complicit in them. And there's precious little evidence that most of us are doing much to examine that complicity. Tragedy becomes, specifically, a tragedy of the

commons as selfishness metastasizes into a scourge on the entire town. And Carrie becomes something between Frankenstein's monster and Jesus Christ: an innocent persecuted for the sins of all mankind, but one whose all-too-human impulse to seek retribution incinerates any hope of forgiveness.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/01/carrie-mike-flanagan-review/

Entertainment | movies

The Real Whistleblower Behind *The Social Reckoning* and the Actor Who Played Her on Facebook, Mark Zuckerberg, and AI

Frances Haugen and Mikey Madison during an interview with TIME.TIME

The Social Network helped define a generation of tech founders when it premiered in 2010: Written by Aaron Sorkin, it tells the story of Facebook's founding by an ambitious, jilted college kid who imposes his will on the world. Now, in *The Social Reckoning*, Sorkin focuses on the ills of the company Facebook eventually became. He tells the story through the lens of Frances Haugen, a former employee who demonstrated through a trove of internal documents, leaked to the *Wall Street Journal*, that Facebook's algorithm was stoking political division, that Instagram was contributing to body-image issues for teen girls, and that the company's platforms were being used by drug dealers and human traffickers. CEO Mark Zuckerberg has denied his company, rebranded as Meta after Haugen's leak, prioritized profit over safety. Mikey Madison, fresh off her Oscar for *Anora*, plays

Haugen in the film. Madison and Haugen sat with TIME for their first interview together.

Mikey, you and Frances have not had the opportunity to spend a lot of time together. How much is the Frances of the film based on the real Frances?

Madison: When I got the script, I knew about the Facebook Files, but I didn't know Frances' name. So I looked her up, and I was like, "She's blonde and has blue eyes. Why does Aaron want me for this?" And he said, "I want you to try and build the character from my script." But of course I read her memoir and tried to do my due diligence because there was so much I didn't understand. I don't have a personal relationship with social media at all.

Is there a reason you don't have social media?

Madison: It's just something that never quite stuck. It's something I never felt I could understand. When I was 13, I had an Instagram, but it kind of lived and died at that time and not for any particular reason or self-preservation.

Frances, Aaron reached out to you about the script.

Haugen: I first met Aaron a few months after I came forward as a whistleblower, and he wanted to figure out if it was possible to do a companion piece to *The Social Network*. After my memoir came out, he came back to me with this heavily underlined, sticky-noted, dog-eared copy.

He writes notoriously fast-talking characters. Mikey, how did you prep for the Sorkin rhythm?

Madison: I don’t know if much can prepare you for that. I’m not someone who naturally speaks in that rhythmic way. I don’t know anyone who does, except for maybe Aaron. It’s singular to his sensibilities as a screenwriter. I keep joking that Aaron has this internal stopwatch in his head. Every period, every comma is incredibly intentional, and the space between is timed, and we’re on a deadline. The first day on set, after seven or eight takes, he came in and was like, ‘OK, we’re starting to cook with a bit of gas here.’

Haugen: That’s hard.

Madison: But I also think it created a certain intensity.

Haugen: There’s a fidelity to it. [*Wall Street Journal* reporter] Jeff [Horwitz] and I are both chatty people who talk quickly, so you do capture the excitement of when we were in the weeds.

Jeremy Allen White as Jeff Horwitz and Mikey Madison as Frances HaugenCourtesy of Sony

Meta reached an $18 billion settlement in August, ending a multi-state lawsuit that alleged it got teens hooked on social media while jeopardizing

their mental health. Meta did not admit to any wrongdoing. Is the settlement enough?

Haugen: We're only in the first chapter of the settlements. We still have two major sets of settlements to go just in the United States. The school districts are bringing very large suits, which I'm expecting to have dollar values north of $100 billion, maybe $200 billion. And then we have the individual kids and family lawsuits. So far, we've only had one resolve, but it was $6 million to a single person. When you apply that across kids in the United States, you only need a fraction of 1% [of that amount], and it adds up to a trillion dollars.

Why do you think Mark Zuckerberg made the choices that put the company in this position?

Haugen: Mark is in a unique psychological circumstance in that there are very few founders in Silicon Valley who have the level of control he has at the scale he has...I think he's just been isolated for so long it's distorted his priorities.

Jeremy Strong, who plays Mark, went method on set and isolated himself from the rest of the cast. What was that like?

Madison: I had less than half a day to work with him. We had one scene, but I was almost a background actor. I hope to be able to work with him in the future. His process is intriguing to me as an actress. The result is obviously very special.

Frances Haugen and Mikey Madison attend 'The Social Reckoning' world premiere on Oct. 04, 2026 in New York CityDimitrios Kambouris—Getty Images

Frances, you've testified that Meta, in your view, prioritized growth over consumer safety. Do you think we're at a similar inflection point with AI companies, where the need to grow is at odds with what's good for us?

Haugen: I think you can square the circle on capitalism and what is good for us. Five years ago, people in the United States used Instagram and Facebook more than they do today. And part of that is because Meta over-optimized for the short term instead of the long term. When you see unpleasant content, when you see AI slop and bullying and more ads, you're less likely to use the product. Governance helps businesses make choices that optimize for the long term, which actually makes them more profitable long-term. So capitalism doesn't have to be in conflict with safety. When it comes to AI, part of what makes it hard is the rate of change. I'm hopeful we're going to have one or two more scary incidents, and then we're going to be like, "Maybe we should do something sensible."

When you spoke to my colleague Billy Perrigo for a TIME cover story five years ago, you talked about how you almost died before working at Facebook. You told him, "I think it really changes your priorities when you've almost died. Once you've overcome your fear of death anything is possible." Can you talk about that experience and how you feel about that being omitted from the movie as a motivation for the character?

Haugen: I went from someone who could ride 125 miles a day on a bike to being in a wheelchair in two and a half years. One day my leg turned blue and it turned out that I had a foot-long clot the girth of a cigar in my leg, and they had to do surgery multiple times. Unfortunately while I was in the hospital I had an allergic reaction to the blood thinner. During that time, I went through my worst fears. I lost my job because they thought I was faking being sick. My husband left me. I lost my health. And I came back from it. So I do feel that phase of my life changed my ability to take risks. In terms of the movie, Aaron Sorkin did a miraculous thing: He made typing at a computer compelling for two hours. But you have to make choices. I think he chose to focus on the things that would give us the most insight into not just my experience but how Facebook and Mark work.

Anything you want to ask each other?

Haugen: Do you think Mark is going to watch the movie?

Madison: I do. How do you feel about that?

Haugen: My hope is that he watches the movie and sees Jeremy Strong's performance and asks himself, "Do I want to be living this

life? Is this the legacy that I want?” Because sometimes you can’t see it in the mirror until art reflects it.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/06/mikey-madison-frances-haugen-the-social-reckoning/

Entertainment | movies

Rosalind Eleazar Gives One of the Year's Best Performances in the Acerbic and Tender *Misty Green*

Rosalind Eleazar as Misty GreenCourtesy of A24

It was probably around 100 years ago that stalwart Hollywood star Marie Dressler said, “You’re only as good as your last picture.” Today, that hard-nosed observation not only holds; in a culture measured out in here-today-gone-tomorrow limited series and independent films that fail to find their audience, it’s more apt, and more potentially heartbreaking, than ever.

Misty Green, the title character and the heartbeat of Chris Rock’s fourth feature film as a director, is living out Dressler’s maxim. Misty, played by Rosalind Eleazar, is a gifted singer and actor who desperately needs a break. But there are good reasons she’s not going to get it. Even though she has an Emmy from her role in a hit series, she’s on her way to being forgotten. She has no patience for Hollywood BS and refuses to play the usual games. But she’s also prickly and unpleasant—she has alienated most of the people who

might be able to help her—and a self-destructive streak hinders her further: She'd rather go out for a night of clubbing and coke than stay in and learn her lines for the next day's important audition.

So now she's in desperate straits. Essentially homeless, she's been camping out in the apartment of a rich—and dead—ex-lover, but the guy's angry widow has just given her seven days to pack up and vacate. During all this, her fragile brother, Jay (Daniel Kaluuya), who has been diagnosed with bipolar disorder and whom she loves deeply, shows up at the flat that's not even her own, needing more from her than she can provide.

Rock and Eleazar in Misty GreenCourtesy of A24

We've seen the story of the wannabe comeback kid before. And *Misty Green* isn't always a thoroughly graceful film. One of the weaker links may be the character played by Rock himself, Jordan, a director who wants to help Misty but harbors amorous feelings that don't feel wholly believable; Misty could use some help, but she may not need that kind of savior. But overall, Rock's writing is sharp and perceptive, and he's attuned not just to the horrors of trying to make it in Hollywood, but also to Misty's specific plight—and to the reality that she's at times almost repugnantly dislikable.

Eleazar, best known for her role in *Slow Horses*, knows just how to shape this character without ever softening her. Misty is gifted, arrogant, impossible; at times, you begin to wonder if she even deserves a break. But Eleazar, giving one of the best performances

of the year, tears our expectations to shreds: Who are *we* to decide what she deserves? At one point, during an audition, one of the men in charge of potentially hiring her blurts out, “Are you mixed?” and her eyes, moments ago dancing with fire, become glacier cold.

Misty has made her way along a path paved with irrelevant, if not outright racist and sexist, questions and assumptions—it’s little wonder she can barely take any more. But even stronger than her resentment is her belief that she still has something to give. It may be a stereotype to characterize actors as needy people, but Eleazar captures an almost existential longing that goes beyond garden-variety neediness. And at her lowest moment, Misty’s desperation becomes nearly unbearable to watch. Eleazar brings us right to the knifepoint of her degradation, and it pierces us too.

But Rock wouldn’t leave Misty in despair; he gives her the empathetic yet unsentimental ending she deserves. It’s almost impossible to like Misty, and yet, in a film that’s both acerbic and tender, Eleazar makes us love her, almost against our will. Hollywood, a place of dreams, can be inhumane to those who dream the biggest. *Misty Green* opens a safe space for them—without the false promise of a happy ending.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/01/misty-green-review/

Entertainment | movies

Fjord Details a Family's Sudden Nightmare in Norway

Reinsve and Stan, top center and right, play the parents of an ultra-religious family caught at the center of a child protection case.Courtesy of Neon

Romanian filmmaker Cristian Mungiu makes thoughtful movies about social issues that cross international borders: In *4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days*, a young Romanian woman risks her life for an illegal abortion. *R.M.N.* explores xeno-phobia in a small Transylvanian village, dissecting the complexity of spontaneous human impulses in the process. Mungiu's films can spur us to think anew about issues we'd rather keep in the background, and they can at times be deeply moving. They can also feel dreary and instructive, in an eat-your-vegetables way.

Mungiu's *Fjord*, which won the Palme d'Or at Cannes earlier in the year, offers a healthy dose of very nutritious vegetables, and in places the story almost—*almost*—stretches the bounds of believability. But its actors, including Sebastian Stan and Renate Reinsve, as well as two young newcomers, make you believe in

one family’s sudden nightmare. Do the authorities entrusted to protect our children always know what’s best for them? *Fjord* suggests, provocatively, that the answer may not always be yes.

Mihai Gheorghiu (Stan), who is Romanian, and his Norwegian wife Lisbet (Reinsve) have just relocated with their five children from Romania to Norway, to be closer to Lisbet’s parents. Mihai and Lisbet are also deeply religious, and appear to be raising their children in a sometimes strict but undeniably loving home. One day, at the children’s new school, an instructor charged with protecting the students’ welfare notices a bruise on the shoulder of the eldest Gheorghiu daughter, Elia (Vanessa Ceban). The administrator takes swift action, and before Mihai and Lisbet can fully grasp what’s happening, their children—including their infant, who’s still breastfeeding—are whisked into foster homes. Their struggle to reunite their family involves risky twists and a great deal of frustrating bureaucracy.

Stan and Reinsve in FjordCourtesy of Neon

Unless you know Norway’s judicial system, you might be tempted to wonder: Could one family really be broken up that fast, with so little evidence? Mungiu’s premise seems somewhat far-fetched, intensified for dramatic reasons, though it’s worth noting that his script is based on a real-life case in Norway. And recently, in the U.S., Child Protective Services interviewed the children of former Secretary of Transportation Pete Buttigieg, separating the children from their fathers for 24 hours, after receiving a tip alleging that they were at risk. The report was proved false, but the incident

shows how easily a system designed to protect kids might be manipulated.

Regardless, the plausibility of *Fjord*'s premise is academic in the context of the performances given by Stan and Reinsve. Reinsve (so terrific in 2025's *Sentimental Value*) is resolutely unglamorous here, a dutiful wife and mother decked out in dowdy clothes. But her distress over the loss of her children crosses the planes of her face like a muted shadow; you sense some anger beneath that meek veneer. And Stan, who is Romanian American, gives layers of complexity to Mihai as a father figure. He clearly loves his kids, but he also has a temper. Stan doesn't make Mihai easy to read, just as the movie around him doesn't offer any easy conclusions.

Yet amid all the child-custody drama *Fjord* lays before us, a subplot involving the deepening friendship between Elia and a neighbor couple's daughter, Noora (Henrikke Lund-Olsen), ends up being the film's most powerful and moving element. These two young teenagers aren't just navigating a new friendship; they're exploring feelings that may or may not be the roots of romantic love. Sometimes kids tell us what we need to know about life, even if it's not always the lesson we expect or want. And sometimes they steal a movie away from the grownups. *Fjord*, perhaps unbeknownst even to the man who made it, really belongs to them.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/01/fjord-review/

Entertainment | Television

Tip Toe Is a Harrowing Melodrama of Queerness and Masculinity in a World Gone Mad

Alan Cumming, left, and David Morrissey in Tip ToeStarz

Tip Toe refuses to be misunderstood. Premiering Oct. 2 on Starz, the British miniseries from *Queer as Folk* creator and *Doctor Who* reviver Russell T Davies set its stakes as high as the lamppost from which Alan Cumming's character is seen hanging, dead, just outside his home, in the very first scene. Reminders of this awful outcome open each episode, preceding flashbacks that take us through the escalation of tensions between Cumming's Leo Struthers and his next-door neighbor, Clive Goss (David Morrissey), over the course of just 10 days. Scripty speechifying and a finale that strains believability notwithstanding, *Tip Toe* is, in its unabashed melodrama, a harrowing *cri de coeur* about masculinity in crisis and queer liberation reversed.

Leo and Clive have a few things in common. Both pushing 60, the men have been sharing a wall in outwardly identical Manchester rowhouses for 14 years. They've also both, when we meet them, hit

rough patches in life. Clive, an electrician, is having trouble finding enough work to support a family that includes touchy 16-year-old George (Jackson Connor) and 25-year-old Saul (Joseph Evans), who assists his dad on jobs but isn't exactly earning the kind of money that would enable him to move out. As gossip swirls that he's cheated on her, Clive's wife, Marie (Pooky Quesnel), constantly berates him. Meanwhile, Leo's longtime partner, Curtis (Charlie Condou), has left him for a woman. Not only is he unmoored in his personal life, overrelying on his indulgent best friend, Stephanie (Elizabeth Berrington); he's also struggling to manage Spit & Polish, the bar in Manchester's gay nightlife district that he and Curtis used to run together.

Alan Cumming in Tip ToeStarz

Early one morning, Leo chases after an anonymous hookup who has just absconded with his laptop—only to find himself locked out of his house in his underwear. Clive reluctantly lets him in to call Stephanie for a spare key, making clear all the while that Leo's lifestyle disgusts him and that he's uncomfortable having his neighbor around his sons, one underage and the other a musclebound Adonis. The thing is, Clive's kids are nowhere near as innocent as he thinks. And he's drawn further out of his comfort zone when Leo, against his better judgment, hires Clive and Saul to fix some wiring at Spit & Polish. The first sign of worlds perilously colliding is when a bar employee recognizes Saul from OnlyFans.

An unsubtle but rhetorically effective montage of Leo and the Gosses, each in separate rooms, indulging in their preferred forms of pornography, reveals both the secrets they're keeping from each other and the loneliness they share.

While *Tip Toe* spends time with all of these characters, Leo is its protagonist. And he's an admirably imperfect one, charming and fundamentally kind but also pugnacious, prone to exaggeration, self-centered enough to earn Stephanie's accusation that he doesn't really value women. (She, in turn, shows glimpses of the J.K. Rowling-style transphobia that seems to afflict British feminists more than most.) His bar functions as a portal into the lives of less privileged members of the queer and trans communities, from his old, flamboyant, gender-nonconforming friend and unrequited admirer, Melba (Paul Rhys), to a 20-something trans bartender (Iz Hesketh), who's calling herself Zee as she deliberates on a permanent female name—and who dodges transphobic violence daily. The question of whether the visibility Leo's generation fought so hard to win has backfired, making them all easy targets, haunts the series.

David Morrissey in Tip ToeStarz

Davies recently raged against the homophobia of the early AIDS crisis in the searing period piece *It's a Sin* and looked queasily

ahead to a dystopian future in the sci-fi family drama *Years & Years*. *Tip Toe* unites their themes to complete a sort of trilogy, combining the anxieties of LGBTQ people, intrafamilial alienation, economic strife, the social-media panopticon, and an overarching sense of doom into a fire sermon against our toxic present. That it shares its Manchester setting with the far breezier, Y2K-era *Queer as Folk* underlines just how much that community's outlook has changed in a quarter-century. And the fact that Cumming's phenomenal performance is airing concurrently in the U.S. with *The Traitors: New Blood*, which he hosts with high-camp aplomb and an androgynous glam wardrobe, highlights the cognitive dissonance of a society where queerness is embraced—by everyone except the sizable faction that actively hates it. More than just Leo's antagonist, Clive is an avatar for straight masculinity in crisis, desperately vulnerable but too terrified of showing emotion to say so. Morrissey captures that tightness of that bind. Devalued at home and work, he dabbles in conspiracy theories and marinates in videos of "real deaths." His story can feel like an adult *Adolescence*.

Tip Toe also calls to mind other recent series (*BEEF*, too many reality shows about feuding neighbors) and films (*Eddington*, *Three Billboards Outside Ebbing, Missouri*) that translate current political and social fault lines into tête-à-tête conflicts. On both sides of the Atlantic, storytellers are trying to understand the hateful tenor of the contemporary public sphere by distilling it down to its simplest, me-against-you form. The difference here is that, although Leo and other characters are shown to have healthy senses of humor, *Tip Toe* itself doesn't share those titles' tone of black-comic absurdity. It isn't a funny show. Sometimes its seriousness veers into stridency. I didn't find the abrupt escalation to Leo's death particularly convincing.

Yet, as in *It's a Sin* and *Years & Years*, it's the incandescent clarity of Davies' anger and fear that make *Tip Toe* powerful. For all the dumbed-down dialogue we get from streamers worried they'll lose

distracted viewers unless someone on screen recaps the plot every five minutes, it's rare to hear characters plainly state things like: "History tells us one thing—that blood and fire and retribution always happen. And right now it's coming for us." When Stephanie confesses her worry that she'll die in 30 years without living to see the pendulum of progress swing society out of what she calls a "new Dark Age," I suspect she's speaking for a lot of people. Too often in fiction (which this is, despite ending title cards that purport to update us on the characters' lives post-Leo), social commentary is inoculated with optimism or couched in irony. In its unblinking earnestness, *Tip Toe*'s melodrama accesses a truth that transcends any shortcomings of its plot.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/01/tip-toe-review-starz/

Entertainment | Television

Omar Sy on *Lupin* Season 4 and His 'Stunned' Reaction to the Louvre Heist

Emmanuel Guimier—Netflix

This article originally appeared in TIME France; click here to read it in French.

A door opens. The 6-foot-3 actor is sitting on a large leather sofa.

His eyes are bright, his smile infectious despite the French team's World Cup defeat, from which he's still recovering. "I feel like *m'être fait 'mêler*,' as we say in the neighborhood when 10 guys jump you," he says. "But if I'm complaining about the World Cup like it's a major misfortune, it means things aren't too bad." It's summer when we meet; he's just arrived at the studios in La Plaine Saint-Denis to promote the fourth season of *Lupin*, the series that saw him explode into global view, in the guise of a gentleman thief who, this time, faces off against a copycat.

The actor has reached a milestone by elevating the program—which he co-produces with his company Carrousel Studios—to the rank of the most-watched non-English language series in the world on Netflix.

It all started with a hunch. A few years ago, alongside director Louis Leterrier, the French duo sensed a great opportunity. “At the time, in France, Netflix was still a somewhat unclear thing,” he says. “But based on the United States, we knew perfectly well that the series would be watched all over the world. We simply said to ourselves: let's make a show that does France proud.” The bet paid off, close to hundreds of millions of views later, all without ever having taken a single drama class. “It also comes down to the people you meet; that's what I love most about this job.”

Having already appeared in the blockbusters *X-Men* and *Jurassic World*, he will soon be seen on posters for the next *Ocean's Eleven*, directed by Bradley Cooper, whom he met nearly 10 years ago on a film set and who has since become a close friend—the story of his life.

Netflix for TIME France

TIME France: What aspects of yourself do you see in Assane Diop, the elusive thief you play on *Lupin*?

OMAR SY: I don't know if there are similarities between us. But there are many things I envy, admire, and like about him. That elusiveness—the fact that he's always where you least expect him. He uses every means at his disposal. He has a bit of an aikido quality: he takes what others consider a weakness and turns it into a strength. I also like his way of dispensing justice. Even though he's a thief, he has this desire to right wrongs, a Robin Hood-like quality. And then there's his panache, his lightheartedness, his playfulness…

We see you a lot at times, then you disappear. Is that necessary for your well-being?

Yes, I work in a creative field, and creativity feeds on life. You can't create if you are constantly on. Otherwise, it becomes industrial. I need to go back to living, to feeling the strong emotions that shape you, define you, and then inspire you to express things. And that's, that's happens off-set… You have to take a break, to recapture a bit of and ask yourself: "Where am I in my life? What moves me? What do I want to express?"

How did you react to the Louvre heist a few months ago, which echoed the series so strongly?

I was a bit overwhelmed by it. People were calling me and inevitably making the connection; there were all the jokes: "Give it back!" "Was it you?" It's crazy to see the extent to which much we draw inspiration from real life… and the extent to which reality can also be inspired by us in turn, like communicating vessels. I was torn between a lot of feelings.

First, immense surprise. I was truly stunned to see that the robbers were capable of trying to reproduce something reminiscent of what we did on Lupin. You tell yourself there was some inspiration, then laugh at the absurdity of the thought. But then comes a moment when you feel guilty and ask yourself, "How much of all this is my responsibility?"

Perhaps one day they'll say they were inspired by *Lupin*, just as Rédoine Faïd was by Michael Mann's *Heat* …

That's also one of the reasons why, in writing *Lupin*, we pay close attention to the moral of the story, to the values we convey. Because Assane Diop and Arsène Lupin are extraordinary characters, but they remain thieves.

Every second foreign tourist in Paris has watched the series. Do you consider yourself an ambassador for France abroad?

I felt like an ambassador for France long before *Lupin*. I've never been more of a representative of France than since I left. By living abroad, I've become even more French. Because the truth is you carry your country within you. And others see you that way. In my daily life in the United States, I'm "the Frenchman in the neighborhood." In my work, I'm "the Frenchman" in the story. I'm chosen for that reason too. Obviously, when we launched *Lupin*, we didn't expect to reach such a level of success. Today, I'm extremely proud of it. And what also touches me is that *Lupin* has rekindled the desire to read the writer Maurice Leblanc. Booksellers and publishers thank us for giving his character a new lease on life. Well… The inhabitants of Étretat [where the series was partly filmed] hate us a little bit. [laughs] It has become unbearable for them; I want to take this opportunity to apologize again.

You seem—through your choice of roles—to want to spotlight something deeper in society. Is that a fair impression?

My work is precisely that. When I say I take time to live before expressing my feelings, that's exactly why. I always have an image in my mind, which I've never articulated before: I think of the shelves at Fnac. I tell myself that in the end, when you look at all of an actor's films, there has to be a coherence. And that coherence is who I am. Yes, I always need to say something.

Sometimes it comes through a particular genre, sometimes through a character, a different story. But, deep down, there's always something I want to express. Regarding Assane Diop and *Lupin*, what interests me are injustices, the invisible people. All those who exist, but that we don't see, that we don't consider. Through this character, there's also a way to bring them to light. There's always a little Trojan horse in what I do. It's not some grand declaration. I'm not going on a crusade. But it's a driving force. No character

interests me if he doesn’t carry a message, if he has nothing to say to the world. It has to be bigger than me for me to take it on. Otherwise, I'm too timid.

This series is also a consequence of *The Intouchables,* the film that transformed your life and brought you to the United States. What do you enjoy most about this life you've been living there for the past 14 years?

It's given me a much more global perspective on the world…and on my profession. It's allowed me to take a step back with the right amount of distance. One of the most important things I've learned there is that filmmaking is also an industry. In France, it's something we sometimes find hard to admit. Yet, here too, we strive to make films that are successful and profitable. We simply talk about it less openly. Over there, that aspect is much less taboo. We can discuss it, study it, understand it. Today, this knowledge helps me as a producer. When you better understand the economic mechanisms of our profession, you can ultimately better express yourself, with even greater impact. For example, if I was able to develop certain productions, if I was able to make *Father & Soldier*, if we were able to make *Lupin*, it's also thanks to this understanding of the business. It also allowed me to develop real estate projects in Senegal.

Do you perceive France differently from a distance?

When you live in France, you feel so many things. The French are passionate; they experience their country very emotionally. Being far away sometimes allows me to observe things with more perspective. I see my American neighbors’ view of France and, ultimately, I have both perspectives now: that of someone who experiences France from the inside, and that of someone who can also observe it from the corner of the room.

You have expressed concern in the past about the state of French society. Do you feel it even more today?

It’s not that I’m more worried—I’m just as worried as ever. I have the feeling that we are going toward what I fear most: a France that is deeply fractured at every level. A France where bridges are becoming more and more difficult to build. Not impossible, mind you, but much more complicated.

Has the idea of "vivre-ensemble" eroded?

It's an overused term. "Le vivre-ensemble" has been used so much, so politically co-opted by both sides… It no longer really means what it should. We've ended up making it lose its meaning.

Your filmmakers and friends Olivier Nakache and Éric Toledano recently made a film in which the *banlieue* of the 1980s were less fractured. Did you feel that was the case for you as well?

When I was a child in Trappes, I didn't have that feeling of division. That doesn't mean everything was great, but we were together. I didn't feel that there were divides between people, like today, where you sometimes feel like you have to cross a river to meet someone. I didn't feel that. There were shared spaces. Of course, there was already racism; I've never had any trouble saying it. And I continue to say it, it's real. But to truly understand it, you have to be Black or Arab in France. We've always experienced it. It's just that today, there's a different intensity. And above all, there is another way to express it… and to experience it.

We're a few months away from the presidential election, and the National Rally is leading in the polls. What does that tell you?

It goes along with everything I've been saying and it confirms the concerns I've been expressing for a long time. We're heading towards a France that's asking itself a lot of questions. And giving itself the wrong answers.

Do you know who you'll vote for in April 2027?

It's still quite unclear. Like many French people, I'm lost; it's been a while since we've had any innovative proposals… On the other hand, I know who I won't vote for.

Is it a delicate matter for you to express your views on the presidential election while living in the United States, or do you feel you have the right to do so?

I feel totally entitled to do so because I am French. France allows French citizens living abroad to vote. So, if my vote exists, it means my voice counts. The day they decide that French citizens abroad should no longer vote, then we'll talk about it again. But today, I have that right. I remain concerned about what is happening in my country. The fact of living elsewhere does not make me a foreigner.

What do you say to those who use that argument against you?

The simple fact that some people question my feelings about France, that I can express my opinion about the country, is clearly racism. It's not that I'm abroad that’s the problem; it's that I'm Black. When people tell me, “You should thank France”— why should I thank France more than anyone else? If everyone is supposed to thank France, then everyone should thank it in the same way. Why is this injunction directed more at me? That's also a form of racism.

I'm often told I'm ungrateful. That because I live abroad, I shouldn't criticize France or have a negative opinion. But what are they all

doing all the time?

You arrived in the United States during Barack Obama's presidency. Now, Donald Trump is in his second term, and there too you live in a troubled society…

The world is troubled, the world is asking itself questions… We are part of that world. I've seen the difference, I still see it, but I don't have the right to vote because I'm not American, and therefore, I can’t legitimately speak on the subject.

You've said that you experience more racism in France than in the United States…

Of course, and in a very real way. There are acts that are punishable by law in the United States that aren't here. In France, we still see things occur without provoking the same reactions. Therefore, in my opinion, there is a different level of legal protection. And there is also a difference in behavior. Some attitudes that are still accepted here would be much harder to find there.

In recent months, there's been the Epstein affair, and, in France, scandals surrounding after-school programs are piling up. As a father of five, are you worried?

What worries me is how late we're discovering things about our children. What strikes me most is the density of the silence. How is the silence so pervasive and, at the same time, so opaque? How could so much have remained hidden for so long? How could we have taken so long to understand what was happening around our children? And I sometimes have the feeling we're fighting the wrong battles. We debate certain issues endlessly… while others, much more serious, are almost relegated to the background. I believe all parents everywhere are asking themselves questions today that our parents never asked. Sending a child to summer

camp—if so, where? Enrolling them in an extracurricular activity? And so on.

When you were growing up, you didn’t need to worry about the climate, the impact of artificial intelligence on employment, or pensions.

But there's another difference: we knew less. This kind of ignorance also protected us, to a certain extent. In our society today, children are much more aware of the gravity of the world they live in. And especially of the consequences this can have on their own future. Us, we felt that anything was possible. The future was a blank page on which we could write whatever we wanted. Today, they already feel that there are limits in place in many areas.

Do you talk to them about it?

A lot. And what's really surprising is that they're perfectly conscious of all this. But they're not afraid. That's actually what gives me hope. I have the feeling that our children are just waiting for one thing: to take the reins. When I listen to them, I understand that they're looking at us and thinking: "You've messed everything up. You're incompetent. Now, let us do it.” I'm counting on them.

Will AI replace you on screen at some point?

That's impossible! [laughs] I don’t think it will replace actors of my generation—if it ever does manage to replace actors, which I don’t believe it will. On the other hand, it’s an extremely powerful tool that’s evolving so fast that by the time we finish this conversation and your article is published, something new will already be out there!

But are you worried about damage to the craft of filmmaking? Many people in Hollywood have spoken up on this subject.

Artificial intelligence must remain a tool in the service of creation. Not a tool that creates in place of creators. When I look at what it produces on its own, it doesn't interest me. Because what moves us in a work of art is precisely what belongs to humanity: the soul. And that soul, artificial intelligence doesn't have it.

How long will this last? Its deployment and its advances are happening every day…

There's no point fighting something that's already underway. It's already part of our jobs. From this point on, the real question is no longer: how do we stop it? But rather: how do we regulate it? How do we protect jobs? How do we support those whose jobs will disappear? How do we embrace this movement? It's exactly the same as when Netflix arrived. At the time, many thought it would kill cinema. Today, we clearly see that the two coexist. Because nobody wants to see cinema disappear. So we've found a balance. With AI, it's the same thing.

Our colleagues at TIME in the United States ranked you among the 100 most influential people in the world in 2021. Do you manage to stay grounded?

I do what I can to stay grounded. And anyway, when you're not grounded, you're not even aware of it. So I'm not the best person to answer that.

Sometimes people project their own struggles onto you. Is it exhausting to be seen as a symbol?

When someone projects something onto me, they're mainly projecting the image they have of me. It's their story. Not mine. I don't belong to anyone. I'm part of their imagination, but it doesn't belong to me. When you're an actor, you quickly come to understand one essential thing: people aren't always talking to you; they're talking to the image they've constructed of you. Once you

understand that, you sleep much better. Otherwise, you go crazy. You can't live according to what everyone expects of you.

You have often spoken out on issues of migration and police violence. Is this a way of giving meaning to your fame?

When I speak out on certain social issues, it's not because I wake up in the morning thinking, "Today, I'm going to defend this or that cause." It doesn't work like that. I'm given a microphone. If the subject resonates with me, then I respond. If not, I don't respond. It's as simple as that. When you ask me about France, about certain realities I'm familiar with, then yes, I have something to say. But it's never a pose. It's never a strategy, much less an obligation.

It's often said, "Omar Sy is a socially engaged actor." But let's look at the questions asked of other actors and those asked of me. They're never the same.

Many don't want to step outside the promotional framework; it's a choice.

Yes, perhaps they don't want to express themselves, but above all, they're never asked certain questions. It doesn't matter which films they're promoting.

Conversely, you openly express your feelings and opinions on these subjects.

To understand my feelings, you first have to ask me questions. People want to hear my perspective on a topic, and by constantly asking me these questions, it makes me seem like someone who reacts to current events and takes a stand. It's the microphone they're holding out to me that ho creates this… You have to look at how I'm approached.

With some actors, you can promote the exact same type of film. And yet, we're not steered toward the same topics. Before I've even

answered, there's already a projection: He's Black, Muslim, he comes from the *banlieue*. And in that, too, it's a form of discrimination.

Talking about the *banlieue* also means talking about your own journey and your story. It's not without reason…

But there are other actors from the *banlieues*; it's just that they don't represent the archetype. People assume they don't come from there. But they do, just as much as I do. At the same level of notoriety—I'm not going to name names, but I know others who grew up in the same neighborhoods, yet who are left alone on these subjects.

Your eldest daughter was born in Trappes, your youngest in Los Angeles—that pretty much sums up this life, almost elastic.

Yes, my eldest daughter was born in Trappes, on my 23rd birthday. In the same hospital, with the same doctor who delivered me. And my youngest child was born in Los Angeles. When I look at it, I think it tells a life story. I like to laugh about it. I often say there's the Trappes girl, the Versailles kid, and the Californian. It also shows that you can evolve without denying your roots. Evolving doesn't mean changing. You can go very far without losing your anchor and your roots. It's important to pass that on to my children, because that's how I was raised.

Despite the money and the change of scenery, has your current life retained some elements of your previous one? A lot has changed in my life; just look at this dressing room, it's an apartment. [laughs] In the beginning, there were 15 of us in a dressing room half the size. But the essentials haven't changed. I think that as you get older, you even return to certain things more. When you lose a parent, certain values become even more important. But I refuse to spend my time analyzing myself; the only time I do that is during interviews when I'm asked questions I

never ask myself. Otherwise, I still enjoy very simple things like going to the market, cooking, and walking in nature.

Is it possible to make friends in Hollywood?

When I arrived in the United States, I was 34. At that age, your life is already built. You have your friends. You're a father, you have a wife. You don't go to the United States to make friends. You make some anyway, but it's not the primary goal. And then, there are a lot of clichés about California. You often hear that everything is fake. Honestly, I haven’t found that to be so. I'd even say that there's sometimes more transparency than in France. Over there, people might take a little longer before inviting you to their home. On the other hand, once they do, it's sincere. Here, sometimes you get invited to dinner very quickly, and then, two years later, the person pretends not to know you anymore on the street. [laughs]

Do you ever wonder what other path you could have taken?

Honestly, very rarely. But I believe that, one way or another, I would have built a life similar to this one, on a different scale... Not with the same encounters, not with the same resources. But I believe my curiosity would have led me to a fairly similar existence. Today, I live on three continents. I think that, even without this job, I probably would have lived on at least two. Because that's just how I am. I've always wanted to see other places, to discover. To build several things at once.

You were passionate about science, and you earned a technical baccalaureate specializing in heating and air conditioning.

My plan was very simple: I had a cousin who was an architect working in Senegal. I wanted to join his business, installing air-conditioning systems on his construction sites. That was my plan. In that life, I would probably have, for example, split my time between France and Senegal.

In your book *Viens, on se parle,* you say that your life is a merry-go-round and that someone will tell you it’s time to get off. Is that still the case?

This profession is a bit like that. Every film is a ride on the merry-go-round. And we all work so we can go on another ride. I know very well that one day, someone will tell me the merry-go-round is closed. I've been aware of that for a long time. And precisely because I know that, I'm already ready. That's also why I'm developing other projects. Paris Basketball [of which he is a co-owner]. Production. Things in Senegal, projects in agriculture. I always want to learn and discover other worlds.

And if that happened, where would you start?

Everything I just mentioned, but I would still find a way to stay involved in filmmaking. I might not be in front of the camera anymore, but I’d be somewhere else. Because this world is now part of my life. I need it. Sports work the same way. When I watch a basketball game, I find what I love about cinema: the emotion, the story, the suspense, the sense of connection. I think the common thread in everything I do has become very clear: I want to bring people together, create bonds, build bridges, unite people. When a project makes that possible, you’ll find me nearby!

Translated by TIME

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/07/omar-sy-lupin-season-4/

Health

- **What to Say to Someone Who Is Dying, According to Hospice Workers**
  There’s no perfect script. Showing up matters more.
- **Why That Mucus in Your Throat Won’t Go Away**
  Experts explain what causes postnasal drip, why antihistamines don’t always help, and how to get relief from mucus.

Health | Time to Talk

What to Say to Someone Who Is Dying, According to Hospice Workers

Photo-Illustration by TIME (Source Image: Peter Dazeley—Getty Images)

Sydney Mishkin's father had Stage IV sarcoma for seven years. In the weeks before he died, she kept trying to figure out what she still hadn't told him. She searched through their old texts and listened to his voicemails. At night, she lay awake reviewing their entire relationship, desperate to identify the words she might one day regret leaving unsaid.

Eventually, she realized there weren't any. A week before her father passed away, Mishkin told him: "There's nothing I've ever wanted to say and didn't." He was very weak, but he managed to answer: "I could not ask for a better daughter." Within days, he was no longer able to speak.

The exchange was deeply meaningful—but also bittersweet. Mishkin worried she had said too much or made her father feel obligated to summon the energy for a profound response. "How do

you sum up a lifetime of loving somebody into a sentence or two?” she says.

The answer, according to people who spend their careers alongside the dying, is that you don’t have to. There are words that can bring comfort, invite honesty, and help both of you find peace. But there’s no perfect script—and your presence likely matters more than anything you manage to say.

Don't wait for the right moment

When people ask Dr. Ira Byock whether they should make the trip to see a seriously ill friend or relative, he answers with a question: “Would you go to the funeral?”

Almost always, they say yes—of course they would. "Well, go now,” says Byock, a palliative care physician in Montana and author of *The Four Things That Matter Most*. You'll say generous things at the memorial about what a remarkable person your friend was. Better to say them while she can hear you. "It's much more fun to say those nice things when somebody is alive," Byock says. If you can only make one trip, make it this one.

Hadley Vlahos, a hospice nurse and author of *The In-Between: Unforgettable Encounters During Life's Final Moments*, regularly hears from families who want her to alert them when the end is near. Her answer never changes. "You need to come right now," she says. "Everyone looks for this perfect time, and they always think that there's gonna be more time." In hospice, the opposite is true: Beginning care earlier leaves more time for meaningful conversations. "You don't want to wait until they're in a coma," she says.

The window for a real back-and-forth closes before most families expect it to. Start when the diagnosis arrives, says Dr. Kate Brazzale, chief medical officer of Empath Health, which operates

Florida’s largest nonprofit hospice network. "Don't wait, because the person that's dying needs to be able to respond and speak," she says. "You need to get all those things out of the way. Towards the end, the person that's dying may not be able to speak, and it's not very fair to unload on them at that point."

Sometimes there's no window at all. Christine Davies, director of spiritual care at Robert Wood Johnson University Hospital, has been a hospital chaplain for more than 25 years. She’s present for expected deaths after long illnesses, as well as sudden ones. "We may not even have the opportunity to say these last words, and so we have to say them all of the time," she says. "Knowing no day is promised makes it all the more sacred."

Lead with the obvious—and then let them talk

Once you're in the room, you don't need to read from a prepared statement. But on the drive or flight over, Byock suggests, think about what's most obvious to you, and open with that: *“It's really good to see you. I've been thinking about you so much. It's just so good to be with you.”*

From there, say the thing you assume they already know. "I so value our relationship. You've been so important to me," Byock offers as an example. Then get specific, the way you might at a celebration of life—without going overboard. “You've always been there for me.” “You're one of the funniest people I've ever known.” “What a remarkable parent you've been.”

"Notice I'm just saying the most obvious things," he says. "If the person means enough for you to travel and see them, they are important to you. This is a time to say it out loud."

Then shift the focus to how they’re feeling. Byock's go-to: “How are you doing physically—but also, how are you doing within

yourself?” "That phrase is one that we don't hear very often, but people tend to know what I'm asking," he says.

If their answer surprises you—or you don’t quite understand it—don’t rush to reassure them or claim to know how they feel. Brazzale suggests three words instead: “Help me understand.” Unlike “I know how you feel,” which few people can truthfully say to someone who is dying, the phrase invites them to share more. “It opens the door,” she says.

She also asks patients directly whether they're afraid—one of her most effective questions, though she notes it lands differently coming from a physician than from a daughter. What surfaces is rarely just fear of physical pain. It's fear of the unknown, of losing control, and of what their loved ones will have to endure.

The conversation can also turn toward the past. Davies uses an approach called life review, inviting people to reflect on the experiences that shaped a person’s life—the highs and lows, regrets and celebrations, important relationships, and the legacy they’ll leave. Looking back can include plenty of laughter: Families might retell favorite stories or swap inside jokes. “I have no idea what they’re referencing,” she says, “but it’s almost like they’re recounting the stories.”

Say the four things that matter most

Decades ago, Byock started teaching patients, students, and families that there are four things worth saying to someone before you're forced to say goodbye. Put them in your own words if you like, but here’s how he phrases it: “Please forgive me. I forgive you. Thank you. I love you.”

The first two are there because no relationship is perfect. "Within the history of almost all relationships, there are times of misunderstandings, hurt feelings, anger—sometimes real

transgressions," Byock says. You can be specific about what you're asking forgiveness for, or you can keep it general. "Dad, please forgive me, because I know I haven't been the perfect son," Byock offers as an example. "And I forgive you for the times that I felt misunderstood and harshly judged by you."

In conversations between parents and children, Byock suggests adding an expression of pride. A parent might say, "I'm so proud to be your dad." "Who else on the planet can tell your child how proud you are to be their mom or their dad?" he says. "That is a gift that keeps on giving." A son or daughter can reverse it: "I'm so proud to be your daughter." When the person dying is young, Byock focuses especially on this kind of affirmation.

It's a good conversation to have even if no one is sick. Byock had it with his own mother in October 2003, prompted by the galleys of his book. They sat together, and he said nearly all of it, including thanking her for being his most steadfast supporter. There were tears, and they talked for an hour. A month later, his mother died suddenly of an undiagnosed heart condition. "I miss her," he says. "But there was nothing critically important left unsaid between my mom and me."

Reassure them about what they're leaving behind

Much of what frightens people at the end isn't about them. It's about everyone else.

Vlahos sees it most clearly with the matriarch of a family—the woman who called all the kids every Sunday, who hosted every holiday. She describes a patient who seemed to be holding on, and whose sons finally said the thing she needed to hear to pass peacefully: "I promise I'm still going to call Dad every Sunday. I promise we're still going to have Christmas."

Vlahos remembers a patient who was told, “I promise to make sure your grandson knows you.” "I think that matters a lot more than people think," she says.

Then there are the reassurances almost no one thinks to offer. Brazzale says patients who are declining may worry about soiling themselves, losing their dignity, or being moved out of their home at the end. What she’d want to hear, she says, is this: “We’re going to keep you clean. We’re going to keep you safe. We’re going to keep you comfortable.” If dying at home is the plan, family can add: “We’re going to keep you home.” “There’s something about cleanliness that resonates with people,” she says. “It sounds simple, but it’s quite powerful.”

In the final phase of dying—a period Barbara Karnes, a hospice nurse and educator since the 1970s, calls labor—many people become nonresponsive. “What we watchers can do is talk as if they can hear us,” she says. Hearing is thought to be one of the last senses to fade, so continue as though your loved one may still hear you. Brazzale offers similar advice: If you run out of things to say, choose a beautiful book and read aloud. She also suggests keeping your touch light—holding a hand rather than hugging, which can be jarring.

Karnes recommends making room for both private goodbyes and a shared gathering. First, have each person go into the room alone, sit down, hold their loved one’s hand, and talk about the relationship. “You can speak from your heart and say everything you want and need to say,” she says, even if the person is nonresponsive. Then come back together: Gather around the bed, put on dad’s favorite music, let the kids in, put the dog on the bed. After the death, before you call the funeral home, let everyone go in alone one last time if they want, Karnes suggests.

Skip the platitudes—and don't try to fix it

Some phrases are worth retiring entirely. At the top of the list: “I know how you feel.”

"How could we possibly know how they feel? We haven't died," Brazzale says.

Davies advises against what she calls spiritual platitudes, like “everything happens for a reason” and “God needed another angel.” "That can be really harmful to the people that are hearing it," she says. Such phrases try to impose meaning onto someone’s suffering or force an unbearable moment to feel better, she says, rather than leaving room for the person’s actual emotions.

And avoid any framing that treats dying as quitting, Brazzale recommends. She has watched families push patients through a 10th round of chemotherapy so no one can say they gave up. "There's going to be a point at which they die, and you should never frame it that they gave up," she says. "What a terrible thing, that 100% of the human race is just going to quit."

Platitudes often spring from the urge to talk someone out of what they’re feeling. But if a dying person says, “This sucks,” you don’t need to insist otherwise. “You can be like, ‘Yeah, you know what, it does,’” Vlahos says. Making room for that honesty also helps relieve the dying person of another burden: managing everyone else’s emotions. Loved ones rarely mean to put them in that position, Vlahos says, but she sees it happen often.

That means silence is a legitimate option. Vlahos believes many of these important final encounters don’t happen because people feel pressure to find the right words. “Sometimes the right thing to say is nothing—to just let someone talk,” she says.

Davies gives her chaplaincy students a five-word rule: “Show up and shut up.” Her interns sometimes come to her surprised that a grieving family hugged them, because they felt they hadn’t done

anything. “No—you bore witness to what they were going through,” she tells them. “‘You were there in the hardest moment, and you didn’t fill it with words. You allowed for the silence to take place.’ We try not to cheer people up, because there’s no cheering up.”

You don’t have to hold yourself together, either. Vlahos would far rather someone show up and cry with her than stay away. Brazzale once made the same point, half-jokingly, to her own children. She initially told them she didn’t want anyone crying at her bedside when she died—then reconsidered. “Actually, you’d better shed a few tears,” she told them. “Because that shows I mattered.”

The person who is dying is grieving, too, Brazzale says. Trying to protect each other by hiding that sadness can create distance at a moment when time together is especially precious. “Don’t be tiptoeing around one another for fear of hurting each other’s feelings,” she says, “because the scars left behind will be that much deeper.”

---

https://time.com/article/2026/08/05/what-to-say-to-someone-who-is-dying/

Health | medicine

Why That Mucus in Your Throat Won’t Go Away

Keeproll—Getty Images

It’s hard to concentrate on a conversation when you’re busy trying to discreetly clear whatever’s stuck in your throat. If you have persistent postnasal drip, you know how quickly that sensation returns—and how little relief another allergy pill or round of gargling might bring.

For people who speak for a living, it can be especially frustrating. “It could be very disruptive when you’re on the phone, when you’re in meetings,” says Dr. Matt Hershcovitch, an ENT and sinus specialist in Burbank, Calif. “You can’t speak for more than 30 seconds without having to cough and clear your throat.”

You don’t have to resign yourself to a lifetime of apologizing for your cough. We asked experts what could be behind that lingering feeling of mucus in your throat, why your go-to remedies might not help, and how to get relief.

What’s driving the drip?

Environmental allergies and chronic rhinosinusitis—ongoing inflammation in the nose and sinuses—are among the most common causes, says Dr. Florence Hsu, a Yale Medicine allergist and immunologist. Inflammation can increase mucus production, sending drainage down the back of your throat.

And having sailed through childhood without allergies doesn’t rule them out now. “Your allergies and sensitivity do change throughout your life,” Hershcovitch says.

Your nose can also react to things you aren’t allergic to. Smoke, strong smells, spicy food, and changing weather can trigger what’s called nonallergic rhinitis, Hershcovitch says. Your nasal lining becomes overly reactive, producing extra mucus.

Another possibility is reflux, which can cause a sensation of mucus in the throat even without the heartburn people tend to associate with it, Hsu says.

And sometimes, the feeling that something is stuck doesn’t mean there’s a stubborn blob you need to dislodge. Irritation from drainage or reflux can leave your throat feeling inflamed, Hershcovitch says, creating what doctors call a “globus sensation”: the feeling of a lump or something lingering there even when nothing is physically blocking it.

Why antihistamines aren’t always the answer

An allergy pill can help with some symptoms, but it won’t address every possible reason your throat feels coated in gunk.

Antihistamines target the effects of histamine, a chemical involved in allergic reactions, Hsu explains. Even when allergies are

involved, other parts of the inflammatory response may require a different treatment, such as a steroid nasal spray.

Sometimes, antihistamines can even make things worse. “Antihistamines can also be drying, leading to thicker mucus that is more difficult to clear,” she says.

What you can try at home

Saline nasal rinses—using a squeeze bottle or neti pot—can help wash out mucus and allergens, Hsu says. If you’re preparing the rinse yourself, use distilled, sterile, or previously boiled and cooled water, not water straight from the tap, and follow the device’s cleaning instructions.

For allergy-related symptoms, a steroid nasal spray such as Flonase or Nasacort is another option, Hsu says. But check the label: “Not all nasal sprays are the same,” Hershcovitch says. Steroid sprays are different from decongestants such as Afrin, which he advises using for no more than two or three days. Longer use can cause rebound congestion, leaving you stuffier.

It’s also worth looking for triggers at home and work, including dust mites and pet dander, Hsu says. To help reduce airborne allergens, Hershcovitch suggests using an air purifier and keeping its filters clean.

When to stop playing drugstore roulette

If this has been going on for years—or keeps persisting despite over-the-counter treatment—make an appointment with an allergist or ENT. Hsu says allergy testing can help identify triggers; an ENT may use a thin camera to examine your nasal passages after applying numbing spray.

What happens next depends on what your doctors find. You might need a different medication, treatment for reflux, or, in some cases, a procedure to address a structural problem or blocked sinuses, Hershcovitch says.

Some symptoms are a reason to get checked promptly instead of continuing to try home remedies. These include bloody or one-sided drainage or facial pain, Hershcovitch says. Hsu also flags loss of smell or taste, complete nasal blockage, or new wheezing or breathing trouble.

If you’re wondering why this suddenly became your problem, Hershcovitch offers some reassurance: “This is a very manageable one,” he says. “It’s not something you did or didn’t do.”

---

https://time.com/article/2026/09/29/postnasal-drip-mucus-throat/

Ideas

- **Why the U.S. Must Simultaneously Compete—and Cooperate—With China on AI**
  “We need to outcompete China on the technology itself, while also working with China on addressing the risks posed by AI,” writes Gina Raimondo.
- **The Cornell 7 Case Demands More Than Outrage**
  “National outrage helps shake people up enough to pay attention,” writes Tarana Burke. “But culture won't shift just because we change laws and elect better politicians.”

Ideas | AI

Why the U.S. Must Simultaneously Compete—and Cooperate—With China on AI

Gina Raimondo was the 40th secretary of commerce and the 75th governor of Rhode Island. She is currently the co-chair and CEO of RAISE US.

President Xi Jinping and President Donald Trump at the White House on September 24, 2026 in Washington, DC.Andrew Harnik—Getty Images

Gina Raimondo was the 40th secretary of commerce and the 75th governor of Rhode Island. She is currently the co-chair and CEO of RAISE US.

Last week, President Donald Trump hosted Chinese President Xi Jinping at the White House. It's their second meeting this year, following the May summit in Beijing. This visit, the stakes were even higher.

We have learned about security incidents from nearly every major AI company, American and Chinese, built on both open and closed models. The leading AI labs are openly debating whether to pace

their frontier model development, and the government is working out what role it plays in that decision.

I spent four years as Secretary of Commerce focused intently on America's economic, technological, and security competition with China—instituting first-of-its-kind export controls on the sale of chips and chipmaking equipment to China to protect our national security, and leading implementation of the CHIPS Act to onshore chip manufacturing. I also created the AI Safety Institute so we could accelerate our AI development responsibly and safely. I have sat across the table from China, and I have an understanding of how they think about AI.

I believe AI companies are right to want to pace the frontier. But we need to stay ahead of China while we pace, because a world where China leads the global AI competition threatens America's interests.

The challenge is this: We need to outcompete China on the technology itself, while also working with China on addressing the risks posed by AI. Competition and cooperation are often in tension, but the stakes are too high in this case to pick only one.

How we cooperate—while staying ahead

China has its own reasons to take AI safety seriously. The Chinese Minister of State Security recently said publicly that the greatest risk advanced AI poses to China is the risk it poses to the stability of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). Beijing is no more interested in powerful AI systems wreaking socio-political havoc than Washington is; both countries have incentives to align on certain safety standards or even just a shared understanding of AI risks. It is in neither country's interest for companies to lose control of their AI systems or for AI to be used to create bioweapons by rogue actors. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent's announcement of a possible AI dialogue with Chinese counterparts after his meeting

with Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng is a tangible sign that China sees at least some space for cooperation here.

I would argue that now is the moment to fully establish that dialogue and keep the momentum going. We should do this by convening experts from both countries. I'm well aware that we'd be foolish to trust People's Republic of China (PRC) leaders. But that doesn't mean we shouldn't try. It just means we need to develop verification mechanisms to ensure agreements work even in the absence of trust.

Even if we don't reach agreement on a shared set of standards, starting a dialogue and opening those lines of communication are critical—just as we did in 2008 during the financial crisis, when it was in our mutual benefit to coordinate. And we spent decades during the Cold War in careful, ongoing dialogue with the Soviet Union about nuclear arms control because the risks to both countries were enormous. During that time we developed zero-trust methods to verify arms control agreements even while locked in an adversarial relationship.

None of that changes the need to vigilantly and continuously update our controls as technology changes so China can't access our most sophisticated compute in ways that threaten our national security. That includes continuously updating our export controls on leading-edge chips, addressing the risks of China accessing controlled compute remotely in data centers around the world, and cracking down on diversion of technology that is controlled.

We also need to tighten remaining gaps in our semiconductor manufacturing equipment controls so China can less capably obtain tools to manufacture powerful chips at scale and service their pre-existing equipment. That work has to happen with our Dutch, Japanese, and German allies and partners who manufacture and service this chipmaking equipment.

American AI

Finally, the U.S. government should put a greater burden on the AI companies to take adversarial distillation much more seriously. Distillation—coordinated, industrial-scale efforts by AI labs to train their weaker models on the outputs of frontier models—has become a significant issue in the past year. Anthropic has attributed more than 16 million Claude exchanges to distillation campaigns, and has estimated that over 3 million of these distillation campaigns can be traced back to China's Moonshot AI (the company behind China's version of ChatGPT, Kimi) along with other Chinese AI labs like Alibaba and DeepSeek. Moonshot, for instance, was later caught forwarding user prompts to Claude to answer and feeding those answers back through Kimi.

China has certainly indigenized much of its AI stack, something Xi publicly made a priority in his Made in China 2025 plan, many years before the U.S. government was talking openly about chips or models. And China has made progress on this plan. But it is clear to many that China's most competitive models, to some degree, are ripping off American ones. American AI labs should be allocating even greater amounts of their money and compute towards finding and exposing this kind of activity so that policymakers—and the public—can adapt accordingly.

The risks and benefits of AI are enormous, something more and more Americans have come to realize as AI advances more quickly than we previously thought possible. There is much to do on AI safety at home, to ensure our society and economy are resilient to the dramatic changes AI will bring. But I also know that safe deployment of AI is only possible if we successfully manage our relationship with China—both by maintaining our technological lead and working towards collaboration.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/01/the-u-s-must-compete-and-cooperate-with-china-on-ai/

Ideas | Sexual Violence

The Cornell 7 Case Demands More Than Outrage

Tarana Burke is the founder of the Me Too movement.
Tarana Burke is the founder of the Me Too movement.

By now, most of America has heard about the young woman who says she was gang raped by fraternity brothers while she was a student at Cornell University.

The case has been dubbed the "Cornell 7" across mainstream and social media, after the seven Chi Phi members named in her recent lawsuit. The woman who filed the suit, referred to as Jane Doe, first reported her experience to Cornell campus police in November 2024. According to her lawyer, after Cornell's Title IX process, two of the seven were expelled, and the other five were suspended, sent to workshops, and assigned essays. Cornell says none of them got off with only an essay.

At the time, the Tompkins County District Attorney declined to prosecute. After public outcry, the DA issued a statement explaining that Jane Doe's original statement to police described the drug use and sex as "voluntary, conscious, and consensual." "However, recognizing that the process of healing from trauma is personal and different for every human, my office has reopened this investigation," he wrote. Now, New York Governor Kathy Hochul has appointed state Attorney General Letitia James as special prosecutor in the case.

How did the case come to light? It took The Cornell Daily Sun, the campus student newspaper, breaking the story roughly two years later for this to capture the hearts, minds, and headlines of Americans across the country. The story struck a nihilistic nerve.

This case lands squarely in a moment of massive frustration, disappointment, and anger over how the Jeffrey Epstein and Ghislaine Maxwell case was handled. New CDC data shows that nearly half of American women and one in six men have experienced some form of contact sexual violence. Based on how broad this issue is and based on how some of the most visible cases have turned out, apathy about our ability to see our way from a society steeped in rape culture to one where sexual violence is rare should come as no surprise.

As someone fully immersed in this work, even though I see a pathway forward, I understand these feelings from a very deep place in my spirit. We should be disgusted. We should be heartbroken. We should be enraged.

So what do we do with these feelings?

We provide an outpouring of support to Jane Doe and to other women who have come forward with their accounts of sexual assault, such as Kendall Francis, who took to TikTok to speak out about how her college, LSU, handled her Title IX case. According to ESPN, in July, the LSU Office of Civil Rights and Title IX found her alleged attacker, a football player, responsible for "forcible rape" and suspended him for two semesters. The player appealed and in August, Administrative Law Judge Janet Waguespack reduced his punishment to four semesters' probation, allowing him to remain on campus. The player's lawyers maintain that their client is innocent.

Again, Francis' story struck a nerve, catching the attention of East Baton Rouge District Attorney Hillar Moore, whose office is now investigating the case.

The outpouring of support matters, both so these young women can get the justice they're seeking and so survivors everywhere know that support is out here. But what many of us know is that for every

Jane Doe and Kendall Francis who reports and seeks justice, there are hundreds, if not thousands, of survivors who won't, for a lot of reasons. Chief among them is feeling alone in the fight. They aren't alone. But I'll admit it's hard to tell when spotlights dim, headlines fade, and accountability seems stifled.

As if right on cue, something else happened this week while these cases took over headlines. The Trump Administration's Department of Education altered Title IX rules, declaring that harassment has to be "severe, pervasive, and objectively offensive" *before* a school must act, that most off-campus violence falls outside a school's responsibility, and that a college survivor can be cross-examined at a live hearing by the advisor her attacker chose.

This decision landing right as the Cornell 7 case came to light is telling. It's one of the clearest illustrations of the direct line between the damage this administration has done to the fight against sexual and gender-based violence—especially among young people.

The Trump Administration's decision to make it more burdensome to file a Title IX complaint only adds to the helplessness so many survivors feel. Patriarchy protects itself the way any system of power does. It writes the rules, staffs the offices, and then leaves survivors like Jane Doe and Kendall Francis to fight for justice on their own.

Of course, it is worth remembering the challenge we collectively face isn't simply a matter of one rule or how it is applied; there are questions we must confront about where our culture has ended up. After all, these Cornell students were tweens when recordings of now-President Donald Trump leaked of him using crude language to describe how he treats women. The context may be different, but we have to ask: How far is the line between "grab 'em by the p---y" and "free p---y", the message the lawsuit says one of the Cornell 7

sent his fraternity brothers, inviting them to join in the hours-long assault on Jane Doe?

Yet, in the face of these various challenges, we must also remember: We are not helpless.

On October 15, it'll be nine years since #MeToo went viral. We're far past the hashtag, but we're still in the movement, and it's a very real, very active movement fighting tooth and nail to destroy systems that prevent justice. The answer to such systems has always been the organized power of the people those systems harm. The rage people are feeling right now, from Baton Rouge to Ithaca, can be organized and directed exactly where it's needed. That means our outrage can't be selective. It can't show up when Epstein or Cornell makes the news and disappear when the coverage moves on. Because when the next national story takes hold, there will still be students on high school and college campuses all over this country who are fundamentally unsafe.

We've made real progress in almost ten years of the MeToo movement, and lasting change will only come from constant demand. Frederick Douglass famously said: "Power concedes nothing without a demand." Black people in the civil rights era didn't wait for a government full of segregationists to find its conscience. They organized until it had no choice. Sexual and gender-based violence is solvable, but those solutions have to be demanded, and we have the numbers to demand them.

Too many survivors who stay silent believe they'd be fighting alone if they raise their voices. The CDC's most recent national survey found that nearly 80 million American adults, close to 58 million women and more than 20 million men, have experienced contact sexual violence. For some people, those are just numbers. In reality, they're a base of power: millions of people who know this trauma intimately and are primed to act.

What action against sexual violence can look like

First, you can join an organization dedicated to addressing sexual violence head-on. Several national organizations are working to bring survivors and our allies together to demand systemic change. Organizations like mine, me too. International, along with the National Women's Law Center and UltraViolet, are on the front lines organizing survivor leaders, fighting for survivors in courtrooms, and keeping people engaged on these issues. Others, like Justice for Migrant Women, Educate Us, and the National Domestic Workers Alliance, work on where sexual and gender-based violence meets immigration, domestic work, and education. The Survivor Justice Network, a coalition of organizations fighting sexual and gender-based violence from a social and political standpoint, runs the Survivors Vote campaign to organize survivors as a voting bloc. And there are countless regional and local organizations fighting this fight every day, especially local rape crisis centers, many of which are struggling.

In April 2025, the Justice Department terminated hundreds of grants worth more than $800 million, including money for victim services, and this spring $200 million meant for violence against women programs was still sitting unspent. Centers like the DC Rape Crisis Center (DCRCC), the oldest in the country, don't only provide direct services to local survivors. They take on the larger issue of sexual violence and how it's affecting the people they serve.

Next, you can use your resources well. Speakimng of DCRCC, local rape crisis centers are the first line of defense, and when students can't get support on campus, they often go looking for it at the rape crisis center in their college town. Find the survivor support organizations near you and give to them directly. It's the best way to shore up the front line so survivors can get what they need and the fight can continue.

Third, you can get active in local politics.

Ask your elected officials where they stand on sexual and gender-based violence and on legislation they can move right now, like the Survivors' Rights Restitution Act, which Rep. Ayanna Pressley introduced in September with Reps. Teresa Leger Fernández and Deborah Ross to compensate survivors whose federal rights were violated, including Epstein's survivors. Pressure them to vote accordingly, and make your support heard and understood.

Lastly, we must unite around our shared challenges. National outrage helps shake people up enough to pay attention, but culture won't shift just because we change laws and elect better politicians. People need to understand how sexual and gender-based violence shows up in their daily lives, how it intersects with the other issues they care about, and how long it stays with families, communities, and institutions. Until the whole of society sees this as an abomination, we won’t have the lasting cultural impact that makes sexual violence a rarity.

Jane Doe and Kendall Francis each refused to carry this quietly. The rest of us owe them and survivors like them more than a week of outrage.

We can let them see what it looks like to turn outrage into outcomes.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/09/the-cornell-7-case-demands-more-than-outrage/

Politics

- **What Trump Has Built**
  An interview with the President at a pivotal moment in his second term.
- **How James Talarico Made Texas Competitive Again**
  Inside one of the fiercest midterm races in the country

Politics | Donald Trump

What Trump Has Built

Donald Trump struts onto the new White House helipad, an 80,000-sq.-ft. expanse of carved granite on the South Lawn. “Can you believe this?” he says, taking in the scene, the Washington Monument rising in the distance. The President lingers over the details of the project with obvious pleasure, pointing out the gray stone imported from Italy and describing how five separate sections were fitted together, with measurements he says are precise to an eighth of an inch.

Behind him rises a bigger renovation project: the new White House ballroom, its concrete skeleton consuming the former East Wing. Lawsuits have followed the endeavor, alleging that Trump demolished the historic structure and began building its replacement without congressional authorization or the required federal reviews. He kept building anyway. Trump points to the walls, calling them “nuclear concrete” (the sort, he says, used in nuclear facilities), and describes a military complex beneath the ballroom that will plunge six stories underground. There will be five separate floors, he says, with one side made entirely of glass, 6 or 8 in. thick. He holds his hands apart to demonstrate. “The steel goes up next week.”

As we walk toward the Oval Office, Trump stops several times to inspect his handiwork. There are freshly painted doors, new gold doorknobs, the Rose Garden lawn ripped out and replaced with a Mar-a-Lago-style patio, where he now presides over dinners at what he calls the Rose Garden Club. “People say, why do you spend so much time on this?” he says. “But I find it relaxing.”

Later, he returns to the subject again. “It’s what I do best,” he muses aloud. “I say, am I a better builder or a politician?”

Photograph by Dan Winters for TIME

One can understand Trump’s fixation on his construction projects. At one of the lowest points of his presidency, he is absorbed with the physical details of a world he can remake to his liking. There is something revealing in the contrast. Here, he can still point to a wall and say how thick it should be, decide where the grass ends and the stone begins, make demands and have them fulfilled. With his presidency seemingly spinning off course, Trump has busied himself with things he can control.

Outside these gates, events have become increasingly resistant to Trump's will. The war in Iran, launched without congressional authorization and initially described by Trump as a four-to-six-week undertaking, is seven months old when we meet, with no end in sight. It has sent oil and gasoline prices soaring and convulsed the global economy. Inflationary pressures compounded by Trump's tariffs have pushed the Federal Reserve—now led by his handpicked chairman—to raise interest rates over his objections, with another hike possible before year's end. Mortgage rates have climbed to 7.5%, worsening an already punishing housing market.

The political coalition that returned Trump to power has frayed, with signs of discontent among independents, rural voters, and parts of the Latino electorate, even as his GOP base remains substantially loyal. A Reuters/Ipsos poll in September put his approval at 32%, the lowest of his political career; a recent *Wall Street Journal* survey recorded the lowest ratings of any President heading into midterm elections since 1990. Republican candidates have distanced themselves from his military actions and his deportation campaign. Voters have recoiled at his laissez-faire approach to the artificial intelligence industry and his accumulation of wealth while in office through crypto deals, thousands of disclosed stock trades, and an expanding empire of Trump-branded developments stretching from Saudi Arabia and Qatar to India and Vietnam.

Inside the Administration, senior advisers increasingly recognize that he has passed the apogee of his second-term power. Across the Republican Party, officials are preparing for the likelihood of losing the House—and perhaps the Senate—in the midterms. After two years spent almost entirely on offense, Trump may soon be forced onto defense. Democratic control of Congress would bring investigations and subpoenas, hearings, and potentially a third round of impeachment proceedings. Cabinet officials could be hauled before Congress. Trump describes the prospect in

characteristic terms. “They’ll probably go after me,” he says, “and I’ll go after them.”

Yet with so much at stake—for the country and the world, for his party and his own power—Trump can seem curiously preoccupied. During a 75-minute Oval Office interview with TIME, he was discursive and grievance-fueled, veering from the crises of his presidency to resentments old and emerging. He said he regretted appointing Neil Gorsuch, Brett Kavanaugh, and Amy Coney Barrett to the Supreme Court, after they ruled against him on tariffs, mail ballots, and birthright citizenship. “I gave them the position of a lifetime,” he said, “and they voted against me often.” On his expectation of fealty, he was unapologetic: “I do like loyalty, yeah.” Again and again, he returned to the condition of the White House itself, complaining that his predecessors had left the building in disrepair and deriding Barack Obama as someone who “doesn’t know if something’s dirty or clean.”

Gold and neoclassical flourishes in the Oval Office of the White House in Washington, D.C., May 21, 2026.Carolyn Van Houten—The New York Times/Redux

A model of President Donald Trump's proposed ballroom, in the Oval Office of the White House in Washington, D.C., Dec. 12, 2025.Doug Mills—The New York Times/Redux

Statues are pictured in the Rose Garden of the White House, Friday, Sept. 11, 2026, in Washington, D.C.Mark Schiefelbein—AP Photo

Trump dismissed widespread opposition to the rapid build-out of data centers, including among his own base, as a prescription for a poorer America. When pressed on the limits of his power, Trump left himself ample room: He would not rule out declaring a national emergency or invoking the Insurrection Act around the midterms, nor promise to refrain from bringing wrecking balls to the Kennedy Center without congressional approval. “I’m not committing to anything,” he says. “We’re going to see how it plays out in court.”

In Trump's telling, he is simply doing what has to be done, even when that means breaking foundational promises to his voters. He campaigned as a president of peace, but is now waging a war he says was necessary to prevent Iran from obtaining a nuclear weapon. He points to Venezuela, where his removal of Nicolás Maduro and the elevation of Delcy Rodríguez have brought the country into Washington's orbit, as proof that his projection of U.S. power can produce results. He touts most-favored-nation drug pricing and restricting institutional investors from buying single-family homes as measures that will lower costs for Americans. New GDP and inflation figures suggest the economy remains strong.

When asked why he remains consumed with construction projects so removed from the country's concerns, Trump offers a rationale: "The White House is a very special symbol. It's a symbol of America. It's a symbol of our greatness." He speaks of his building projects in the language of legacy—monuments meant to endure long after he is gone. But while Trump obsesses over stonework and fixtures, gold and glass, the more important parts of his legacy are being built too—in the decisions he makes from inside these walls, and the consequences unfolding far beyond them.

In late April, the President summoned Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and a retinue of military and national security officials to the Oval Office. By Trump's own timeline, the war with Iran was supposed to be over already, with a new regime in place and a nuclear program throttled. But the Islamic Republic had proved resilient and resourceful, choking off oil through the Strait of Hormuz and sending tremors through the global economy.

Now there was another problem. Trump had learned from a New York *Times* report that the U.S. military was running low on certain munitions after firing more than 1,200 Patriot missile interceptors. To replenish the losses, the Pentagon was drawing on assets

stationed in Asia and Europe, potentially weakening American defenses in other theaters. “What the f-ck is this?” Trump said to Hegseth, according to two officials familiar with the exchange, handing him a printout of the story.

According to those officials, Hegseth borrowed one of Trump’s favorite terms of derision, telling the President it was “fake news.” The Secretary of Defense insisted that the reporters had taken the facts out of context and exaggerated them to make the Administration look bad. But the reporting emerged from an official DOD inspector general’s assessment. (A spokesperson for Hegseth denied the exchange.)

Trump’s frustration went beyond munition stores. The war was polling miserably. At the time, 13 U.S. service members had been killed and nearly 400 wounded. (Those numbers would increase to 19 killed and more than 800 wounded by the end of September.) Gasoline prices had risen more than 40% since the opening attacks on Feb. 28. The conflict had already cost more than $25 billion, and the consequences were beginning to bleed into the midterm campaign. The President found himself without an exit ramp. That dynamic appears to hold true: Instead of concluding the war, Trump tells TIME, he may ramp up the bombing after the midterms if they can’t reach a satisfactory deal. “Because by annihilating Iran, we’ve created peace in the world,” he says. “With Iran, I don’t think you could ever have peace.”

Arleigh Burke-class guided-missile destroyer USS Spruance fires a Tomahawk Land Attack Missile in support of Operation Epic Fury, at an undisclosed location, Feb. 28, 2026.U.S. Navy—Handout/Reuters

A view of the Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps Navy warship struck by a U.S. missile, off the coast of Bandar Abbas, Iran, on Sept. 9, 2026.Fatemeh Bahrami—Anadolu/Getty Images

In recent months, Trump's relationship with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has grown more acrimonious, according to a senior Administration official. Netanyahu urged Trump toward war with Tehran but has since complicated Trump's efforts to end it, including by striking Hezbollah targets in Lebanon after Trump told him not to, multiple U.S. officials tell TIME. Trump says he does not believe reports that Netanyahu was warned by Egypt and the UAE ahead of the Oct. 7 attacks, but stops short of endorsing him for re-election as Israelis prepare to vote in late October for the first time since the worst security failure in the country's history.

Asked whether he might work better with Netanyahu's leading challenger, former military chief Gadi Eisenkot, Trump leaves the possibility open. "Well, I don't know," he says. "I don't hear bad things about him."

The decision to attack Iran was a hinge point in Trump's second term. His first year back in power had unfolded as a frenetic exercise in presidential will, a barrage of executive actions and dismantled guardrails that had largely gone according to plan. Then his second year opened with the raid on Caracas and capture of Maduro, a daring operation that reinforced Trump's conviction that audacity could succeed where caution had failed. The subsequent attack on Tehran would test the limits of that conviction—and reveal how quickly confidence born of success could lead to overreach.

A cascade of crises followed. Though Trump has dismissed the pain of rising gas prices, he concedes the war has depleted a subset of U.S. munitions. "Some forms of ammunition are a little bit lower than other forms," he says. Trump says he has struck deals with leading defense manufacturers, including Raytheon and Lockheed Martin, to replenish the arsenal and expand production. "They're building four, five, six plants," he says, citing Patriot and THAAD anti-ballistic-missile facilities. "They're building tremendous amounts of capability."

When asked what this will cost American taxpayers, Trump offers a curious metric: less, he says, than America makes in a single month from Venezuelan oil. Yet Americans have so far felt little benefit from that arrangement. Major U.S. oil companies have returned to Venezuela and begun extracting from the world's largest proven crude reserves, but gas prices remain at record highs for September. Meanwhile, Trump's tariff regime strained America's global relationships and reverberated through the economy.

Trump points to low unemployment, robust consumer spending, and a stock market at record highs as evidence that his economic program is working. By those measures, the economy has remained strong. But they coexist with a harsher reality: the cost of everyday life remains painfully high.

By summer, Trump was growing angrier with U.S. allies that had refused to come to America's aid against Iran—from the European powers and South Korea to Canada. Trump has directed much of his ire over the issue at America's neighbor to the north, according to a close aide. "He doesn't like the fact that we essentially protect them because of their proximity to our military might, and doesn't think they give us enough in return," says a Trump senior adviser. On July 20, Trump invoked a 1930 statute to impose a 50% tariff on Canadian goods. The trade war with America's second largest trading partner hit steel, aluminum, and lumber especially hard, disrupting supply chains and raising the cost of materials that went into everything from factories to new homes.

President Trump at the White House in Washington, D.C., on Sept. 28, 2026.Dan Winters for TIME

Borrowing costs were becoming their own problem. For Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, preventing a sell-off in the bond market from becoming a broader crisis was an increasingly urgent task. By late September, only 25% of Americans believed Trump's policies had improved the economy, according to a *Wall Street Journal* poll, while 60% said they had worsened it. Trump had returned to office promising cheaper energy, lower prices, and an economic boom. Instead, voters were finding the opposite. "It's not lost on any of us," a Trump adviser tells TIME. "When voters aren't happy with the economy, they tend to vote against the party in charge."

Since returning to office, Trump has marveled at AI's capabilities. He is increasingly in thrall to the tech executives courting him. In December 2025, Elon Musk returned to the Oval Office for a clandestine meeting. Trump spent hours asking Grok, Musk's AI chatbot, questions about his presidency and legacy, according to an official present. At the time, Trump was ordering missile strikes against Venezuelan boats he alleged were smuggling drugs into the U.S. He asked Grok how Venezuelans would react if the U.S. captured Maduro. According to the official present, the chatbot responded that Maduro was a repressive and deeply unpopular dictator and that many Venezuelans would likely celebrate his downfall. After Trump ordered the mission to seize Maduro, the following month, celebrations broke out in the streets. Trump, according to officials, came away thinking Grok was ingenious.

Along with his fascination with the technology came two related concerns. One was economic: that enthusiasm for AI's potential was propping up the stock market. The other was geopolitical, reinforced in conversations with industry titans such as Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang: that China could gain a decisive advantage over the U.S. if it developed more powerful AI first. Trump was committed to giving American companies the freedom to build faster than their foreign competitors. That meant embracing the unprecedented infrastructure build-out required to support the industry's computing needs. After watching a cable news segment about the backlash, Trump fired off a Truth Social post. "The only reason that communities throughout the U.S.A. should not want Data Centers is if they want to end up being backwards and poor," he wrote Aug. 31. "If they want to be successful and rich, with far lower taxes and jobs all over the place, let Data Reign."

Days later, aides showed Trump surveys from his longtime pollster, Tony Fabrizio, showing pervasive anxiety about AI: fears of lost jobs, rising costs, and technology eventually escaping human control. Fellow Republicans facing voters in November were

increasingly eager to put distance between themselves and the issue. Trump “really just didn’t seem to care,” one aide says. “He wants to do what he wants to do. He’s used to generating outrage and then watching everyone eventually crawl back to him. It’s hard to convince him to do anything at this point.”

Trump was unfazed by the burgeoning bipartisan calls for new AI regulations. “I don’t have to destroy the industry,” he says. “We’re making a lot of money with that industry. That industry is the Industrial Revolution, but bigger. It’s the internet, but much bigger.” The details don’t appear to concern him. When TIME asks about OpenAI agents’ meddling with federal government websites, Trump responds: “Who breached it? They’re not allowed to do that.”

President Trump speaks to the press after a meeting with technology executives about artificial intelligence at the White House in Washington, D.C., on Sept. 29, 2026.Kent Nishimura—AFP/Getty Images

Trump’s contribution to the debate about AI safeguards has been to announce the formation of an “AI Force,” which he now wants to rename the “SI Force”—part of his effort to rebrand artificial intelligence as “super intelligence.” Asked what the group will do, Trump responds: “It’s going to be super intelligent.” Pressed further, he explains that it will consist of industry leaders advising him on government policy. On Sept. 29, he met with AI leaders at

the White House, where the President and top executives from six leading tech companies signed a “constitution” to police themselves—a covenant of self-regulation in lieu of government oversight. An Administration official present said they left with a “no surprises if something happens” understanding between the White House and the industry.

It was an example of how Trump has surrounded himself with industry leaders, seeking their advice, favor, and political donations. A recent CNN poll found 75% of Americans viewed artificial intelligence with more fear and concern than excitement, with broad bipartisan support for greater federal oversight. But Trump waves away AI fears, placing them in a familiar catalogue of what he considers manufactured panics. “They said that our country was going to burn down because of global warming,” he says. “Then they changed the name to climate change because global warming turned out to be a hoax. Russia, Russia, Russia was a hoax.” Asked who, exactly, is perpetrating the supposed hoax of AI concern, Trump throws his hands in the air. “The whole country is based on fake stuff,” he says, “because these people have Trump derangement syndrome.”

Inside the Oval Office, Trump’s redesign is impossible to miss. There is gold everywhere, from the decorative plasterwork to the inscriptions on the ceiling and the gilded frames crowding the walls. The room is so dazzling you practically need sunglasses. Trumpian tchotchkes are scattered about: a FIFA “World Peace Prize” sits next to the Resolute Desk, where the President keeps a commendation given to his uncle during his years as an MIT professor.

At times, Trump’s train of thought was difficult to keep up with, his conversation moving in streams and eddies before circling back to familiar obsessions. He recounted conversations that sometimes sounded improbable. At one point, Trump claimed the Secret

Service had wanted to tear down the Oval Office and rebuild it, only for him to intervene. “I said, ‘My ass, you can’t build a new one. This is a special place.’”

Whatever happens in November, people close to Trump expect him to devote more of his remaining presidency to foreign affairs, as second-term Presidents often do, with particular attention to the western hemisphere, where ideologically sympathetic governments have given him opportunities to expand American influence. At home, they expect another emphasis altogether: Trump’s campaign against what he calls “lawfare” and his effort to reshape cultural institutions, including the nation’s museums, in his battle against what he calls “woke” ideology.

President Donald Trump speaks at the Republican National Committee Midterm Convention, dubbed “Trumpapalooza,” in Dallas, Texas on Sept. 9, 2026.Carrie Schreck—Redux

President Donald Trump appears on stage on the second day of the 2026 Republican National Convention at the American Airlines Center on Sept. 10, 2026 in Dallas, Texas.Kevin Dietsch—Getty Images

Looking ahead to the midterms, Trump dismisses unfavorable polls as fake and insists Republicans can prevail. “I think we’ll do OK if I campaign, and I intend to,” he says. So far, he has done little beyond a two-day midterm convention and a few fundraisers, but top advisers say the President is preparing a campaign sprint to help Republicans stave off disaster in the midterms: visiting 32 competitive districts in the next month, with the MAGA-style rallies that powered his political rise.

Inside the White House, advisers are already contemplating what a divided Washington would mean. “I think if the worst happens in the midterms, we’ll be forced to think more bipartisan,” one top official says. “I would hope that if we win, we can still do that, because for two years we’ve run a completely partisan play. When you’re looking back on your time, I don’t think that’s what you should be proud of, even if it was successful.”

Trump’s political operation boasts a $400 million war chest, but he has only recently begun opening his checkbook. Aides say he has been reluctant to spend because he wants to preserve cash for future elections as a means of keeping his grip on his party. “He wants to have as much money in his account as possible when he’s no longer able to raise the kind of money he can now,” a Trump aide told TIME this fall. “He doesn’t seem to care that much about the midterms, thinks they’re a lost cause anyway, and wants to preserve future possibilities.”

Aides are bracing for turnover after the midterms as Trump sheds officials who have frustrated him. A source close to the President says he has openly mused about firing the FBI Director Kash Patel and has expressed frustration with Hegseth. Trump says he intends to protect those who remain. When TIME asks whether he plans to issue pre-emptive pardons to aides and associates before

Democrats—or a future Administration—can pursue them, he suggests he will, offering a familiar justification: “Sleepy Joe gave pardons to everybody.”

As the conversation moves between war and peace, his own grip on power, and the possibility of impeachment, Trump keeps returning to the trappings of the office. He asks Natalie Harp, his ever present aide, to bring in photographs of earlier White House construction projects, including renovations from the 1930s and the Truman-era reconstruction. He studies the pictures as evidence for his case, lamenting the judges and injunctions now complicating his own efforts. Holding up a photograph of work being performed on the State Dining Room in 1950, Trump complains about a judge he says accused him of destroying the White House. “It’s the sh-t I have to go through,” he says.

Toward the end of our interview, I ask what he will miss most when his presidency is over. This time there is no digression, no grievance, no story. Trump does not need a moment to think: “This beautiful room.”

—*With reporting by* Leslie Dickstein, Simmone Shah, and Olivia B. Waxman

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/01/donald-trump-2026-interview/

Politics | Congress

How James Talarico Made Texas Competitive Again

Photograph by Brenda Bazán for TIME

James Talarico has been speaking for 12 minutes and he still hasn't mentioned Ken Paxton. He's name-checked Jeff Bezos and Mark Zuckerberg. He's called out Texas resident Elon Musk—not for pledging millions to keep Talarico from representing him in Washington, but for becoming the world's first trillionaire. He's taken shots at oligarchs, tax loopholes, and A.I. data centers. Jeffrey Epstein is mentioned, as is Jimmy Kimmel, whose

interview with this fresh-faced idealist was not allowed to air on ABC's airwaves.

Finally, with about three minutes left, Talarico lands on his Republican rival in arguably the fiercest Senate race in the country. “Listen, even the most advanced A.I. couldn't come up with Ken Paxton's actual scandals,” he says, drawing chuckles and cheers from the rapt audience in a church hall across from Texas Southern University, a historically Black university. “I don't need to use A.I. and deep fakes. The truth about Ken Paxton is bad enough.”

Talarico knows this is not true. His opponent’s scandals actually aren’t enough—not in Texas, where Paxton, the state attorney general, remains a political force even after a grand jury indicted him, his fellow Republicans in the Texas House impeached him, and his own staffers reported him to the FBI. Texas is where Republicans have maintained an almost three-decade lock on political power; the last Democrat to win statewide did so in 1994. For Talarico to break that epic losing streak, he knows he can’t just hammer his opponent and energize hardcore Democrats. He needs to build a broader coalition than any other Senate candidate in the country. He needs to convince millions of Texans that not only this year is different, but that he’s different.

“I want people to vote for something, not against something,” Talarico, 37, tells TIME after his Sept. 13 event. “Obviously, Ken Paxton's career of corruption is alarming to most Texans, but it's not enough just to have people showing up to vote against a bad alternative. I want people to feel excited about my vision and my values and what we're going to do together.”

With a mix of matter-of-fact earnestness and youthful idealism, Talarico is potentially doing something bigger than winning a Senate seat in a state where Democrats forgot how to win; he is nimbly blending the competing versions of the Democratic identity. Here is a seminarian who preaches a progressive message, a

pragmatist who found ways to pass bills in a Republican-controlled Legislature, a sharp-tongued brawler who can smoothly veer from dunking on his opponent to celebrating the value of decency. All this, while also being one of the best fundraisers of the midterms, thanks in no small measure to his ability to tap into voters' raw frustrations.

"We are all getting screwed," he tells the galvanized crowd at Wheeler Avenue Baptist Church. "Whether you are a little more conservative or a little more progressive, whether you're Black, white, brown, we are all getting screwed."

Democratic leaders across the country are watching closely. After years of party leaders fumbling to articulate what they believe in the post-Obama era, Talarico, if he pulls this off, could give Democrats a national blueprint for 2028, or at least a clue about next steps.

Talarico greets two supporters at the Wheeler Avenue Baptist Church in Houston on Sept. 13, 2026.Photograph by Brenda Bazán for TIME

That's not to say his path to victory is wide open. Despite commanding the airwaves for months, his lead in almost every reputable polls is within the margin of error. And his money advantage has evaporated. After enjoying a 7-to-1 spending

imbalance against Paxton and his allies between June and August, a super PAC tied to Senate Republican leadership is pouring more than $100 million in ads to boost Paxton in what is shaping up to be the most expensive Senate seat in U.S. history. This week, the super PAC linked to Senate Democrats stepped up with millions in digital ads, but the imbalance for the final stretch is still set to favor Republicans by a 5-to-1 margin. Talarico has also struggled to shake the persistent narrative that his support from Black voters is weak after a personal and ugly primary fight against Rep. Jasmine Crockett, who is Black.

Talarico appears to recognize the coalition he's been building still might not be big enough to win Texas. He's softened or reversed past positions that have drawn Republican fire, including his defense of trans athletes. He's put significant resources into ramping up his outreach to Black voters, rolling out policy proposals on maternal healthcare and student loans with that audience in mind. And amid efforts to lump him in with the rise of democratic socialists in other parts of the country, he's reworked his talking points on capitalism.

"I think Democrats should reclaim the principles of capitalism," he tells me. "I'm fighting for old-school capitalism. A capitalism that cares about people, the kind of capitalism we had in the middle of the 20th century, when we built the strongest middle class in the world. When corporations felt a responsibility to their workers and their community. That's the kind of capitalism we have to get back to."

Is all that enough for Talarico to build a tent as big as Texas? Republicans' main attack lines—false allegations that he's vegan, innuendo that he's gay, a Trumpist nickname of "Talafreako"—have largely fallen flat. Still, even the most optimistic of his backers keep reminding themselves what state they're in.

“Things are trending in the right direction, but it’s still Texas,” says Yasmin Radjy, a Democratic strategist with Swing Left, which is mobilizing voters on behalf of Talarico. “There’s been so much hope that’s been built up over so many years and it’s been shattered so many times.”

James Talarico greets supporters at the Wheeler Avenue Baptist Church in Houston on September 13, 2026.Photograph by Brenda Bazán for TIME

On July 4th—the 250th anniversary of America’s independence—Senate candidates in other states were marching in parades, waving miniature Stars and Stripes, and brandishing sparklers. The splitscreen offered by the contenders from Texas left even diehard Republicans groaning. Talarico was in Austin, attending the annual barbecue and concert of Texas patron saint Willie Nelson. Paxton was spotted on vacation in London with a woman who is not his wife.

It was the most striking example of the markedly distinct campaigns being run by the two men. Talarico goes for breakfast tacos with former President Barack Obama. Paxton grimaces through two nights of Trump’s bizarre midterm political convention in Dallas. Talarico laces his campaign speeches with scripture. Paxton punctuates his with MAGA-targeted trolling. Talarico is a

likable foil on the podcast—and manosphere—circuit. Paxton is more often seen on Fox News.

The contrast is clear: Talarico is chasing a big tent. Paxton is building a bunker.

Paxton essentially steamrolled his way to the GOP nomination, over the objections of the party's leaders in Washington and Texas who wanted to stick with incumbent John Cornyn. Trump declined to endorse either in the first round of voting, which was interpreted by many in the state as a tacit endorsement of Paxton. A week ahead of a runoff in May, Trump formally endorsed Paxton, who was already leading Cornyn in most polls. Ever since, support for Paxton from much of the party's old guard has been grudging at best. Many seem to struggle to find anything nice to say about him. Earlier this month in Dallas, Cornyn and former President George W. Bush gathered some of the party's biggest donors to raise cash for several Senate candidates. Even though it was held in his own backyard, Paxton was not on the guest list or among the beneficiaries.

Even Trump can't help but mock Paxton as he encourages people to vote for him. "You might not love his look. You might not love his television interview," Trump said at this month's GOP convention in Dallas. "But he was the best attorney general in the country, perhaps. He was one of the best in the entire country. And that speaks a lot louder than the suit he's wearing that doesn't look so great."

Virtually every poll shows the headwinds are against Republicans, but GOP strategists note a similar scenario faced the party in 2018 when Sen. Ted Cruz defeated another Democratic darling, Beto O'Rourke. "This is Texas, not Pennsylvania," says one Republican strategist who worked for Cornyn.

Yet most political observers in the state agree that talk of Talarico's chances would likely be far more muted if Cornyn had ended up the nominee. "I don't think that being an exceptional talent is enough in Texas," says Jess McIntosh, a Democratic strategist. "But he's running against an exceptionally corrupt candidate."

In 2015, Paxton, while state attorney general, was indicted on felony securities fraud for allegedly scamming people to join a startup without disclosing he received a commission. Nine years later, he agreed to pay nearly $300,000 in restitution and complete community service in exchange for the special prosecutors dropping the charges. Paxton did not have to admit guilt and was re-elected twice to the AG role while fighting the case. All the noise, he successfully argued to voters, was a political hit job.

And in 2020, eight of his lieutenants in the Texas AG's office accused him of bribery and abuse of office to upgrade a home of his mistress. The Republican-led Texas state House impeached him but the state Senate acquitted him. He and his wife, a state senator, are in the midst of finalizing a divorce, which she has said she filed "on biblical grounds."

Ken Paxton, the Texas attorney general, center, and Sen. Ted Cruz, greet supporters during a campaign rally at Glorious Way Church in Houston, on Sept. 21, 2026.Brett Coomer—Houston Chronicle via Getty Images

Talarico, by contrast, is downright bland. A high school debater and amateur Danny Zuko in *Grease,* he led a statewide campaign against tuition hikes while an undergrad at the University of Texas at Austin. He then joined Teach For America, which had him teaching sixth graders from one of the poorest zip codes in San Antonio. “My students weren't just kids, they were survivors. They were fighters,” he says. Two years later, Talarico signed-on with an education non-profit and earned a master's degree from Harvard. In 2018, he ran for state legislature and was its youngest member that session at age 29. Even in the political minority, 16 bills he wrote became law.

In his personal life, he followed in his grandfather’s footsteps and joined the seminary, where he is still completing those studies. Most Sunday mornings, he is somewhere in Texas guest preaching as he makes the case for his campaign.

Talarico says he is ready to work with Republicans in Washington to advance a mutual agenda, including his first proposed bill tackling corruption by banning super PACs, gerrymandering, and members of Congress from trading stocks. “That's exactly what I did in the state legislature. I worked in a Republican-dominated body, very conservative colleagues, and I built real relationships with those Republican lawmakers,” Talarico tells me. “If I can do it in the trenches of the Texas legislature, I can do it with Ted Cruz in Washington, D.C.”

Republicans have focused their attacks on Talarico’s past, much of it around his positions on transgender issues. As a state lawmaker, he voted against restrictions targeting transgender student-athletes and opposed a ban on gender-affirming transition healthcare for minors. He also said during a committee hearing in 2021 that "modern science obviously recognizes that there are many more than two biological sexes. In fact, there are six, which honestly... surprised me, too."

Talarico has since partially walked back both of those stances, calling some of his past comments “cringy” and telling all who ask that he missed the mark. “I will oppose trans athletes playing in girls’ sports if it risks safety or fairness,” he recently said on Fox News. He has also softened his criticism of polluting energy sources, insisting he is a believer in an all-of-the-above energy policy.

Paxton isn’t about to give him a pass. In one digital ad, Paxton calls Talarico “too weird for Texas” and splices his rival’s answer about his favorite Texas drag queen—Alyssa Edwards—with clips from Edwards’ performances. At an event with Cruz last week at Glorious Way Church in Cypress, Paxton dug in on the strategy, suggesting he viewed the transgender issue as among the most important in the race: “Protecting kids is not a culture war; it's our job description. In Texas, parents raise children—not the government, not a doctor.”

A supporter cheers during Talarico’s speech at a rally at the Wheeler Avenue Baptist Church in Houston, on Sept. 13, 2026.Photograph by Brenda Bazán for TIME

As Talarico tries to expand his coalition in Texas, he's also working to shore up support among a pivotal part of his base: Black voters.

It is almost impossible for a Democrat to win the state without turning out that bloc. It's why Talarico's team had planned multiple events earlier this month at or near Texas Southern University, one of the country's largest historically Black universities.

A back-to-school rally in a sparkling, renovated community center in Houston's Emancipation Park was replete with a DJ, facepainting for kids, and food. Yet only a few dozen people were milling about at an event that could have hosted hundreds. Soon, word spread that even Talarico would be a no-show because of a scheduling conflict. (As attendees put the pieces together, a Democratic strategist not working on his campaign joked: "I get it. If the room's empty, they don't come.")

It was all very much at odds with Talarico's brand as the tireless campaigner packing rooms and constantly hustling to reach every Texan. The campaign plays more than a bit faintly here in Harris County, home to the biggest Black population of any county in the United States. Talarico's primary against Crockett, a firebrand U.S. House member, turned into a heated battle between two rising stars. Many of Crockett's supporters viewed the contest as racially charged, and felt some Talarico backers were implying that only a white man could possibly break Democrats' statewide drought in Texas. When one podcaster suggested donations to Crockett were wasted money, the backlash briefly consumed the race.

For some, the wounds are still raw, and Crockett's refusal to campaign with her one-time foe has been impossible to ignore. "James and Jasmine Crockett need to come together. People need to see them together," says Barry Esceme of Houston, who supported Talarico in the primary. "The Democratic Party has chosen Talarico. We need to rally."

Black Democratic strategists have been warning for years that Democrats risk losing Black voters if they take that support for granted. In Texas, they make up about 13% of the state's voters.

“As U.S. Senator, I'll represent the most number of African Americans than any other Senator,” Talarico tells me. “So this kind of outreach, this kind of investment, this kind of listening is essential—not just to win, but also to be effective in the job.”

Talarico’s advisers argue they are in better shape than many realize, pointing to polling that shows him running better than Beto O’Rourke did with Black voters at roughly the same point in the 2018 cycle. O’Rourke had 49% support of Black voters in the late summer edition of that 2018 poll. A TSU poll from this August found 67% of Black voters supporting Talarico.

But the sparsely attended event where Talarico ultimately didn’t show suggests he still has work to do. Things go more according to plan the next evening at Wheeler Avenue Baptist, where a filled hall is vibing as a DJ spins crowd favorites. Tables of boxed fried chicken from a beloved local chain, Frenchy’s, are popular draws, as is the campaign merchandise. And while the 12,000-member church has a long history as a hub of Civil Rights activism, the crowd in the fellowship hall that evening is as diverse as Talarico’s idealized coalition.

Talarico supporters cheer as he enters the venue at the Wheeler Avenue Baptist Church in Houston on Sept. 13, 2026.Photograph by Brenda Bazán for TIME

There, Letitia Plummer, a candidate for Harris County Judge, introduces her ticketmate as someone whose evolution from the primary to the general election is worth celebrating. During the primary, Talarico got dinged hard for not specifically addressing policy needs of Black voters. He has since brought on a top-tier flight of advisers and consultants, met with Black leaders, and made a point of listening to their ideas. In May, he rolled out a maternal mortality health policy because, as he tells me, “Harris County, where we're standing right now, is the deadliest place to give birth for a Black woman in the whole country.” At the state party’s convention in June, he stood and took a drubbing from Black caucus members who peppered him with skepticism. The whole effort has brought hard-earned credibility. “He understands how important *our* Harris County is,” Plummer says.

It’s a point that Plummer continues to explain to me after the rally, as Talarico was taking pictures with visitors for more than an hour.

“I ran in 2018. I remember the Beto wave. This is different. This is deeper,” she tells me. “And I don’t think we’ve ever been this close. I really don’t.”

Talarico understands that luck and charisma won’t shake loose Texas Democrats’ long dry spell. It’s going to take a generational break in a status quo that is as closely associated with Texas as faith, football, and barbecue.

“We live in a country with broken politics and backwards priorities, but we can change that. We can turn that around,” Talarico says as he closes at the church near Texas Southern. “We can protect our immigrant neighbors and prosecute the Epstein class. We can make billionaires pay their fair share in taxes and ensure that every single child in this state has access to a quality public education. And we can end this disastrous war in Iran and ensure that no American goes bankrupt just because they get sick.”

They’re ambitious goals. Perhaps as big as the tent he’s trying to build in the middle of deep-red Texas.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/09/30/can-james-talarico-make-texas-competitive-again/

Sports

- **'I Think I'm the Best Player in the NBA.' The Excellence of Shai Gilgeous-Alexander**
  The OKC Thunder superstar believes he's the best player in the NBA

Sports | Basketball

'I Think I'm the Best Player in the NBA.' The Excellence of Shai Gilgeous-Alexander

00:0023:04

Narrated by TIME AI.

Shai Gilgeous-Alexander had not seen the *Onion* headline.

We are talking in the back of a black SUV, parked in front of his offseason home in the Toronto suburbs, when I mention the bit of satire that went viral during the Western Conference Finals in May. I hand him my phone and he laughs.

"Shai Gilgeous-Alexander Trying to Draw Foul While Shooting Free Throw," reads the headline, which is accompanied by an image of him flailing on the foul line. "Trying to draw a foul at the free-throw line," he says, "that would be good."

Gilgeous-Alexander, or SGA, is known for many things—winning NBA MVP two years in a row; becoming one of the only players in league history to sweep the regular-season MVP, scoring title, and Finals MVP in the same year (Kareem Abdul-Jabbar, Michael Jordan, and Shaquille O'Neal are the others); being selected four times for both the All-Star team and the All-NBA First Team; and being named the 2026 Clutch Player of the Year. But the Oklahoma City Thunder superstar who has achieved initial status—think MJ, Dr. J, or KD—has also faced backlash. Fellow players, pundits, and the NBA's chaotic online tinderbox have accused him of "flopping"—or acting as if he were hit much harder than he really

was, often falling down in the process, to goad the ref into calling a foul. The goal: get to the free-throw line for two easy points.

Photograph by Sharif Hamza for TIME

San Antonio's 7-ft. 4-in. alien talent Victor Wembanyama helped unleash this anger in December when he said, after a Spurs win over the Thunder, that he was glad to suit up for a team that practiced "pure and ethical basketball." The implication was clear: OKC is a bunch of foul merchants, with Gilgeous-Alexander, who led the NBA in free-throws-made per game for a third straight season, the top salesman. The criticism only escalated when the Thunder faced the Spurs for a spot in the Finals.

I want to gauge SGA's feelings about all the noise. Up to this point, he has seemed almost universally admired, if not beloved—perhaps

by dint of his businesslike demeanor, low-wattage Canadian upbringing, and small-market employer. Understandably, given his 30-plus-points-per-game average, 88% efficiency from the line over the past three regular seasons and playoffs combined, plethora of honors, and the $285 million contract extension he signed in July 2025, SGA is unapologetic about his approach to scoring. “Playing this game has done amazing things for my and my family’s life,” he says. “And if a narrative on social media is the worst that comes from this game for me, well, I’d take that a million times out of a million times.”

Besides, he has other priorities at the moment. Last season, Oklahoma City was on the brink of establishing a dynasty. They were the reigning NBA champions, having won a title in 2025, and had again finished with the league’s best record. Then the Spurs sent them home in that contentious seven-game series. “Awful feeling, sick to your stomach,” SGA recalls. “I tried to let it go for a little bit. Don’t obsess over it. Not yet.”

The Thunder are now the co-favorites with the Spurs—against whom they face off in the season opener on Oct. 20—to win the 2027 title, but other teams are hogging the spotlight. The New York Knicks are enjoying much of the shine after bringing the championship trophy home after a 53-year drought, and could become the first franchise in nearly a decade to repeat. Meanwhile the Philadelphia 76ers, on paper, have assembled a superteam, as LeBron James and Jaylen Brown join forces with 2023 league MVP Joel Embiid, two-time All-Star Tyrese Maxey, and VJ Edgecombe, who finished third in 2026 Rookie of the Year voting.

Gilgeous-Alexander, 28, is used to being overlooked: he’s morphed from an underhyped draft pick, and the consolation prize in a blockbuster trade, to arguably the best basketball player on earth. Through spectacularly consistent work, he has mastered basketball physics, starting and stopping and slithering his way into the lane enough to, in March, break Wilt Chamberlain’s record for most

consecutive games scoring at least 20 points (126). “One person saw this happening,” says Thunder coach Mark Daigneault, who was an assistant coach when SGA joined the team in 2019. “And it was him. That’s it. If anybody else says, ‘This is what I saw,’ then it’s revisionist history.”

SGA wants to strike that dutiful descriptor—*arguably*—from the record. “I think I’m the best player in the NBA,” he says. “I think the production that I have night in and night out is best-player-in-the-NBA production. I think the efficiency that I do it at is best-player-in-the-NBA efficiency. I think everybody picks up a basketball or a soccer ball or a football or a tennis ball to win the game, the match, whatever it is. And I’ve done my fair share of winning in these past couple years.”

SGA won his first title on June 22, 2025, when the Thunder beat the Indiana PacersJesse D. Garrabrant—NBAE/Getty Images

SGA credits his hometown of Hamilton, Ontario—“an underdog city”—for his work ethic, which is helpful considering the two-time NBA MVP didn’t make the JV team in ninth grade. Born to Vaughn Alexander, who won a high school city championship in Toronto, and Charmaine Gilgeous, who represented Antigua and Barbuda in the 400 m at the 1992 Barcelona Olympics, he and his younger brother Thomasi sampled all kinds of sports, including the

national pastime of hockey—though never on ice. “I wanted to, but I just couldn’t afford it,” he says. But by high school, SGA was all in on basketball.

So it was a “wake-up call” when he was cut from the squad. “I thought I was this player,” he says. “I learned quickly that I wasn’t.” (In an oft-told tale, Michael Jordan’s high school coach cut him from the varsity team as a sophomore, fueling his ferocious competitiveness: the man was booed when introduced at a Jordan salute in Chicago in the mid-1990s, and Jordan referenced the slight in his Hall of Fame speech. “You made a mistake, dude,” Jordan said. SGA, on the other hand, doesn’t even recall this coach’s name. “I’ll let him off the hook,” he says.)

He sprouted from 5 ft. 7 in., with big clown feet, in ninth grade to 6 ft. 2 in. at the end of 10th. But, he says, “I was wonky. I was growing with knee pains, moving slow, hard to control my body.” So SGA and his club-basketball coach Dwayne Washington, a high school math and science teacher, spent hours in the gym developing tricks to compensate for his lack of coordination: superior ballhandling, changing speeds to deceive defenders, perfecting the art of deceleration—stopping fast on a dribble, so a defender’s momentum carries him past you. He wrote down practice instructions in a marble notebook. “He is able to sustain concentration for longer periods of time than anybody I’ve seen,” says Washington. “Everything is predicated on his inner clock to slow down, focus on tasks, and problem solve.”

By the time SGA matured into his 6-ft. 6-in. frame, and became more athletic and efficient in his movements, those tricks had evolved into lethal weapons. In order to face better competition, he and his first cousin, Atlanta Hawks guard Nickeil Alexander-Walker, who grew up in Toronto, played their last two years of high school basketball together in the U.S. They led Hamilton Heights Christian Academy, in Chattanooga, Tenn., to a Christian schools

national championship. “Being able to hold your own in America is the first step to like, ‘OK, I’m on the right track,’” says SGA.

The next stop was the University of Kentucky, where he planned to do one year before entering the NBA Draft. He feels fortunate that NIL—the legal right of college athletes to cash in on their name, image, and likeness—wasn’t on the books then. Having so many options and so much money in college can sap a player’s urgency to collect a pro payday. “For me, it was so simple,” he says. “Now it’s tricky. You’re right out of high school. You don’t know anything. It’s hard to make smart business decisions. Kids have handlers, but you see it all the time: guys go down the wrong path because they’re advised by the wrong people. There’s room for error.”

At 19, after one year in college, SGA was picked 11th overall in the 2018 NBA DraftMike Lawrie—Getty Images

In the 2018 draft, the Charlotte Hornets selected SGA with the 11th overall pick, then traded him to the Los Angeles Clippers minutes later. He had a promising rookie season, scoring 10.8 points per game, and finished sixth in Rookie of the Year voting. But Gilgeous-Alexander, along with the Clippers’ third leading scorer, Danilo Gallinari, and a boatload of future first-round draft choices, was shipped to the Thunder for Paul George, who had finished third in the MVP voting that season. “You’re never as good as you

think you are, or as safe or as comfortable as you think you are," he says. "I just use it as a chip on my shoulder."

Playing with Hall of Famer Chris Paul in his first OKC season further enhanced his development. "I used to eat terrible," says Gilgeous-Alexander, who strongly believes that Canadian McDonald's is better than American McDonald's, thank you very much. "The seriousness that he approached the things outside of the game, his diet, the weight room, recovery, everything that he did ticked towards his performance. That was pretty eye-opening to me."

In March 2020, the pandemic shut down sports and SGA returned to Ontario. When he came back to OKC for pre-bubble workouts in June, he was visibly stronger. "It was COVID, everybody's on Zoom calls, staying in their pajamas all day," says Daigneault. "You're like, 'OK, maybe he's in his pajamas, but if he's in his pajamas, he's lifting.' He was not resting." On a vet-laden playoff team that earned a five seed in the loaded Western Conference, it was SGA, the sophomore, who topped the Thunder in scoring.

In Gilgeous-Alexander, the Thunder had a foundational piece. But the team would take its lumps. "We had to take a longer view to get to a more sustainable level of winning," says OKC general manager Sam Presti. The franchise lost 50 games in 2020–21 and 58 in 2021–22, before creeping back near .500, 40-42, in 2022–23. But for Presti, those years were productive: He cleared salary-cap space and used the first-round picks from the Clippers deal—plus the Thunder's own selections—to stockpile young standouts like Jalen Williams and Chet Holmgren, both drafted in 2022, and use others as trade assets. This fallow period also put the Thunder in position to better compensate their emerging stars and to add veteran role players like Isaiah Hartenstein, who joined the team in 2024.

The losing seasons never got SGA down. “I get to go out there and essentially shoot any ball that I want,” he says. “So many players don’t get this opportunity. I was so wrapped up in just playing the game that I love with that amount of responsibility that it was honestly just so fun for me that I didn’t even care.”

He was also enjoying himself off the court, establishing a reputation as one of the world’s best-dressed athletes. He showcased his fashion sense before and after Thunder games, at the Met Gala, and even on a Paris Fashion Week runway. “It’s fun to be able to play with color palettes,” says Gilgeous-Alexander, who has arrived at arenas in all-leather outfits, oversize fur coats, and various presentations of camo. “I’ve always been into arts and crafts, and it’s a way to do it through clothes.” He beat out Timothée Chalamet and A$AP Rocky for *GQ*’s Most Stylish Man of 2022, well before the Thunder became a national TV staple. “My parents always made sure that we looked presentable,” he says. “That was a nonnegotiable. Little things, whether it’s making sure your pants are seamed the right way, or the collar was flapped the right way.”

Shai, photographed in Toronto on Sept. 4, spends his offseasons in the areaPhotography by Sharif Hamza for TIME

SGA has inspired his teammates to look good too. “He’s made me spend more money, for sure,” quips Williams. The young, chic Thunder developed a unique chemistry. Gilgeous-Alexander and Holmgren sang an off-key parody of Christina Aguilera’s “What a Girl Wants” in an AT&T commercial that ran ad nauseam during March Madness and the NBA playoffs in 2024; the next year Williams joined them in a new spot, the joke being they all wore the same outfit to an event. Players also developed a tradition of crashing postgame TV interviews with Thunder sideline reporter Nick Gallo, covering him in towels and executing other hijinks as he talks to the star of the game.

SGA sets the tone. “I was shocked at how normal he is,” says Williams. “It makes it really easy for people on the team to feel like they can be themselves.” As the accolades have piled up, he’s remained committed to meshing. “If you’re a superstar in the NBA, there’s a natural gravity that pulls you outside the team,” says Daigneault. “He wants to be one of the guys as badly as he wants to be an all-time player. He’s constantly plugging himself back into the team despite the gravity that’s pulling him out.”

After each of his MVP announcements, SGA bought gifts for his teammates: Rolexes in 2025; Audemars Piguet watches, Burberry trench coats, and golf clubs in May. “These guys don’t get to have as much fun,” he says. “I don’t ever have to think about my minutes. I don’t have to think about where my shots are coming from. Essentially, we go out there, we play my game. These guys rebound, dive on loose balls, do all the dirty work. They essentially play off of me. I just think that they deserve a little bit of credit for their sacrifice.”

SGA was awarded his second straight NBA MVP trophy before a playoff game on May 18Alex Slitz—Getty Images

After the Thunder won 68 regular-season games in 2024–25 and beat their opponents by an average of 12.9 points per game, a new NBA record, they began this past season 24-1, tying the 2015–16 Golden State Warriors for the hottest start ever. But injuries

plagued them in the Western Conference Finals, as Williams and Ajay Mitchell, a second-year player who provided punch off the bench, missed key games. The 7-ft. 1-in. Holmgren had a particularly rough series: Wembanyama's production (27.3 points per game) trumped Holmgren's (10.7 points), and the Frenchman dunked on Holmgren minutes into Game 7. Holmgren finished that final game with 4 points, 4 rebounds, and no assists. Among fans and pundits, he took a beating.

But on the September day we spend together in Ontario, Gilgeous-Alexander says he was the one at fault. "The MVP of the league waited until Game 7 to have a good game," he says. (While SGA's output and efficiency did not meet his usual standard, he did shoot 50% from the field and score 30 points in OKC's Game 2 victory over San Antonio.) "I don't think it's on Chet," he says. "I carry a lot of the weight. The only way you can truly fail is if you don't learn from the moment. I know the type of guy he is. And I know what type of worker he is. He'll definitely do it."

About two weeks later, I tell Holmgren that SGA blamed himself for the defeat. "I might disagree with him," he replies. "Losing in a sh-tty fashion on the last game of the season, and f-ck-ing having that be your last game for the next three months or whatever, sucks. But he definitely checked on me. We chopped it up, trying to talk some hoops, figuring out how to use this time of the summer productively. I don't think I'm somebody who necessarily needs to be checked in on. But it speaks to his character and his willingness and awareness to do that."

Off Queen Elizabeth Way, not far from a Ford assembly plant that drives what's left of Ontario's manufacturing economy, sits the gym where Gilgeous-Alexander holes up all summer. It's an unremarkable space—from time to time, SGA says, a shot bounces off the facility's low ceiling. A half-dozen young men join him, a mix of former college players who offer some defensive resistance

and smaller guys he's known since grade school. They rebound and do some passing. "That's his circle," says Nate Mitchell, an assistant coach for the Canadian national team who works with SGA in the summers. "It doesn't get any bigger than what you see."

While most Ontarians are just waking up, SGA sweats through his workout, shooting dozens of three-pointers on the move. Over the past couple of seasons, he has upped his three-point attempts and efficiency, making him even more difficult to defend, though the long ball abandoned him in the Spurs series. "It's OK, it's OK," he says while bobbling a pass, burying the shot anyway.

He showed up at 6 a.m. this morning, but these sessions can start as early as 4:30. The week prior, Gilgeous-Alexander flew home from Nike's campus outside Portland, Ore., slept two hours, and was on the court before dawn. (He transferred from Converse, a Nike subsidiary, to the big brand in June; Nike plans to release a second edition of his signature shoe—the Shai 002—early next year. Asked what customers can expect, SGA, who counts drawing and tennis as hobbies, responds: "Sick design. Because I drew it. That's all I can give you.")

After a series of drills, he is bent over, hands on knees. "A little fatigue never hurt nobody," says Mitchell. Gilgeous-Alexander steps to his safe space, the foul line, where he's almost automatic. He makes nine in a row.

For the record, he does not practice falling. Yahoo! Sports basketball analyst Tom Haberstroh did yeoman's work last spring: he tracked more than 1,300 shots taken by top scorers SGA, Wembanyama, Jalen Brunson, James Harden, and Donovan Mitchell in the playoffs and found that, indeed, SGA hits the deck at the highest rate—on both attempts that are whistled as fouls and those that aren't. But SGA swears he's not acting. After all, he drives to the bucket more than most, so he's more likely to draw

contact. Plus, he often lands on his tush for safety. “Sometimes I’m leaning so much and fading away so much that it’s easier for me to fall than to try to stick a landing or risk landing on someone,” he says. “It’s just natural. Your body’s in a way in the air that if you try to stick the landing, it’s unnatural. If I’m this way and my knee will have to go the other way, you’re compromising your body.”

With Echo, the Doberman he has called the “swaggiest pup ever”Photography by Sharif Hamza for TIME

Even with SGA healthy, OKC is no lock to top the Western Conference. Younger players like Ajay Mitchell and Cason Wallace must keep improving. And Presti traded some battle-tested cogs this summer in order to save salary and load up on more draft picks. One of them, Lu Dort, is SGA’s running mate on the Canadian national team. He’s been going up against Gilgeous-Alexander in practice for years. “I keep telling people I’m the only one that can stop him,” says Dort, who will now play with SGA’s cousin on the Hawks. SGA sees things differently. “He’s going to stand in front of me and try to stop me from going places on the basketball court, and I’m going to go places on the basketball court,” he says. “That’s just how basketball works.”

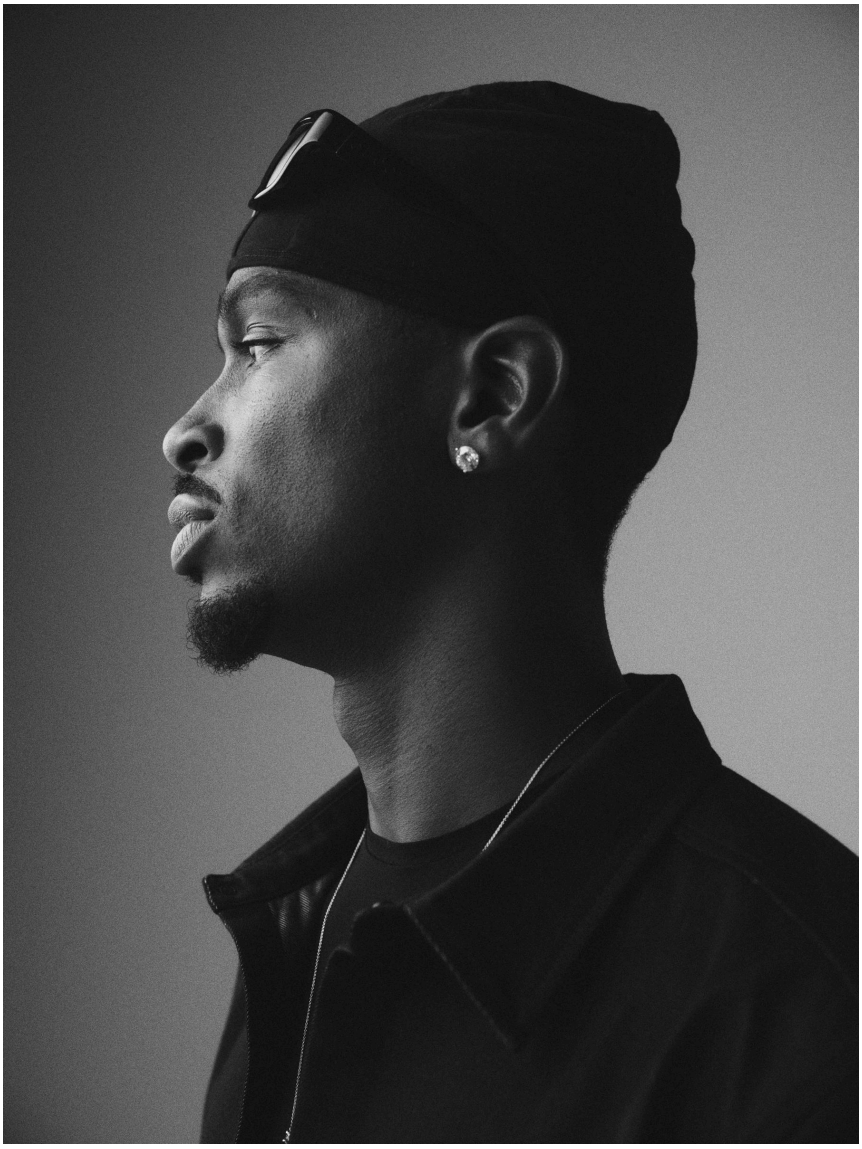
After SGA finishes his workout, he makes small talk with his team about movies—SGA has never watched a mob flick—and whether they prefer Damian Lillard or Kyrie Irving in their primes (he

pleads the fifth). He'll go back home for a lift and to hang with Ares, his 2-year-old son with his high school sweetheart and now wife Hailey Summers.

As he looks ahead to the season, SGA makes clear that he's not out for revenge. "It's hard to be in that state of mind that long," he says later in the day. "Even as a kid, I was never good when I played mad. Never, never, never, never. I just don't think you make the best decisions." Instead, he'll lean on his curious mind. He's making tactical adjustments he won't share. (Trade secrets.) He'll troubleshoot at his own pace. "I wasn't happy to lose," SGA says. "But I was like, 'OK, good, I deserved it.' It's my job to figure out why I didn't deserve to win. I attack losing."

Like many elite athletes, SGA dabbles in other pursuits. He is a part-owner of an arena in Hamilton, and according to his management team, he has also joined the ownership groups of the Spanish soccer club Atlético Madrid and the coffee brand La La Land. In September, he started a charitable foundation, and he plans on launching a media and entertainment company in early 2027. (Gilgeous-Alexander is less inclined to involve himself in politics. During the peak of the U.S.-Canada tariff war in early September, he wasn't much interested in opining on North American trade policy, though he did offer a brief comment on President Trump's attempt to make Lake America a thing. "It's obviously Lake Ontario to me," he says. "I don't have nothing more to say beyond that.")

But despite his many engagements, SGA assures fans that the Thunder come first. "I mean, you can't put your time into everything in life," he says. "I should get started sooner than later, to figure out what I'll do after [basketball]. But while I'm in it, it gets all of me."



Beyond his on-court prowess, SGA has established himself as one of the world's most stylish athletesPhotography by Sharif Hamza for TIME

Styling: Matthew Henson; Clothing: Gucci; jewelry: talent’s own; watch: Audemars Piguet; Set Design: Suzanne Campos; Grooming: Lateisha Grant; Location: Astrolab Studio.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/08/shai-gilgeous-alexander-sga-interview/

| Section menu | Main menu |

U.S.

- **Tennessee Reviews Lethal Injection Process After Botched Execution**
  Christa Pike, who has been on death row for over 30 years for murder, is the first person in the modern era of the U.S. death penalty to receive lethal injection drugs and survive.

U.S. | justice

Tennessee Reviews Lethal Injection Process After Botched Execution

Media witnesses recount the moments before the execution of Christa Pike was halted in Nashville, Tenn., on Sept. 30, 2026.George Walker IV—AP

Tennessee is reviewing its lethal injection process after a botched execution attempt left 50-year-old Christa Pike in critical condition.

Pike was receiving “lifesaving care” at a Nashville hospital on Thursday, having survived two shots of the lethal drug pentobarbital, her attorneys said in a press conference. It is the first time in the modern era of the U.S. death penalty that a person received lethal injection drugs and survived, according to the nonpartisan Death Penalty Information Center.

“This failed attempt is the worst we’ve ever seen and unlike any other botched execution in the modern era,” Robin Maher, the center’s director, said in a statement on Thursday.

Pike’s case has drawn scrutiny over the state’s decision to proceed with her execution, despite repeated warnings about its lethal

injection protocol from her attorneys, who said she was subjected to “chemical torture.”

Gov. Bill Lee, a Republican, ordered an independent investigation of the lethal injection process late on Wednesday. Lee also suspended executions in the state till the end of the year, the second moratorium on executions during his time in office due to concerns over the state’s lethal injections.

“There is no one that wanted what happened last night to happen,” Lee told reporters on Thursday, describing the botched execution as a “tragedy.” But he stopped short of suggesting that he might heed renewed calls to commute Pike’s sentence to life in prison.

“The people of Tennessee have determined that the death penalty is the appropriate penalty for the most heinous crimes in the state,” Lee said. “The people of Tennessee make that decision, and my job is to make sure then that those sentences are carried out.”

Lee had denied Pike’s clemency request to commute her sentence to life in prison without the possibility of parole on Monday.

Pike, convicted of the 1995 murder of then-19-year-old Colleen Slemmer, has been on death row for more than 30 years. She would have been the first woman executed in Tennessee in more than 200 years. Only 18 women have been executed in the U.S. since 1976, according to the Death Penalty Information Center.

The Tennessee Department of Correction said in a statement to media outlets late Wednesday that it “had followed every step of the state’s lawful, established execution protocol approved by the attorney general’s office.” It described the lethal injection as “consistently effective.”

Lee defended the agency, saying it followed protocol.

TIME has reached out to the state's Department of Correction and Pike's attorneys for comment.

"There was no reason to expect it to not work," Lee said. "But something didn't go well or right last night, and we need to find out why."

Attorneys say execution attempt amounted to 'chemical torture'

Randy Spivey, an attorney with the Tennessee Office of the Post-Conviction Defender, said Pike endured a "torturous" experience in the execution chamber. Pike's left arm was pierced by at least seven needles, and her right arm turned purple, he said. She said her arm felt like it was "about to explode," her attorneys said.

Pike's attorneys suggested that the drugs may have entered her arm tissue instead of directly into her bloodstream. They described it as "chemical torture."

Pike remained cooperative throughout the multiple execution attempts and tried to help her executioners, her attorneys said. "She over and over again said, 'Please try up on my shoulder higher. Please try here. Please try here,'" Spivey said.

"We may never know what all she was suffering through, either because she can't remember it, she can't tell it, or it overwhelms her," said Stephen Ferrell, from the Federal Defender Services of Eastern Tennessee. Pike's greatest fear was not of dying but "of a prolonged, painful, traumatic death."

"And that's what happened," Ferrell said. "Minus the death."

Witnesses to the execution said late Wednesday that Pike could still be heard breathing and snoring an hour after her executioners administered two rounds of pentobarbital, including when the

curtain closed and when witnesses were escorted out of the chamber.

Tennessee switched to a one-drug lethal injection of the barbiturate pentobarbital as its execution protocol in December 2024. Pike's lawyers previously raised concerns about the source of the drugs, while Reuters reported on Thursday that that information had been withheld. E.U. law bars pharmaceutical companies from selling drugs for use in executions, leading some U.S. prison systems to procure the drugs from compounding pharmacies in processes often shielded by state secrecy laws.

In legal filings, Pike's lawyers had raised concerns that Pike's execution by lethal injection might be compromised by her small veins and medical history of thrombocytosis. But their petitions to the state to use alternative execution methods, like death by hanging, were denied.

Pike's lawyers said in a statement that their concerns proved true: "difficult vein access, blown veins, degraded pentobarbital, no emergency medical care available when things inevitably go wrong, all under a protocol that remains veiled in secrecy."

In a June court filing, Pike's attorneys pointed to the state's failed execution of Tony Carruthers in May, when medical staff failed to find a vein. Lee granted Carruthers a one-year reprieve.

The American Medical Association and American Nurses Association prohibit doctors and nurses from participating in executions under their professional ethics standards. Some states have used execution personnel without current medical licenses. Tennessee, however, requires the participation of physicians, or other medically trained personnel in an execution.

After the botched execution of Carruthers, more than 40 doctors and nurses penned a letter to Lee, calling on him to redesign the

protocol to exclude health care workers, arguing that it is at odds with their commitment to preserve life.

Lee also paused executions and ordered an independent review in 2022 after it was discovered that prison officials failed to properly test lethal injection drugs for endotoxins in the lead-up to the planned execution of Oscar Franklin Smith. Smith was ultimately killed in May 2025, three years after Lee issued a temporary reprieve.

The review resulted in the one-drug protocol that was used on Wednesday. It also showed that officials had skipped proper endotoxin testing for multiple prior executions.

Some call for commutation, others the electric chair

Pike's attorneys have publicly called on the state's governor to reconsider commuting Pike's sentence to life in prison. Pike, who was sentenced in March 1996 at age 20, has expressed remorse for the torture and murder of her classmate. Her legal team had asked courts to review mitigating claims of sexual abuse and rape as a child, which they said Tennessee had disputed in earlier proceedings. They also separately argued that aspects of the execution process could trigger PTSD related to that abuse, constituting cruel and unusual punishment.

Hours before the scheduled execution on Wednesday, a federal appeals court issued an eleventh hour stay of execution to review the case. The state asked the Supreme Court to vacate the lower court's ruling, which it did in a 6-3 decision, allowing Tennessee officials to proceed. The Supreme Court did not explain its decision.

In her dissent alongside liberal justices Elena Kagan and Ketanji Brown Jackson, Justice Sonia Sotomayor wrote, "I see no reason to

short-circuit the ordinary process of appellate review, particularly in light of the grave consequences of an erroneous decision. Tennessee's desire to expedite Pike's execution by a few days or even weeks cannot outweigh her 'fundamental interest in [her] own life.'"

Pike's underlying case remains pending before the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Sixth Circuit.

Pike's case has also renewed calls to abolish the death penalty.

"I have always opposed the death penalty. It is irreversible and applied unequally, and it has never made Tennesseans safer," said Democratic state senator Heidi Campbell in a social media post. "But you don't have to share my view to be appalled. If the state claims the power to kill, it has a basic duty to be competent, transparent, and humane."

Campbell described the incident as a "moral catastrophe" that cost the state $500,000.

Abraham Bonowitz speaks during a March 4 Mercy protest against the death penalty at the Tennessee State Capitol in Nashville, Tenn., on Sept. 27, 2026.George Walker IV—AP

Jerri Green, the Democratic nominee to replace Lee as governor when his term ends in January, said that, if elected, she would

extend the moratorium on executions throughout her time in office.

U.N. human rights chief Volker Turk said on Thursday that “the case of Christa Pike lays bare multiple reasons why the death penalty should be abolished.” Calling for the state to stop any further attempt to execute Pike, he said, “the prolonged suffering—physical and mental—arising from multiple failed execution attempts is abhorrent and cruel.”

Tennessee is one of 27 states where the death penalty is legal, according to the Death Penalty Information Center, although governors in four states—California, Ohio, Oregon, and Pennsylvania—have halted all executions.

Others have instead said the failed execution demonstrates the need for a different, more effective execution protocol.

Sen. Marsha Blackburn (R, Tenn.), who is running for governor, called for the state to “bring back the electric chair.” Tennessee allows prisoners whose crimes occurred before 1999 to choose electrocution, although lethal injection is its primary execution method. Pike’s attorneys argued that opting for electrocution would go against her religious beliefs of not participating in her own death. They explained they had presented hanging as an alternative execution method in her challenge to lethal injection as legally required.

Cameron Sexton, Republican speaker of Tennessee’s House, said the General Assembly would investigate ways to ensure future executions do not fail, including expanding alternative methods and changing current medications to include potassium chloride.

“Justice wasn’t carried out last night due to an error,” Sexton said. “Thirty years is too long for justice.”

Slemmer’s mother, May Martinez, who had driven from Florida to Nashville to witness the execution, said Thursday that the execution process was an injustice to her family. “Here we are, 31 years, and you’re laughing in my face again,” she told First Coast News, expressing frustration that she and her husband were kept in the prison for hours and were not allowed to leave without an escort. The victim’s family had long supported Pike’s execution.

May Martinez, mother of murder victim Colleen Slemmer, walks out of Riverbend Maximum Security Institution during a stay of the planned execution of Christa Pike in Nashville, Tenn., on Sept. 30, 2026.George Walker IV—AP

Martinez said the prison gave her few answers about what would happen after the execution attempt failed, and that she disagreed with the decision to take Pike to an off-site hospital. “Now I have to worry about her being out,’” Martinez said. “And then I brought up, ‘Is she going to come back to the prison?’ ‘I don’t know what we’re doing with her yet.’ That’s the answer I got.”

‘Cruel’ punishment

While Pike appears to be the first person in the U.S. to survive lethal injection drugs, she is not the only person to have experienced botched execution attempts, nor the first whose attorneys have argued that multiple attempts could violate the Constitution.

On May 3, 1946, Louisiana officials strapped Willie Francis, a 17-year-old Black teenager convicted of murder, into the portable electric chair nicknamed “Gruesome Gertie.” But Francis survived the first jolt when the electric chair malfunctioned. Francis’s lawyer challenged the state in an attempt to stop a second execution attempt, arguing that subjecting him to a second electrocution would amount to cruel and unusual punishment and violate the Eighth Amendment. His lawyer also argued that it would amount to double jeopardy—punishing him twice for the same offence, in violation of the Fifth Amendment.

The Supreme Court, however, ruled in a 5-4 decision that a state can attempt a second execution, finding that an unintentional equipment malfunction did not violate the Constitution.

The landmark ruling has been cited in subsequent cases, including *State v. Broom* (2016), when the Ohio Supreme Court permitted another execution attempt after officials failed to establish an IV line.

Still, Pike’s lawyers are urging the governor to spare her another execution attempt after what they said caused “unnecessary agony.”

“The state of Tennessee has shown us again that they are not capable of carrying out an execution consistent with basic human dignity,” Spivey said. “Last night was not just inefficient. It was cruel, and it was torturous.”

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/02/christa-pike-botched-execution-lethal-injection-tennessee-pentobarbital/

World

- **Navanethem 'Navi' Pillay Wins the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize**
  The South African jurist has been recognized “for her efforts to promote peace and international law,” said Jørgen Watne Frydnes, chair of the Norwegian Nobel Committee.
- **Why the Trump Administration Is Being Accused of Interfering in Brazil's Election**
  Brazilians are heading to the polls in what is set to be a decisive moment for Latin America’s largest nation, but the event has been clouded by accusations that the Trump Administration is attempting to overexert its influence.

World | Nobel Peace Prize

Navanethem 'Navi' Pillay Wins the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize

Navanethem "Navi" Pillay, a South African jurist and former U.N. high commissioner for human rights, won the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize on Friday “for her efforts to promote peace and international law.”

“Pillay’s commitment to universal legal principles and her firm moral compass are constants in a long career. Born into a family of Indian Tamil origin under apartheid in Durban, South Africa, Pillay became a lawyer and legal pioneer, confronting deep structural discrimination, segregation, and exclusion,” said Jørgen Watne Frydnes, chair of the Norwegian Nobel Committee.

“A common thread runs from her early work defending Nelson Mandela and others who stood up against apartheid to her service as a judge in some of the key international court cases of our time.”

Pillay, 85, is a judge on the International Court of Justice (ICJ) in the case where Myanmar stands accused of genocide. She was also chair of the U.N. Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory that concluded last year that Israel has committed genocide in Gaza. (Israel at the time dismissed the report as "scandalous" and “fake.") Israel's Foreign Ministry criticized Pillay's win, referring to it as a "grotesque weaponization" of the award.

In "historic international court cases, she has shown that legal measures can help prevent acts of war and violence," Frydnes said, referring to Pillay as "one of the great defenders of international legal principles in our time."

Reflecting on her win, Pillay said she is often asked when she will stop working. "I can’t obviously stop my work in support of the Nuremberg Principles, because of the people we meet here," she said.

Pillay's career spans more than 50 years

Born in South Africa in 1941, Pillay was the first non-white woman to establish a legal practice in the country, according to the U.N.

In those early years of practicing law, she acted as a defense attorney for anti-apartheid activists.

Pillay has served as a judge on the High Court in South Africa, the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda, and the International Criminal Court (ICC) throughout the course of her career.

She was the U.N. human rights chief from September 2008 to August 2014. Volker Türk, who currently holds that position, said Pillay's Nobel recognition is "particularly poignant" as it comes "at a time when human rights are under attack on so many fronts, including from those who wield enormous power."

“It is an award to all those who around the world dedicate their lives to the defense of human rights, often at great risk to their security," he added.

Pillay is the fifth South African national to be awarded the Nobel Peace Prize. She follows in the footsteps of Nelson Mandela, FW de Klerk, Archbishop Desmond Tutu, and Albert Luthuli.

Pillay dedicates award to "survivors of international crimes"

Pillay dedicated her Nobel Peace Prize to “all of the survivors of international crimes” and people defending international criminal justice, “whose compassion and courage continue to ensure that impunity will not be allowed to reign.”

During a press conference at the International Nuremberg Principle Academy, in the German city where the trials of Nazi leaders showcased the enforcement of international law, Pillay referred to the award as a "wonderful surprise" and the "highest honor."

Using her platform to spotlight the international justice system, Pillay told reporters: “We are living through an era when international law and human rights are under significant political attack... This worsening reality is particularly visible with the attacks on the International Criminal Court."

She added that the Nobel recognition has strengthened her "conviction that we must stand together in defense of the rule of law, in defense of independent courts, and an international legal order based on principle."

Trump Admin announces sanctions against the ICC hours after win

When asked during a press briefing if the award sends a message to those who question or sanction international courts, Frydnes told reporters: “This is definitely a message to those who are attacking, undermin[ing] the international system, the international rules-based system, and the institutions."

U.S. President Donald Trump last month called for countries to "immediately" resign from the International Criminal Court (ICC), amid a broader push by the Trump Administration to dismantle the institution it accuses of unfairly targeting the U.S. and Israel. His call was firmly rejected by European leaders.

The Trump Administration has criticized the ICC over arrest warrants issued for Israeli leaders, including Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, and former investigations into the actions of American soldiers in Afghanistan.

Hours after Pillay's win, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced the Trump Administration is placing sweeping new sanctions on the ICC. It has previously imposed sanctions on the court's prosecutors and judges, but these new measures go a step further.

“We will ban transactions with this rogue court, cutting off their resources and crippling its ability to operate against us,” Rubio said. “The United States and the American people are not subject to the jurisdiction of this fake ICC.”

As a result of the sanctions, and "subject to applicable licenses and exceptions, all property and interests in property of the ICC that are in the United States or in possession or control of U.S. persons are blocked and must be reported to the Department of the Treasury’s Office of Foreign Assets Control," read a notice from the State Department.

Rubio claimed both Republicans and Democrats have concerns about the court overstepping its jurisdiction, but said only Trump is willing to take action. “Either the ICC will end its threats, or we will end the ICC," he warned.

In response, the ICC's deputy prosecutor Nazhat Shameem Khan condemned the sanctions and vowed the court's "work will continue across all our situations, our investigations, and our prosecution."

The Foreign Ministers of Canada, Denmark, Germany, France, Italy, Japan, the Netherlands, and the U.K. have also denounced the sanctions.

In a joint statement that expressed "unwavering support for the independence, impartiality, and integrity of the ICC," the officials said the sanctions "will have a significant impact on the [ICC's] work, its dedicated staff, and their families."

Pillay pokes fun at Trump as she reacts to award

Pillay referenced Trump and his well-documented campaign to be awarded the Nobel Peace Prize when she reacted to her own recognition on Friday morning.

In a video shared by Agnes Callamard, secretary general of Amnesty International, Pillay could be seen entering a room at Nuremberg Court to resounding applause from her peers. "If you clap a little bit more, I may share this prize with Trump," she joked.

The 2025 Nobel Peace Prize winner, Venezuelan opposition leader María Corina Machado, famously gave her medal to Trump in January as she pressed the U.S. to support democracy in Venezuela.

While the Norwegian Nobel Institute doesn't release a shortlist of its contenders each year, the leaders of Israel, Cambodia, and Pakistan have all previously said they nominated Trump. The institute registered a total of 287 candidates for this year's prize, including 208 individuals and 79 organizations.

Trump said earlier this week it would be a "great discredit" to the Norwegian Nobel Committee if they did not announce him as this year's recipient.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/09/navanethem-navi-pillay-wins-the-2026-nobel-peace-prize/

World | brazil

Why the Trump Administration Is Being Accused of Interfering in Brazil's Election

Brazil's President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva and U.S. President Donald Trump are seen in this combination of pictures created on Dec. 2, 2025.Pablo Porciuncula, Andrew Caballero-Reynolds—Getty Images

President Donald Trump on Thursday said he is following the upcoming Brazilian election “very closely,” referring to Brazil as a “very important" country. "The people of Brazil are fantastic people,” he told reporters outside the White House. “It’s a very important election.”

The U.S. State Department later announced the suspension of its consular services in Brazil ahead of the election taking place on Sunday, citing unspecified security concerns. “U.S. citizens seeking emergency assistance during this time should not come to the Embassy, the Consulates, or other U.S. diplomatic facilities,” the security alert advised.

Brazilians are heading to the polls for a set of federal elections spanning congressional and gubernatorial races, alongside the first

round of the presidential election votes. It's set to be a decisive moment for Latin America's largest nation, as the region has seen a shift toward the right in recent years. An Oct. 25 runoff is expected, as polls show a tight contest between leftist President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva and far-right Sen. Flávio Bolsonaro, the son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, who was convicted last year for plotting a coup to overturn his 2022 election loss. Trump led the conservative voices denouncing the conviction, referring to the trial as a "witch hunt."

While Trump has acknowledged his active interest as Brazil votes on its political future, there are concerns he could be too involved. Trump and his Administration have been accused of attempting to interfere with the high-stakes overseas election.

In a letter sent to Secretary of State Marco Rubio in late September, Democratic lawmakers expressed "grave concern" over what they referred to as "the Administration's coordinated effort to threaten our strategic alliance with Brazil and undermine the Western Hemisphere's second-largest democracy ahead of its upcoming presidential election."

"Over the course of President Trump's second term, we have seen U.S. officials engage in a sustained, multifaceted campaign of interference and destabilization in Brazil," the lawmakers said in the Sept. 24 letter, signed by 30 House Democrats and Independent Sen. Bernie Sanders of Vermont, who caucuses with the Democratic Party.

In another letter sent to Rubio on Monday, three Democratic Senators voiced similar concerns about potential U.S. interference.

"This effort first escalated sharply during the summer of 2025, with the [U.S.] Administration deploying tariffs and targeted sanctions to attempt to shape the Brazilian Supreme Court's verdict in the trial of former President Jair Bolsonaro on charges of attempting to

foment a military coup to stay in power," said the Senators, noting that the tariff pressure escalated in July this year when the Trump Administration moved to impose a new 25% tariff on many imports from Brazil—a decision labeled a "lamentable milestone" by Lula's office.

The Senators argued that the "campaign directed at Brazil's authorities resumed with the appointment of Darren Beattie as a senior advisor on Brazil issues in the State Department." Beattie served as a White House speech writer in Trump's first term, but was axed for attending a gathering of white supremacists. He returned to the fold early on in Trump's second term. When serving as undersecretary for public diplomacy and public affairs last year, he called one of Brazil's Supreme Court Judges a "key architect of the censorship and persecution complex directed against Bolsonaro and his supporters."

Accusing the Trump Administration of using "diplomatic, economic, and political pressure in ways that risk weakening [Brazil's] democratic institutions [and] undermining confidence in Brazil's electoral process," the Senators closed the letter by asking the Administration to "commit to recognizing the certified outcome of Brazil's 2026 democratic elections."

The White House has staunchly rejected claims of interference in Brazil's elections.

"Conservative leaders are winning elections across the Western Hemisphere on their own merit because everyone sees the success of President Trump's policies," said White House spokesperson Anna Kelly in a statement to TIME. "These claims are nonsense."

President Lula has also expressed concern over Trump's interest in his country's election. "I have already told President Trump it is very important that the U.S. do not interfere in Brazil's elections," he said in a Sept. 22 interview. "Brazilian elections are the concern

of the Brazilian people. American elections are the concern of the American people."

Lula added that he is "very worried about Marco Rubio," claiming that the U.S. Secretary of State "is very closely connected to Bolsonaro's people," though he stressed that this was only "suspicion." TIME has reached out to the State Department for comment.

How the Trump Administration has been accused of meddling in Brazil's affairs

Trump has not formally endorsed either candidate in Brazil's presidential race, but his defense of former Brazilian President Bolsonaro, who was last year sentenced to 27 years in prison, is well documented.

After Trump criticized the trial proceedings as a "terrible thing" in July 2025, the Trump Administration increased pressure on Brazil's government by imposing punishing 50% tariffs— extended in part due to Bolsonaro's treatment in the courts—and directing the office of the U.S. Trade Representative (USTR) to investigate trade relations with the country.

The State Department added to the pressure later that same month, when Rubio called Supreme Court Justice Alexandre de Moraes' actions a "political witch hunt against Jair Bolsonaro" and announced visa restrictions on Moraes, unspecified judicial allies, and their immediate families.

Feliciano de Sá Guimarães, an associate professor at the Institute of International Relations at the University of São Paulo, says Lula was able to turn the economic pressure into a political argument of his own.

“Lula realized that he could play [these threats] in his favor for electoral purposes,” he says, explaining that Lula used the concept of “rally round the flag,” meaning that once a country is targeted by another, “the incumbent President can rally the people and say, ‘look our sovereignty is under attack.’”

The theme of sovereignty has featured prominently in Lula’s 2026 government manifesto, which points to Trump’s tariffs as damaging the Brazilian economy.

Guimarães says the U.S. Administration has since slightly altered its strategy, favoring an approach that could instead benefit Lula’s opposition.

Flávio Bolsonaro met with Trump, Rubio, and Vice President J.D. Vance at the White House in May. Trump later described the Brazilian lawmaker as a “smart young man, who loves his country very much.” Shortly after that meeting, the U.S. Administration on May 28 designated Primeiro Comando da Capital and Comando Vermelho—two Brazilian gangs—as terrorist organizations, with Bolsonaro appearing to take credit for the move in the media.

Guimarães says the issue may have resonated in Brazil due to public concerns about crime.

“Brazilians are so desperate with the situation of crime in the country that they are resorting to support any initiative, whether it's coming from the federal government or a foreign power to fix the problem,” Guimarães explains, so the move could be seen to strengthen Bolsonaro’s chances with the electorate.

Economic pressure has continued as well. After ordering the USTR to investigate Brazil’s trade practices last year, the office imposed 25% tariffs on the country in July under Section 301, for what it described as unfair trade practices.

Other disputes have further heightened diplomatic tensions. At the end of July, Brazil denied visas to two U.S. State Department officials, accusing them of trying to interfere in the upcoming election. Shortly afterward, Brazilian Ambassador Maria Luiza Ribeiro Viotti had her U.S. visa revoked.

Is the Trump Administration influencing Latin America's rightward-turn?

Since returning to office, Trump has sought to exert U.S. influence more directly across Latin America.

In November 2025, the Trump Administration released its National Security Strategy, which highlighted a return to U.S. dominance in the Western Hemisphere and the beginning of the implementation of the "Donroe Doctrine," an informal term for Trump's reinterpretation of the 19th-century Monroe Doctrine.

"The corollary of the 'Donroe Doctrine' is trying to stop the influence of extra regional powers in Latin America, mainly China," says Guimarães.

Trump has also showcased his support for right-wing candidates across the region.

In 2025, he endorsed close ally Javier Milei in Argentina's midterm elections and supported Tito Asfura to become the next President of Honduras.

In June, he gave his "complete and total endorsement" to right-wing challenger Abelardo de la Espriella in Colombia's presidential election. (The Trump-backed populist went on to win the race.)

In response to Trump's endorsement, House Democrats had sent a letter to Rubio expressing concern over what they said was "the brazen interference of senior U.S. officials, including President

Trump” in Colombia’s election. “This interference involves the full-throated endorsement of Abelardo de la Espriella, a candidate with a profoundly troubling record that appears to run counter to U.S. interests and potentially to U.S. laws,” the lawmakers said.

But perhaps one of the most significant displays of American power came when the U.S. military captured Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro and his wife during an overnight operation in January and brought them to New York to face narco-terrorism and drug trafficking charges.

Delcy Rodríguez, Venezuela’s acting president, has since adopted a friendlier posture toward the U.S. Administration, enabling access to the country’s oil. In an interview with TIME conducted in late September, Trump heralded the operation in Venezuela as an “incredible” feat and one of the “great things” he’s achieved in his presidency.

“The main reason the [U.S. Administration] will always prefer a right-winger more aligned with the United States, is so they can sell to domestic audiences that, at least in Latin America, Trump's policy is to some extent an effective foreign policy,” Guimarães says.

The State Department under Rubio’s direction has been key in the Trump Administration’s approach to Brazil, Guimarães says.

He cites the creation of the Shield of Americas, a U.S.-led security and political coalition launched in March to fight drug cartels and transnational crime across the Western Hemisphere, as an example. Brazil has not joined the initiative.

Guimarães calls it an “initiative launched by Rubio who wants to bring all Latin American countries under the yoke of the United States to fight organized crime,” and argues that Lula’s resistance could fuel Rubio’s interest in seeing a right-wing government take

power, as Bolsonaro has promised to integrate Brazil into the security initiative if he wins the presidential election.

---

https://time.com/article/2026/10/01/trump-brazil-election-interference-accusations-lula-bolsonaro-tensions/